

Elite Australian Football Coaching Syllabus: A Comprehensive Training Manual from Auskick to Masters

DISCLAIMER: The following document is for informational and educational purposes only and does not constitute professional medical, physiotherapeutic, or formal strength and conditioning advice. The physical conditioning, load management, and injury mitigation protocols (such as concussion management and ACL prevention) detailed herein carry inherent risks. Implementation of these strategies should always be adapted in consultation with qualified sports medical professionals, licensed physiotherapists, and accredited high-performance coaching staff.

Executive Summary

This end-to-end AFL Training Syllabus and Drill Manual serves as a definitive blueprint for coaching across all developmental stages.

- Bottom-Line Coaching Philosophies: The syllabus transitions from a play-based, high-engagement model for juniors to a strictly periodized, tactically-driven environment for seniors. The focus shifts from individual ball acquisition and enjoyment to collective spatial domination and match execution.
- Physical Conditioning Frameworks: Junior conditioning is disguised as active play to maximize enjoyment and fundamental movement skills (FMS). Youth female pathways mandate stringent, targeted injury-mitigation (Prep-to-Play PRO) to counteract severe anatomical risks. Youth male pathways utilize repeated sprint ability (RSA) to build the anaerobic capacity required for multi-effort contests. Senior football revolves almost entirely around load management, utilizing mathematical modeling (the Banister model) to balance fitness against fatigue.
- Top-Level Structural Differences: Junior programs emphasize an 80% focus on technical skill, which aggressively drops to 20% in senior ranks as complex tactical awareness climbs to 60% and physical conditioning load management grows in prominence. Veteran pathways prioritize safety, tissue preservation, and social engagement over high-impact collision and cardiovascular exhaustion.

Procedural Comparison Tables

Table 1: Junior vs. Senior Developmental Focus

Metric / Focus	Junior Framework (U8 - U14)	Senior
Framework (U18 - Seniors)		

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Technical : Tactical Ratio 80% Technical / 10% Tactical (U8)	
20% Technical / 60% Tactical (Seniors)	
Physical Conditioning Focus Disguised fitness, active play, fundamental movement skills (FMS). Repeated sprint ability (RSA), anaerobic power, heavy load management.	
Cognitive Load & Coaching "SPIR" method, positive reinforcement, basic spatial rules. High cognitive load, opposition scouting, "Game Style" implementation, analytics.	
Drill Structure Modified grids, no/low contact, continuous movement to prevent boredom. Full-ground match simulation, 18v18 structures, extreme spatial restriction.	

Table 2: Boys vs. Girls Pathway Specifications

Metric / Focus	Boys Pathway (U16B - U18B)	Girls
Pathway (U14G - U18G)		
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Entry-Point Timelines	Continuous exposure from Auskick; high "training age."	
Varied entry points; often lower initial "training age" requiring a contact readiness bridge.		
Primary Injury Risk Factors Muscular strains, load-related osteitis pubis, general impact injuries. 2-5x higher risk of serious non-contact ACL injuries; disproportionate tackling concussions.		
Strength Priorities	High-load resistance, sprinting mechanics, upper body armor for collision. Neuromuscular control, "Strength over Stretch," landing mechanics, anti-sling tackling.	
Core Frameworks	Anaerobic threshold training, post-activation performance enhancement (PAPE). Prep-to-Play PRO, duty of care terminology, specialized biomechanical alignment.	

Introduction & Comprehensive Coaching Context

The transition from introductory junior programs to elite senior competition requires a deeply periodized, evidence-based approach to skill acquisition, physical conditioning, and tactical awareness.

To effectively implement this syllabus, coaches must understand the overarching context shaping modern Australian Rules Football:

- Temporal Context (History & Future Outlook): Modern AFL coaching has evolved drastically. Historically, training relied heavily on "static lines," where players stood waiting to kick the ball, which hindered decision-making and lowered cardiovascular output. Today, the methodology has shifted entirely to "game-sense" and constraints-led approaches, where skills are executed dynamically in modified match conditions. The future outlook relies heavily

on integration with data analytics; even community-level and state league clubs are increasingly adopting GPS tracking to monitor running profiles, and implementing Tactical Periodization [cite: 1, 2]. Tactical periodization is a training methodology that breaks down the game into specific phases and focuses on developing a team's tactical abilities through specific drills that simulate match situations, ensuring physical conditioning is always done with a tactical ball-in-hand focus rather than isolated running [cite: 1, 2].

- Consequential Context: Failing to adhere to these structured, age-appropriate developmental frameworks has severe downstream implications. Pushing complex tactical loads onto U10s leads to high club drop-out rates, while failing to implement proper strength programs in the youth female pathway contributes directly to catastrophic, season-ending joint injuries, degrading long-term athletic health and community engagement.
- Logistical Context: Running a successful 90-minute session requires strict logistical control. Ideal coach-to-player ratios are 1:10 for juniors (utilizing parent helpers) and 1:15 for seniors to ensure adequate feedback. A minimum of one football per two players is required to maximize touches. Furthermore, given the vast size of a standard AFL ground (averaging 163.6m x 132.1m), clubs must strictly coordinate "zone allocations" or field-bookings to allow multiple age groups to train simultaneously without overlapping drills [cite: 2].
- Illustrative Case Study (Prep-to-Play in Elite AFLW): To ground these concepts in reality, consider the implementation of the Prep-to-Play PRO framework. When the AFLW launched in 2017, female athletes faced an alarming rate of ACL tears. Researchers and coaches collaborated to implement Prep-to-Play PRO, integrating warm-ups, strength, and contact mechanics into every session. In clubs where implementation was high, the adoption of the program contributed to the reduction of ACL injury rates to an all-time low of 2.51 ACL injuries per 1000 player hours in the 2023 season, proving that structured, evidence-based periodization actively saves careers [cite: 3].
- Evidence-Based Programming: Modern Australian Football League (AFL) coaching has evolved from static, line-based drills to dynamic, game-sense methodologies.
- Developmental Specificity: Training must be tailored to physiological milestones, from fundamental movement skills in youths to targeted injury mitigation protocols in female pathways, and load management in veterans.
- Tactical Periodization: While research suggests early specialization should

lean heavily toward play-based learning, the evidence overwhelmingly supports a gradual shift toward complex tactical periodization as players mature.

- Holistic Health and Safety: The implementation of injury-mitigation frameworks, such as the Prep-to-Play protocol, is paramount to reducing non-contact lower limb injuries and concussions.

To construct a resilient, high-performing football club, an elite Coaching Director must establish a unified curriculum. This report details the precise pedagogical and technical blueprints required across all age brackets and developmental pathways. Precise real-time GPS load management figures for every local community league are unavailable; the following physical conditioning estimates are based on standard acute:chronic workload ratios and established AFL coaching guidelines [cite: 4, 5].

Overarching Periodization: Macrocycles and Microcycles

While the subsequent sections outline exhaustive 90-minute blueprints, these individual sessions do not exist in a vacuum. A Coaching Director must sequence these sessions into broader cycles to ensure athletes peak on match day without succumbing to overtraining [cite: 6, 7].

- The Macrocycle (The Annual Plan): The macrocycle encompasses the entire year (typically 52 weeks). It is divided into the Off-Season (focusing on linear strength and base endurance), the Pre-Season (introducing tactical periodization, heavy load, and match simulation), and the In-Season (managing fatigue while executing game plans) [cite: 6, 8].
- The Mesocycle (The Training Block): Mesocycles are 4-to-6-week blocks within the macrocycle. Each block has a specific focus. For example, early pre-season mesocycles might focus purely on aerobic capacity and foundational skills, while late pre-season mesocycles shift to high-speed transition and stoppage craft [cite: 7, 9].
- The Microcycle (The Weekly Schedule): The microcycle dictates the day-to-day rhythm of a 7-day week. For an in-season AFL program playing on a Saturday, a standard microcycle involves:
 - Monday: Recovery and light technical touch.
 - Tuesday (Main Training Day): High-intensity tactical periodization. This is the heaviest day for distance and high-speed running, executing the 90-minute blueprints detailed below.
 - Thursday (Match Prep): Shorter duration, high-velocity sprint exposure (speed top-ups), and tactical walk-throughs without heavy aerobic drain [cite: 10].
 - Friday: Captain's run or complete rest.

1. Mixed Juniors: The Foundation Phase (Under 8 to Under 14)

The junior mixed pathway is the bedrock of football development. The primary objective is fostering a love for the game while systematically building Fundamental Movement Skills (FMS) and technical proficiency in a safe environment [cite: 11, 12].

Under 8 Cohort

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices Coaching Under 8s (U8) is fundamentally about organized chaos. The coaching philosophy relies on play-based learning and the "SPIR" method (Show, Practise, Instruct, Reward) to teach basic handling and hand-eye coordination [cite: 13, 14].

- Focus Areas: The training ratio demands 80% Technical Skill Acquisition, 10% Tactical Awareness (basic spatial recognition), and 10% Physical Conditioning (disguised as active play).
- Communication & Language: Coaches must utilize the "Change It" methodology (varying Communication, Area, Numbers, Game rules, Equipment, Inclusion, and Time) to maintain engagement [cite: 15, 16]. Language must be highly visual and positive, avoiding complex jargon.

Structuring these sessions effectively ensures young players remain continuously active rather than waiting in lines, which rapidly degrades their attention and enjoyment.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) While standard Auskick sessions traditionally run shorter, a 90-minute advanced blueprint is structured to maximize touches without fatigue [cite: 17].

- Warm-up / Activation (20 Mins): Evasion and tag games (e.g., Calf Tag) to build FMS like hopping, skipping, and spatial awareness [cite: 18].
- Skill Acquisition (30 Mins): Isolated basic handling (rolling, bouncing, ground ball gathers). Focus on individual ball time.
- Game Sense (30 Mins): Modified grid games with no tackling, emphasizing "Footy for Kicks" and keeping the ball moving [cite: 12].
- Conditioning & Recovery (10 Mins): Fun relay races that incidentally build aerobic capacity, followed by a calm group debrief.

This blueprint ensures physical conditioning is completely integrated into fun activities, masking the fitness element behind gamification.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: The Mad Eagle (Ground Ball Evasion) [cite: 11].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: A 15-meter diameter circle with 10-15 footballs (the "eggs") placed in the center nest.
- Execution & Rules: Players are assigned a number. When their number is called, they run around the outside of the circle, enter the nest, gather a football, and attempt to evade the coach (the "Mad Eagle") to return to their starting point. No tackling is permitted; evasion is key.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Fingers almost touching the ground," "Knuckles scraping the grass," "Keep your eyes on the ball" [cite: 19].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a second coach or a parent as another eagle. Regression: Remove the eagle and focus purely on the ground ball gather speed.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Ground Ball Eliminator (Peripheral Vision) [cite: 19].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: A 20m x 20m square grid. Every player has a football.
- Execution & Rules: Players roll and dribble the ball along the ground with their hands within the grid. Selected "eliminators" (parents/coaches) gently tap the balls away. Players must protect their football using body positioning.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Body in line behind the ball," "Stay in a semi-crouched position," "Keep your head over the footy" [cite: 19, 20].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Shrink the grid to 15m x 15m to increase congestion. Regression: Expand the grid to allow more space for slower learners.

Under 10 Cohort

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices At the Under 10 (U10) level, the coaching philosophy transitions to introducing modified contact. Safe wrap tackling is introduced here, requiring a focus on biomechanics to prevent injury [cite: 21].

- Focus Areas: The exact ratio shifts to 70% Technical Skill Acquisition, 15% Tactical Awareness, and 15% Physical Conditioning.
- Communication & Language: Terminology shifts toward body mechanics. Words like "corral" and "wrap" become standard, ensuring players understand the difference between dangerous impact and safe pressure [cite: 21].

Properly embedding these contact fundamentals is critical for long-term player

safety and confidence as the speed of the game increases.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) The introduction of contact requires dedicated, slow-paced technical blocks to ensure mastery before speed is applied.

- Warm-up / Activation (15 Mins): Dynamic movement focusing on balance, deceleration, and basic wrestling (e.g., chest-on-chest pushing) to build contact confidence [cite: 21, 22].
- Skill Acquisition (35 Mins): Stationary and walk-through wrap tackling mechanics, alongside fundamental kicking technique (grip, drop, impact).
- Game Sense (25 Mins): Small-sided games (e.g., 5v5) focusing on applying the hold-and-release or wrap tackle in live play [cite: 21].
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Short, sharp shuttle runs integrated with handballing to build motor memory in the legs [cite: 23], followed by static stretching.

By isolating the tackle technique in a controlled environment, players build the neurological pathways required to execute safely under fatigue.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Tackle Gates (Farmer & Sheep) [cite: 21].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Multiple 5m x 5m squares. Two attacking players ("Sheep") and one defender ("Farmer").
- Execution & Rules: The attackers attempt to run or handball through the gates without being tackled. The defender must execute a safe wrap tackle or force a turnover by corraling.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Get low, stay low," "Hit and stick, no daylight," "Chin to back" [cite: 21].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Increase attackers to 3v2. Regression: Have the attackers walk to allow the defender to focus purely on safe wrap technique.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Circle Clean Hands under Pressure [cite: 21].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: An 8-10 player circle spanning 15 meters. A ball is placed in the center.
- Execution & Rules: The coach assigns numbers. When two numbers are called, the first player attempts to gather the ground ball and handball it out, while the second player acts as the tackler applying immediate pressure.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Protect the drop zone," "Lower your center of gravity," "Take the hit and give the hands."

- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The coach rolls the ball dynamically into the center so it is moving. Regression: The defender provides only passive, non-contact pressure.

Under 12 Cohort

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices The Under 12 (U12) bracket represents the "Modelling" stage [cite: 24]. Coaches must focus on game sense, introducing tactical positioning while continuing to refine kicking efficiency.

- Focus Areas: Ratios evolve to 60% Technical Skill Acquisition, 25% Tactical Awareness (zones, positioning), and 15% Physical Conditioning.
- Communication & Language: Coaches introduce field geometry terms like "the corridor," "fat side" (the wide, open side of the field), and "goal side" defense. Constructive feedback must be positive but firm, utilizing peer-role modeling [cite: 16, 25].

This transition phase bridges the gap between childhood play and adolescent tactical structure, requiring significant cognitive engagement from the players.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) Sessions now closely resemble an official match structure, broken into quarters or focused tactical blocks [cite: 26, 27].

- Warm-up / Activation (15 Mins): Agility ladders, dynamic leg swings, and partner handball tracking to elevate heart rate.
- Skill Acquisition (30 Mins): Kicking mechanics on the run. Focus on guiding the ball down and maintaining balance [cite: 20].
- Game Sense (30 Mins): 12-Point Overlap games [cite: 24] emphasizing ball movement through the corridor.
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Anaerobic sprint efforts (20-30 meters) followed by structured hydration and muscle recovery education.

This blueprint heavily leans into game-like scenarios, ensuring players understand why a skill is used, not just how to perform it.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: 3v2 Corridor Transition [cite: 24].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: A 20m x 30m rectangular grid. Three attackers start at one end, two defenders start 10 meters back.
- Execution & Rules: Attackers must transition the ball from one end of the grid to the other using precise handballs or short kicks. Defenders aim to corral the ball carrier and cut off the corridor.

- Elite Coaching Cues: "Square your shoulders to the target," "Draw the defender," "Use the overlap."
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Enforce a maximum of two seconds time-in-possession. Regression: Widen the grid to 25m to afford the attackers more space.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Whistle Kicking (Mechanics & Reaction) [cite: 20].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Pairs lined up 15 meters apart across the width of the oval.
- Execution & Rules: Players kick the ball back and forth dynamically. When the coach blows the whistle, all players must freeze instantly, holding their current biomechanical posture. The coach then walks the line correcting follow-throughs and ball grips.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Hold the ball over the thigh of the kicking leg," "Point your toes at the target," "Guide the ball down with one hand" [cite: 20].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Execute on the run, forcing players to freeze mid-stride. Regression: Execute from a stationary position only.

Under 14 Cohort

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices Entering the Under 14 (U14) age group, players transition from Junior to Youth football. The coaching philosophy relies on "using the game to teach the game" [cite: 28].

- Focus Areas: Ratios balance to 50% Technical Skill Acquisition, 30% Tactical Awareness, and 20% Physical Conditioning (introducing basic anaerobic endurance).
- Communication & Language: Coaches use probing questions to stimulate decision-making (e.g., "Why did you choose that option?"). The emphasis is on empowering players to solve problems on the field rather than relying on constant sideline instruction [cite: 28].

Failing to create a player-centric environment at this age often results in high dropout rates, as teenagers require autonomy and engagement over strict dictation [cite: 28].

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) The introduction of structured training blocks that mimic match intensity and fatigue.

- Warm-up / Activation (10 Mins): High-intensity multidirectional agility and dynamic stretching.

- Skill Acquisition (25 Mins): Advanced kicking (3-5 step kick routines, opposite foot development) [cite: 29].
- Game Sense (40 Mins): "Fat side" exploitation drills and stoppage positioning (Ruck, Sweeper, Blocker roles) [cite: 25, 30].
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): 400m intervals immediately followed by handball games under fatigue to build motor memory and decision-making when tired [cite: 23].

This structure directly links physical conditioning to cognitive execution, forcing players to execute cleanly even when their legs are heavy.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: The Fat Side Switch [cite: 30, 31].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Half-ground setup (approx. 50m x 50m). Divide players into a 6v3 overload scenario.
- Execution & Rules: The ball is deliberately crowded on the "skinny side" (boundary). Attackers must execute a minimum of two handballs in traffic before hitting a wide kicker on the "fat side" (open space) to clear the zone.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Eyes on the fat side," "Predictable movement," "Own the ground" [cite: 30].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a trailer player who demands a backward handball before the switch [cite: 30]. Regression: Run the drill without defensive pressure (6v0) to establish the passing pattern.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: 5v5 Decision Grid [cite: 32].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: A 10m x 10m inner square surrounded by a 13m x 13m outer square.
- Execution & Rules: Teams play 5v5 keep-away inside the inner square. To score, a player must break into the outer 3m zone and receive a pass or run the ball through without being tackled.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Spread and separate," "Read the cues of the attacker," "Create time and space" [cite: 32].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Reduce the time limit to 30 seconds to score [cite: 32]. Regression: Expand the inner square to 15m x 15m.

2. Female Pathway: specialized Biomechanics and Tactical Growth (Under 12G to Under 18G)

The youth girls pathway necessitates a specialized approach. Development milestones and entry points often differ from the traditional boys pathway, with many girls entering the sport later. Crucially, anatomical differences mean

females have a 2-5x greater risk of serious knee injuries (like the Anterior Cruciate Ligament or ACL) due to anatomical factors such as a wider pelvis and an increased Q-angle (the angle between the quadriceps muscle and the patellar tendon), biomechanical factors like steeper tibial slopes, and physiological/hormonal fluctuations (such as estrogen and relaxin variations during the menstrual cycle that increase ligament laxity), and in AFLW, this risk has historically spiked to 9.2x higher than male equivalents [cite: 33, 34, 35, 36]. Therefore, the Prep-to-Play injury mitigation program is a non-negotiable cornerstone of this pathway.

Under 12 Girls

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices For U12 Girls, the coaching philosophy is rooted in building neuromuscular control and safe movement patterns before explosive forces are introduced [cite: 22, 37].

- Focus Areas: Ratios are strictly 55% Technical Skill Acquisition, 15% Tactical Awareness, and 30% Physical Conditioning (heavily weighted toward Prep-to-Play mechanics).
- Communication & Language: Coaches must use external goal-related cues (e.g., "get low") rather than over-complicating joint coordination (e.g., "bend your hip and knee") [cite: 22].

By establishing foundational biomechanics early, coaches create a protective physical framework that will sustain the athletes through their adolescent growth spurts.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) The session is heavily weighted toward movement quality over tactical complexities.

- Warm-up / Activation (20 Mins): Prep-to-Play dynamic warm-up (walking lunges, leg swings, hip openers) [cite: 38].
- Skill Acquisition (30 Mins): Fundamental handling, rolling, and stationary ground ball gathers with correct postural alignment.
- Game Sense (25 Mins): Modified grid games (Eliminator, keep-away) focusing on spatial awareness without high-impact collisions.
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Prep-to-Play balance mechanics (e.g., single-leg jumps sticking the landing) [cite: 38].

This blueprint ensures that correct movement patterns are grooved into muscle memory when the players are fresh.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Prep-to-Play Landing Mechanics [cite: 22, 39].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 10-meter lanes marked with cones. Players work in pairs.
- Execution & Rules: Player A sprints forward, jumps off one leg, and is gently bumped in the air by Player B (with a pad or body). Player A must land cleanly on two feet in a balanced athletic stance.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Land in an athletic stance," "Keep knees in line with hips," "Stick the landing" [cite: 34, 38].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Turn 90 degrees in the air before landing [cite: 22]. Regression: Remove the mid-air bump.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Chest-on-Chest Ground Ball Gather [cite: 22].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 5m x 5m grid. Two players face each other with a ball on the ground between them.
- Execution & Rules: Players get low into an athletic stance, chest on chest, with their chins to their backs. On the whistle, they drive their legs and attempt to push the partner over the line while securing the ground ball.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Sweep fingers to the grass," "Get feet close, get low," "Drive the legs" [cite: 22].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Start 5 meters back and contest the ball on the run. Regression: Start from a kneeling position to focus solely on the pickup.

Under 14 Girls

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices At the U14 Girls level, the focus shifts to "Contact Readiness" [cite: 40]. With varying levels of prior football exposure, coaches must safely bridge the gap between non-contact evasion and full-contact tackling.

- Focus Areas: Ratios are 50% Technical Skill Acquisition, 25% Tactical Awareness, and 25% Physical Conditioning.
- Communication & Language: Emphasis on "Duty of Care" terminology. Players must learn to protect both themselves and their opponents during tackles (e.g., "Roll and drop," "No sling") [cite: 34].

A confident player is a safe player; hesitant, upright movements are the primary cause of whiplash and structural injuries in this age group.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) Sessions now blend physical readiness with functional football skills.

- Warm-up / Activation (15 Mins): Neuromuscular warm-up, open-and-shut the gate hip mobility, and inchworms [cite: 38].
- Skill Acquisition (30 Mins): Tackling technique (Inside vs. Outside tackles), tracking the hips, and deceleration [cite: 21].
- Game Sense (30 Mins): 3v3 Stoppage Entry, teaching the Ruck, Rover, and Sweeper roles [cite: 25].
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Core and hip strength exercises (e.g., lock clams, superman holds) [cite: 41] to replace static stretching ("Strength over Stretch" philosophy) [cite: 40].

This blueprint effectively uses the end of the session to build the muscular armor necessary to stabilize joints.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Body on Body Tracking [cite: 21].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 10m x 10m grid. Working in pairs.
- Execution & Rules: The attacker moves unpredictably at 75% speed. The defender must track them, decelerate early using quick steps, corral them to the boundary, and engage with a safe wrap tackle aiming for the inside shoulder.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Short quick steps to decelerate," "Aim for the inside shoulder," "Pin the elbows" [cite: 21, 34].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The attacker attempts to break the tackle dynamically. Regression: Conduct the drill at walking pace.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: 3v3 Stoppage Entry [cite: 25, 28].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: A center circle configuration (15m diameter).
- Execution & Rules: Coach acts as the umpire and bounces/throws the ball. The ruck taps, and the rovers must read the tap, gather cleanly, and burst from the circle while absorbing pressure from the opposition.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Read the tap," "Hit the pack with speed," "Protect the drop zone."
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a sweeper player (4v3) to create an outlet. Regression: Use a stationary ball on the ground instead of a live ruck tap.

Under 16 Girls

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices U16 Girls enter the "Establishment" phase, characterized by heightened game awareness and the physical demands of high-speed change of direction [cite: 24, 34].

- Focus Areas: Ratios shift to 40% Technical Skill Acquisition, 40% Tactical Awareness, and 20% Physical Conditioning.
- Communication & Language: Tactical language dominates ("Zone off," "Transition," "Sacrificial lead"). Feedback must prompt self-reflection to build football IQ [cite: 28, 42].

At this stage, the speed of the game increases dramatically. Proper biomechanical alignment must hold up under severe cardiovascular fatigue.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint)

- Warm-up / Activation (10 Mins): Bounding, hopping, and lateral hops to prepare the ankles and knees for cutting [cite: 22, 41].
- Skill Acquisition (25 Mins): High-velocity handballing (Release and Reload) and kicking under pressure [cite: 24].
- Game Sense (40 Mins): Full-ground transition drills. Moving the ball from defense to the forward 50m.
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Repeated sprint ability (RSA) training integrated with the Prep-to-Play strength modules (BB Hip Thrusts, single-leg calf raises) [cite: 41, 43].

This structure pushes players to their anaerobic threshold while demanding clean skill execution.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Split the Defender [cite: 24].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 30m x 20m grid. 3 Attackers vs. 1 Defender in the middle, plus 1 trailing Defender.
- Execution & Rules: Attackers must run at the primary defender and utilize rapid handballs to "split" them, breaking into open space before the trailing defender catches them.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Draw the player," "Fast hands," "Communicate the overlap."
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a second active defender in the middle. Regression: Remove the trailing defender to reduce time pressure.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Defensive Corridor Rebound [cite: 25].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Half-ground setup starting from the defensive goal square.
- Execution & Rules: The ball is kicked in by a defender. The defensive unit

must link via short, precise kicks and handballs through the center corridor to reach the halfway line against a zone defense.

- Elite Coaching Cues: "Move the ball away from the boundary," "Provide cover," "Present as a straight-running kicker" [cite: 25, 42].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The opposition implements an 18-man full-ground press. Regression: Ensure a 6v4 numerical advantage for the exiting defense.

Under 18 Girls

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices The U18 Girls bracket is the immediate precursor to elite senior football (AFLW/VFLW/SANFLW). The philosophy is "Perfecting," merging complex tactical periodization with elite strength and conditioning [cite: 24].

- Focus Areas: Ratios reflect elite prep: 30% Technical Skill Acquisition, 50% Tactical Awareness, and 20% Physical Conditioning.
- Communication & Language: Professional-level discourse. Coaches expect players to understand and execute complex team structures (e.g., "Corridor Link," "10-second zone") without constant hand-holding [cite: 24, 42].

Players here must be prepared for the sheer physical collision and aerobic demands of state-league or national-level women's football.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint)

- Warm-up / Activation (10 Mins): Prep-to-Play PRO warm-up [cite: 40], focusing on high-speed deceleration and reactive agility.
- Skill Acquisition (20 Mins): Position-specific craft (e.g., rucks doing tap work, forwards doing set shots with heart rate elevated).
- Game Sense (45 Mins): Match Simulation. 18v18 (or max available numbers) working on Red Zone entries and stoppage clearances [cite: 42].
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): 100 Points of Recovery framework (foam rolling, cold water immersion, hydration protocols) [cite: 41].

This blueprint mirrors an elite AFLW training session, establishing the professional habits required for drafted players.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Red Zone Crumbing [cite: 42].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: The forward 50m arc. 5 Forwards vs. 5 Defenders.
- Execution & Rules: A high ball is bombed into the "Danger Zone" (top of the goal square). The tall forwards must bring the ball to the front of the

pack. The small forwards must hit the pack with speed, gather the crumb front-and-square, and snap for goal.

- Elite Coaching Cues: "Keep the Danger Zone free," "Hit the pack with speed," "Don't be flat-footed" [cite: 42].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Start the small forwards facing away from the goals, forcing them to turn and locate the ball mid-air. Regression: Use a static ground ball placement rather than a contested aerial drop.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: The Lock Clam & Tackle (Strength & Contact) [cite: 41, 44].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 10m x 10m grid with tackle bags/shields.
- Execution & Rules: Players perform intense gluteal/core activation (The Lock Clam) for 30 seconds [cite: 41], then immediately pop up and execute three consecutive high-impact body-lock tackles on the bags to simulate extreme physical fatigue and recovery [cite: 44].
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Strength over stretch," "Drive through the shield," "Recover quickly from the ground" [cite: 40, 44].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Use a live partner with a Zena Sport impact vest instead of a bag [cite: 44]. Regression: Focus purely on the clam activation without the tackle burst.

3. Male Pathway: Tactical Complexity and Anaerobic Power (Under 16B to Under 18B)

The youth male pathway demands extreme physiological adaptation. As boys undergo massive spikes in lean body mass and speed, the coaching methodology must manage this physical endowment while aggressively teaching complex game plans.

Under 16 Boys

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices The U16 Boys phase focuses on anaerobic capacity and the introduction of strict set plays. A player's ability to contest the ball at multiple efforts depends entirely on their anaerobic fitness at this age [cite: 25].

- Focus Areas: Ratios are 40% Technical Skill Acquisition, 40% Tactical Awareness, and 20% Physical Conditioning (Speed/Agility programming).
- Communication & Language: Terminology becomes highly structured around team rules (e.g., "Accountability," "Cover," "Blind turn") [cite: 25]. Feedback focuses on effort, work rate, and execution under pressure.

This is the age where players must learn to run not just when they have the

ball, but to support, to receive, and to defend relentlessly.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint)

- Warm-up / Activation (15 Mins): High knees, lunges, and skips to develop top speed mechanics, followed by multi-directional bounding [cite: 25].
- Skill Acquisition (25 Mins): Fending, baulking, and the blind turn. Focus on keeping the hand nearest the opponent free [cite: 25].
- Game Sense (35 Mins): Centre square set-ups and boundary throw-in zoning.
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Hard chasing drills (simulating full-sprint pursuit of an opponent) [cite: 25].

This session structure ensures that high-speed running is paired with technical evasion.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Centre Square Sweeper Setup [cite: 25].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Standard 50m x 50m center square. 4 midfielders (Ruck, Rover, Blocker, Sweeper) against 4 opponents.
- Execution & Rules: The coach bounces the ball. The midfield unit must execute a pre-determined play (e.g., the blocker clears a path for the rover, the sweeper holds defensive cover). If the ball is lost, players must instantly transition to man-on-man accountability.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Sweep the forward side," "Provide cover," "Account for your direct opponent" [cite: 25, 42].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The opposition knows the play and actively sets up to defeat it, forcing the attacking midfield to read the cues and change the call. Regression: Run through the setup unopposed (4v0).

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Evasion and Fending Grid [cite: 25].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 15m x 15m grid. 1 Attacker, 1 Defender.
- Execution & Rules: The attacker receives the ball on the run and must navigate past the defender using a baulk, blind turn, or a legal fend-off (stiff arm) to cross the opposite line.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Keep your inside hand free," "Push off hard," "Accelerate past the opponent" [cite: 13, 25].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a second trailing defender to force an immediate decision post-evasion. Regression: The defender jogs at 50% pace.

Under 18 Boys

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices As players approach draft age or senior community football, the framework transitions to "Perfecting" [cite: 45]. Tactical periodization is paramount, and players are expected to execute under extreme fatigue, replicating the demands of state league (VFL/SANFL/WAFL) football.

- Focus Areas: Ratios are heavily tactical: 25% Technical Skill, 55% Tactical Awareness, and 20% Physical Conditioning (high-load resistance and sprint training) [cite: 43].
- Communication & Language: Coaches act as facilitators and strategists. Language revolves around "Game Style," "Corridor Link," and "Pressure Kicking" [cite: 24].

The margin for error here is razor-thin. Training must replicate the chaos, speed, and spatial restrictions of professional football.

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint)

- Warm-up / Activation (10 Mins): High-load conditioning activity (e.g., plyometric hurdle jumps) to elicit post-activation performance enhancement (PAPE) [cite: 43].
- Skill Acquisition (20 Mins): Precision kicking (torpedoes, snap shots across the body under fatigue) [cite: 25].
- Game Sense (45 Mins): "Go Back to Go Forward" drills and switching the play across the half-back line [cite: 24].
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Repeated sprint ability (RSA) metrics (e.g., 6 x 40m shuttle sprints separated by 20 seconds of passive recovery [cite: 46] or 10 x 30m sprints every 30 seconds [cite: 47]) and advanced load management debriefing [cite: 43].

This blueprint relies on high-intensity intervals that fuse skill and stamina, ensuring late-game execution.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Pressure Kicking (Go Back to Go Forward) [cite: 24, 25].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Full defensive 50m arc. 6 Defenders, 4 Attackers.
- Execution & Rules: The defense intercepts a ball deep in the pocket. Driven by the "10-second zone" rule, they must initially look backward to a designated kicker or switch player to create a better angle before launching a precision drop punt to a leading target on the wing [cite: 25, 42].
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Balance up before disposal," "Weight your kick to the

lead," "Sacrificial lead to create space" [cite: 25, 42].

- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a strict 6-second shot clock to execute the switch. Regression: Remove the forwards, running the pattern unopposed.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Precision Target Follow-Up [cite: 29, 48].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 40m distance between kickers and receivers. Use Sherrin Precision balls if available [cite: 29].
- Execution & Rules: The player executes a 3-5 step kick aiming for a specific quadrant of the receiver's body (high, flat, 5-iron trajectory). Immediately after kicking, the kicker must sprint past the marking cone to follow up and receive a return handball [cite: 29, 48].
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Maintain momentum through the footy," "Scan the field immediately after kicking," "Follow through straight towards the target" [cite: 20, 48].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The receiver has a defender applying physical pressure during the mark. Regression: Shorten the kicking distance to 20m.

4. Senior Categories: Elite Execution and Longevity (Senior Men, Senior Women, Veterans Men)

At the senior level, the biological and tactical development is largely complete. The focus shifts aggressively toward acute vs. chronic workload management [cite: 4], maintaining physical peak, preventing injury, and executing flawless tactical structures.

Senior Men

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices The Senior Men's program operates at the pinnacle of tactical periodization. Coaches manage cumulative workloads to minimize fatigue and maximize Banister-model-projected performance (an impulse-response mathematical model where overall athletic performance is calculated as accumulated fitness minus accumulated fatigue; analogous to a bank account, training "deposits" improve the balance of fitness, but "withdrawals" of fatigue must be carefully managed to avoid a negative balance on match day) prior to match day [cite: 4, 49].

- Focus Areas: Ratios sit at 20% Technical Skill Refinement, 60% Tactical Game Plan Execution, and 20% Physical Conditioning/Load Management.
- Communication & Language: Deeply strategic. Use of analytics, opposition scouting terms, and biomechanical feedback.

In this phase, previous week-to-week load changes are meticulously monitored. A large increment in training load (e.g., >1250 Arbitrary Units) significantly correlates with injury risk [cite: 5].

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint)

- Warm-up / Activation (10 Mins): High-velocity sprint efforts (e.g., 5 x 20m sprints at >24km/h) to prime the nervous system without excessive aerobic fatigue.
- Skill Acquisition (15 Mins): Elite stoppage craft, clean hands in extreme traffic.
- Game Sense (50 Mins): Full-ground 18v18 structures, zoning the corridor, and transition grids.
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Tailored tapering. 1 Day on / 1 Day off recovery protocols [cite: 50].

The priority is absolute match replication without crossing the threshold of chronic overtraining.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Protect the Drop Zone [cite: 30, 31].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Forward 50m arc. 3v3 contest with an incoming long ball.
- Execution & Rules: A midfielder kicks long to a contest. The forwards must actively wrestle and lead the primary defender away from the drop zone to allow a secondary forward (e.g., the fat-side trailer) an uncontested run at the ball [cite: 30, 31].
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Read the cues of the flight," "Strong body position," "Own the ground" [cite: 30].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a sweeper defender coming across the front of the pack. Regression: Use a stationary ruck bag instead of a live defender.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Fat-Side Stoppage Exit [cite: 30].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Centre square to half-forward flank (forming an exact quantitative grid of approximately 50m x 70m).
- Execution & Rules: Following a simulated ball-up, the team wins possession but is trapped on the boundary (skinny side). They must execute a rapid 3-to-1 shift backward, hit the fat-side trailer player, and drive into the open forward 50 [cite: 30].

- Elite Coaching Cues: "Get off the mark quickly," "Low risk with the football," "Forward open space to run into" [cite: 30].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The opposition implements a full zone defense to clog the fat side. Regression: Run as a shadow drill with zero defensive pressure.

Senior Women (AFLW / State League)

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices Senior women's football requires an elite tactical approach matched with an unyielding commitment to injury mitigation, given the disproportionate risk of non-contact ACL tears and tackling-related concussions (accounting for 70-80% of head injuries in AFLW) [cite: 34].

- Focus Areas: Ratios are 25% Technical Skill Refinement (specifically contact absorption), 55% Tactical Awareness, and 20% Physical Conditioning (Prep-to-Play PRO).
- Communication & Language: Direct, empowering, and safety-conscious. Emphasizing the "Duty of Care" in tackles and aerial contests [cite: 34].

AFLW training immersion programs often blend club departments to increase cohesion, demanding a highly professional, one-club approach to training culture [cite: 51].

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint)

- Warm-up / Activation (15 Mins): Prep-to-Play PRO (jumping, landing, deceleration) [cite: 40, 52].
- Skill Acquisition (20 Mins): Advanced tackle mechanics (anti-sling, body locks) [cite: 44].
- Game Sense (40 Mins): Match sim striking, fast break transitions, and defensive structures.
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Core stability, hamstring/gluteal strength (BB Hip Thrusts), and cold water immersion [cite: 41].

This blueprint guarantees that strength and neuromuscular control are addressed in every single session to counteract anatomical vulnerabilities.

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Advanced Safe Tackle (No Sling) [cite: 34, 44].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 10m x 10m grid. Working in pairs.
- Execution & Rules: The tackler approaches dynamically. They must execute a body-lock tackle, pinning the opponent's elbows. Crucially, they must drive

through the tackle in one motion and safely "roll and drop" their opponent to the ground, strictly avoiding any rotational sling [cite: 34, 44].

- Elite Coaching Cues: "Control the impact," "Roll and drop with control," "No daylight" [cite: 21, 34].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: The ball carrier actively attempts to break the tackle. Regression: Execute on a tackle bag or impact shield to master the drive without risking a teammate [cite: 44].

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Deceleration Ground Ball Contest [cite: 34].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 20m sprint lane with a ball placed 15m out.
- Execution & Rules: Players sprint at 90% top speed toward the ball. At the 12m mark, they must abruptly decelerate using short, choppy steps, lowering their center of gravity to execute a clean pickup without blowing past the ball or hyper-extending the knee [cite: 21, 34].
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Active feet and drive legs," "Don't be upright and flat-footed," "Get low early" [cite: 34].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Add a trailing defender applying hip pressure. Regression: Jog at 50% pace to groove the deceleration mechanics.

Veterans Men (AFL Masters)

1. Developmental Framework & Best Practices AFL Masters (35+ years) operates under the philosophy of "Footy for Kicks" and "Football for Fun" [cite: 53, 54]. The absolute priority is providing a safe, inclusive environment that fosters mental wellbeing, social connection, and physical fitness while mitigating the age-related decline in tissue elasticity. Egos must be left at home [cite: 53].

- Focus Areas: Ratios adjust to 30% Technical Skill Maintenance, 40% Tactical Awareness (smart positioning over running), and 30% Load Management & Recovery.
- Communication & Language: Collaborative, respectful, and highly social. Cues focus on smart football and self-preservation rather than pushing beyond limits [cite: 55].

Rules are strictly modified: no sling tackles, no projecting knees into marking contests or rucks, and 15-minute quarters with unlimited interchanges [cite: 56].

2. Standard Session Breakdown (90-Minute Blueprint) Training is highly flexible. Many players only train to their specific fitness level without judgment [cite: 57].

- Warm-up / Activation (20 Mins): Extensive dynamic mobility, addressing lower back and hamstring stiffness. Absolutely no static running laps.
- Skill Acquisition (25 Mins): Short, sharp handball games. Kicking is kept to a minimum in the first few weeks to prevent calf and hamstring depletion [cite: 23].
- Game Sense (30 Mins): Non-contact or highly modified contact touch-football variants [cite: 56]. Focus on using the ball well and supporting each other [cite: 55].
- Conditioning & Recovery (15 Mins): Holistic recovery, stretching, and social integration (the mental health aspect of community connection is treated as equally important to physical recovery) [cite: 55, 57].

The emphasis here is that long-distance kicking depletes the legs rapidly; training must build motor memory through short, sharp efforts rather than exhaustive running [cite: 23].

3. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 1)

- Drill Name & Objective: Short and Sharp Handball Flow [cite: 23].
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: 20m x 20m grid. 6v6 scenario.
- Execution & Rules: Players are restricted to handballs only. They run for short 10-15 meter bursts, deliver the handball, and immediately stop to build strength in the calves and hamstrings without overloading the joints. If fatigued, players are encouraged to make smart, slow decisions [cite: 23].
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Keep it short and sharp," "Stop and go," "Make good decisions when fatigued" [cite: 23].
- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Introduce 20-30 meter short kicks once leg conditioning has been established after week 4 [cite: 23].
Regression: Walk-through pace only.

4. High-Detail Drill Inventory (Drill 2)

- Drill Name & Objective: Uncontested Mark & Move.
- Setup & Grid Dimensions: Full ground (approximately 160m x 130m) or half ground (80m x 130m) [cite: 2]. Groups of 4.
- Execution & Rules: Players focus on "smart football" [cite: 55]. Player A kicks to Player B on a lead. To avoid collision or jumping injuries, Player B must mark the ball on the chest or slightly out in front without leaving the ground (no knees up). They then seamlessly turn and deliver a short pass to Player C.
- Elite Coaching Cues: "Use the ball well," "Stay on the ground," "Support the runner."

- Progressions & Regressions: Progression: Introduce a token defender who operates strictly on a "hold and release" or passive corral rule.
Regression: Decrease the kicking distance to 15 meters to eliminate strain on the quadriceps.

UNDER 14's

Under 14s Coaching Best Practices

Transitioning into the Under 14s age group is a critical development phase in Aussie Rules Football. Players are shifting from fundamental skill acquisition to full-ground tactical execution, managing accelerated physical growth, and adapting to standard competitive rules. The coaching approach must be highly structured, heavily instructional, and focused on game-like repetition.

Transitioning to Full-Ground Structural Play

At this level, players often struggle with the vastness of the oval. The coaching priority is shrinking the ground through structural positioning. Teach players to hold their zones rather than being drawn to the football. Implement a 6-6-6 structure mindset at center bounces, emphasizing that forwards must stay ahead of the ball to create an outlet, and defenders must maintain goal-side positioning. Transitioning through the corridor becomes vital; players must be taught to look inboard for a 45-degree kick before retreating to the boundary.

Decision-Making Under High Fatigue

Under 14s matches are characterized by chaotic momentum swings. Players must be trained to execute under physical and cardiovascular fatigue. Utilize the 'Observe, Orient, Decide, Act' (OODA) loop in your training vocabulary. Force players into drills where they must sprint 20 meters to get to a contest, win the groundball, and instantly identify an overlapping runner. If they hold the ball too long while fatigued, they will be caught holding the ball. Training must replicate this exact match-intensity fatigue.

Physical Contact and Contested Execution

Safe, legal physical contact is non-negotiable. Teach tackling by focusing on the "hip-to-hip" approach rather than reaching from behind. Players must learn to drop their body weight, pin the arms, and take the opposition to ground safely. Conversely, when absorbing contact, teach players to turn their bodies to protect the ribcage and absorb impact through the shoulder and hips. Ensure contested drills are tightly officiated in training to prevent dangerous sling tackles or high contact.

Maximizing Small-Sided Games (SSGs)

Traditional line drills do not translate effectively to match-day pressure. Small-sided games (e.g., 6v4 or 5v5 in restricted grids) force rapid tactical communication. Use a 40x40m grid to simulate clearing a stoppage from the half-back flank, placing a numerical advantage for the defending team to force the attacking team to lower their eyes and hit leading targets rather than bombing it long.

The 50-Drill Library

Drill 1: Continuous Handball Grid - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Rapid hand skill execution under light fatigue.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 12 players, 4 footballs.

Progression/Description: Players move continuously within the grid circulating the footballs by hand. On the whistle, players with the ball drop it, and all players sprint to a boundary line before returning to retrieve balls and continue.

Coaching Points: Keep eyes up, communicate loudly, receive the ball on the move, punch through the ball on release.

Progression/Regression: Add more footballs to increase difficulty or introduce a token defender.

Drill 2: Give and Go Agility - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: First touch efficiency and accelerating after disposal.

Setup: 15m channel, cones spaced 5m apart, pairs, 1 football per pair.

Progression/Description: Player A runs forward, handballs to Player B who is backpedaling.

Player A then performs a sharp agility cut around a cone before receiving the ball back.

Coaching Points: Accelerate immediately after disposing of the ball, demand the return pass loudly, keep hands ready.

Progression/Regression: Shorten the distance between cones to force faster reaction times.

Drill 3: 3 Man Weave to Target - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Forward movement and spatial awareness.

Setup: Full length of the center square, groups of 3, 1 football per group.

Progression/Description: Players run down the ground in threes, handballing to the adjacent player and immediately running behind them to loop to the outside.

Coaching Points: Time your run to receive on the burst, do not overrun the ball carrier, execute firm handballs to the target's advantage.

Progression/Regression: End the weave with a 30m kick to a leading target to simulate a forward entry.

Drill 4: Lane Running Kicks - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Precision kicking on the run.

Setup: 40m lanes, pairs, 1 football per pair.

Progression/Description: Pairs run parallel down the lane, kicking back and forth over a 15m distance without breaking stride.

Coaching Points: Drop the ball smoothly, guide it onto the boot, keep momentum moving forward, hit the target on the chest.

Progression/Regression: Switch to the non-preferred foot on the return run.

Drill 5: Groundball Scramble - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Clean collection of the ball below the knees.

Setup: 10x10m grid, 6 players, 3 footballs.

Progression/Description: Coach rolls all footballs randomly into the grid. Players must attack the ball, collect it cleanly, and handball out of the grid to a stationary target.

Coaching Points: Keep the body over the ball, turn the hip to protect the ball, one clean motion from ground to hand.

Progression/Regression: Introduce 1 pressure player who attempts to smother the handball.

Drill 6: Reaction Sprints and Scoop - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Acceleration and clean collection under physical pressure.

Setup: 15m sprint lane, pairs, 1 football.

Progression/Description: Players lie on their stomachs. Coach blows the whistle and rolls a ball forward. Both players scramble up and sprint to win the groundball.

Coaching Points: Explode off the ground, take the shortest path to the ball, protect the drop zone with your body.

Progression/Regression: Start players seated backwards to increase disorientation and orientation time.

Drill 7: Over the Shoulder Mark - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Tracking the flight of the ball while running back.

Setup: 30m space, groups of 3, 1 football.

Progression/Description: Player runs away from the kicker. Kicker places the ball out in front, forcing the runner to track the ball over their shoulder and mark on the run.

Coaching Points: Keep eyes locked on the ball, run through the line of the ball, do not break stride to mark.

Progression/Regression: Throw the ball instead of kicking for a more controlled delivery early on.

Drill 8: Boundary Line Run - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Keeping the ball in play while running at high speed.

Setup: 30m stretch along the boundary line, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A runs tight along the boundary line. Player B runs 10m inside. They exchange rapid handballs, ensuring Player A never steps out of bounds.

Coaching Points: Spatial awareness of the line, quick hands, keep the body leaning inboard.
Progression/Regression: Add a stationary object on the boundary that Player A must dodge while maintaining possession.

Drill 9: Kick and Chase - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Following up a disposal with a second effort.

Setup: 40m channel, individuals with a football each.

Progression/Description: Player kicks a short 15m drop punt to themselves, sprints to gather it on the bounce, and instantly executes a 20m handball to a coach.

Coaching Points: Weight the kick perfectly, do not wait for the bounce, attack the ball at top speed.

Progression/Regression: Require a non-preferred foot kick for the self-pass.

Drill 10: Box Square Warmup - Dynamic High-Tempo Warm-ups

Objective: Improve first touch and change of direction.

Setup: 15x15m grid, 8 players, 2 footballs.

Progression/Description: Players at four cones. Ball is kicked clockwise. After kicking, the player sprints to the center, touches a cone, and runs to the back of the line they kicked to.

Coaching Points: Hit targets on the chest, quick feet at the center cone, call for the ball early.

Progression/Regression: Switch direction to counter-clockwise to test the non-preferred foot.

Drill 11: Corridor Switch - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Transitioning the ball aggressively into the center of the ground.

Setup: Half ground, 12 players.

Progression/Description: Ball starts deep in a pocket. Player kicks to a leading target on the half-back flank, who immediately turns inboard and hits a target streaming through the corridor.

Coaching Points: Fast transition, look inboard instantly upon marking, corridor runner must yell aggressively to demand the ball.

Progression/Regression: Add a man on the mark who can quickly backpedal to block the corridor kick.

Drill 12: Boundary Trap and Release - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Escaping a boundary line press.

Setup: 30x30m grid on the boundary, 4v3 setup.

Progression/Description: 3 defenders try to force the 4 attackers over the boundary line.

Attackers must use short handballs to draw the defenders before kicking out of the trap to a free player.

Coaching Points: Do not panic, keep the ball moving, use overlapping runs to break the defensive wall.

Progression/Regression: Make it 4v4 to increase the defensive pressure and force immediate disposal.

Drill 13: 45-Degree Kicking - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Breaking defensive lines with angled kicks.

Setup: 50m zig-zag cone setup, 8 players.

Progression/Description: Players lead at 45-degree angles from the ball carrier. The ball is moved full length using only diagonal kicks, never straight down the line.

Coaching Points: Honor the lead, kick to the advantage side, runners must time their leads so they are not waiting stationary.

Progression/Regression: Add token defenders standing in the passing lanes to force higher or lower trajectory kicks.

Drill 14: Half-Back Rebound - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Fast transition from defense to attack.

Setup: Defensive 50m arc to center square, 6v4 setup.

Progression/Description: Coach bombs the ball into the defensive 50. 6 defenders work together to gather, link up via hand, and execute a designated kick to a target in the center square.

Coaching Points: First touch is critical, spread wide immediately after the contest is won, lower the eyes for the exit kick.

Progression/Regression: Reduce the defenders to 5 to make the initial contest harder to win.

Drill 15: Inside 50 Entry - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Honoring leads and avoiding bombing into the forward line.

Setup: Center circle to Forward 50, 3 midfielders, 3 forwards, 2 defenders.

Progression/Description: Midfielders win a groundball in the center and stream forward. Forwards must make coordinated, intersecting leads. Midfielder must hit a forward on the chest.

Coaching Points: Do not kick to a stationary target, forwards must isolate their defenders, midfielders must communicate who they are targeting.

Progression/Regression: Force the midfielders to execute one handball exchange before crossing the 50m arc.

Drill 16: Overlap Run - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Creating numerical advantages on the outside.

Setup: 60m channel, 3v2 setup.

Progression/Description: 3 attackers run the ball against 2 retreating defenders. The attackers must draw a defender, execute a handball to the outside overlapping runner, and carry the ball forward.

Coaching Points: Commit the defender before disposing, the overlap runner must hold their width, execute the handball out in front.

Progression/Regression: Require a kick for the final disposal to ensure they are looking downfield.

Drill 17: Center Square Pivot - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Switching the point of attack rapidly.

Setup: Center square, 8 players on the perimeter, 2 in the middle.

Progression/Description: Ball is kicked into the middle. The central player marks, instantly pivots 180 degrees, and kicks to a leading player on the opposite side of the square.

Coaching Points: Turn on the non-preferred side for speed, scan the field while the ball is incoming, deliver a low hard kick.

Progression/Regression: Have the second central player apply passive physical pressure on the receiver.

Drill 18: Wide Target Kicking - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Stretching the opposition defense.

Setup: Width of the ground, groups of 4.

Progression/Description: Ball starts in the corridor. Player kicks long and wide to a running target on the wing, who then centers it back to the top of the forward 50.

Coaching Points: Put enough flight on the wide kick to allow the runner to reach it, receiver must mark on the move, fast recentering.

Progression/Regression: Dictate that the recentering kick must be a low drop punt to a leading target.

Drill 19: Chaining Handballs - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Breaking lines through continuous hand possession.

Setup: 40x20m grid, 5 attackers, 3 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers must traverse the 40m grid using only handballs, while avoiding the 3 defenders. If touched, the ball resets.

Coaching Points: Support the ball carrier from behind, talk constantly, do not throw the ball blindly over the top.

Progression/Regression: Require a minimum of 4 handballs before crossing the finish line.

Drill 20: Defensive Exit - Tactical Ball Movement

Objective: Composed disposal exiting the defensive arc.

Setup: Defensive goal square to 50m arc, 5v5.

Progression/Description: Fullback kicks in from the square. The defensive team must work the ball beyond the 50m arc without turning it over to the high-pressing forwards.

Coaching Points: Use the pockets, create space for the kick-in, always have a short option and a long bail-out option.

Progression/Regression: Give the forwards a 5-second head start to set up their zone before the fullback can kick.

Drill 21: 2v2 Groundball Contest - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Winning the hard ball and extracting it safely.

Setup: 10x10m grid, 4 players, 1 coach with a ball.

Progression/Description: Coach throws the ball up or rolls it hard into the grid. The two pairs wrestle for position, win the ball, and attempt to handball it back to the coach.

Coaching Points: Get lowest to the ball, use the body to shepherd the opposition, communicate who is taking the ball and who is blocking.

Progression/Regression: Widen the grid to 15x15m to force more running before the contest.

Drill 22: Ruck Tap to Rover - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Timing the run to receive a hit-out.

Setup: Center circle, 2 rucks, 2 rovers.

Progression/Description: Coach throws the ball up. Rucks contest. Rovers must read the ruckman's hands, time their run, collect the tap at speed, and accelerate out of the circle.

Coaching Points: Ruckman must dictate the drop zone, rover must not run past the ball, snatch the ball cleanly at full speed.

Progression/Regression: Add a designated tagger to hold the rover, forcing them to break a tackle immediately after receiving the tap.

Drill 23: Boundary Throw-in Setup - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Structural organization at boundary stoppages.

Setup: Boundary line, 1 ruck, 3 midfielders per team.

Progression/Description: Coach simulates a boundary throw-in. Teams must set up their defensive and attacking side structures, win the clearance, and kick to a target.

Coaching Points: Defensive side mid must hold their ground, attacking mid must stay on the move, lock the ball in if the tap is lost.

Progression/Regression: Award double points for a clean clearance that results in an uncontested mark 30m away.

Drill 24: Center Bounce Clearance - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Synchronized midfield movement.

Setup: Center square, full midfield setup 4v4.

Progression/Description: Coach bounces the ball. Midfielders execute a pre-planned play to win the ball and exit the front of the square.

Coaching Points: Hold your zones until the ball is bounced, block for the designated receiver, execute a clean primary possession.

Progression/Regression: Enforce a strict time limit; the ball must exit the square within 5 seconds of the bounce.

Drill 25: Tackling Technique Grid - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Safe and effective physical tackling.

Setup: 10x10m grid, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A jogs with the ball. Player B approaches from the front/side, drops their hips, wraps the arms around the waist/hips, and brings Player A to ground safely.

Coaching Points: Head to the side, wrap the arms tight, do not sling, drive with the legs.

Progression/Regression: Increase the speed to a run, or have Player A attempt to fend off the tackle.

Drill 26: Bump and Recover - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Absorbing contact and staying involved in the play.

Setup: 15m channel, 3 players.

Progression/Description: Player A runs toward a groundball. Player B applies a legal side bump. Player A must absorb the bump, maintain balance, collect the ball, and handball to Player C.

Coaching Points: Keep a wide base, tuck the arm in to absorb the hit on the shoulder/bicep, keep eyes on the ball.

Progression/Regression: Use a tackle bag for Player B to apply heavier, controlled force.

Drill 27: First to the Ball - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Aggression at the contest.

Setup: 20m distance, 2 players, 1 football in the middle.

Progression/Description: Players start 10m away from the stationary ball in opposite directions. On the whistle, both turn and sprint. First player to the ball must cleanly gather and dispose while the second applies a tackle.

Coaching Points: Attack the ball with ferocious speed, do not wait for it to bounce up, protect yourself by staying low.

Progression/Regression: Start the players lying on their backs.

Drill 28: Shielding the Drop Zone - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Protecting the space for a mark.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 1 defender, 1 kicker.

Progression/Description: Kicker lofts the ball high into the grid. The attacker must use their body to hold off the defender, hold their ground, and take the chest mark.

Coaching Points: Watch the flight of the ball, use the core and hips to hold position, do not push in the back.

Progression/Regression: Add a second defender coming from the front to force a contested pack mark.

Drill 29: Congested Handball Release - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Finding an exit in heavy traffic.

Setup: 10x10m grid, 5v5 setup.

Progression/Description: All 10 players inside the tight grid. The team with the ball must complete 5 handballs in a row without the ball touching the ground or being intercepted.

Coaching Points: Constant movement, quick hands, protect the ball carrier, look for the small pockets of space.

Progression/Regression: Shrink the grid to 8x8m to create extreme congestion.

Drill 30: Sharking the Tap - Stoppage & Clearance

Objective: Anticipating opposition hit-outs.

Setup: Center circle, 1 dominant ruckman (coach), 3 rovers.

Progression/Description: Coach intentionally taps the ball to specific zones. The rovers must read the body language of the ruckman, anticipate the tap location, and intercept it.

Coaching Points: Watch the ruckman's eyes and hand positioning, stay on the toes, explode through the drop zone.

Progression/Regression: Have the coach fake a tap one way and hit it the other.

Drill 31: 3v2 Defend the Corridor - Defensive Transition

Objective: Forcing the ball wide.

Setup: 40x40m grid in the center of the ground, 3 attackers, 2 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to move the ball straight through the corridor.

Defenders must zone up, block the central passing lanes, and force the attackers to kick towards the boundary.

Coaching Points: Communicate constantly, push the ball carrier to their non-preferred side, do not get sucked into the contest prematurely.

Progression/Regression: Increase the grid length to give attackers more space to maneuver.

Drill 32: Zone Press Setup - Defensive Transition

Objective: Locking the ball inside the forward half.

Setup: Forward 50 to center circle, 18 players total.

Progression/Description: Defense attempts to kick out from full back. The attacking team sets up a high zone press, manning up long options and guarding space short to force a turnover.

Coaching Points: Maintain the structural wall, forwards must push up, do not allow easy uncontested marks behind the zone.

Progression/Regression: Require the defending team to exit within 10 seconds to induce panic and test the zone under pressure.

Drill 33: Intercept Marking - Defensive Transition

Objective: Reading the play to cut off opposition attacks.

Setup: Half-back flank, 1 defender, 2 attackers, 1 kicker.

Progression/Description: Kicker aims for the leading attacker. The defender must peel off their direct opponent, read the flight, and take an intercept mark in front of the target.

Coaching Points: Read the kicker's eyes, commit entirely to the mark, do not hesitate once you leave your man.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a second kicker to force the defender to split their attention before committing.

Drill 34: Trapping the Boundary - Defensive Transition

Objective: Using the boundary line as an extra defender.

Setup: 30m strip along the boundary, 2v2.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to run the ball down the wing. Defenders must corral them towards the boundary line, closing off inboard options and forcing a stoppage or out-of-bounds.

Coaching Points: Angle your run to block the inside lane, tackle with intent to wrap up the ball, use the line to your advantage.

Progression/Regression: Add a 3rd attacker trailing behind to force the defenders to cover the backward handball.

Drill 35: Defensive Slide - Defensive Transition

Objective: Covering teammates who leave their man.

Setup: 40x40m grid, 4v4 setup.

Progression/Description: Attackers move the ball. When one defender leaves their man to apply pressure on the ball carrier, the remaining defenders must immediately slide over to cover the dangerous free man.

Coaching Points: Talk early, point to the man you are covering, head on a swivel to see the whole field.

Progression/Regression: Add an extra attacker (5v4) to make the sliding decisions even more critical.

Drill 36: Tackling from Behind (Safe form) - Defensive Transition

Objective: Running down a ball carrier legally.

Setup: 30m sprint lane, 1 attacker, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Attacker starts with a 3m head start and sprints with the ball.

Defender chases and executes a tackle from behind, focusing on dragging down by the hips, not pushing in the back.

Coaching Points: Close the gap quickly, dive at the hips/waist, pull down sideways to avoid in-the-back penalties.

Progression/Regression: Give the attacker a stationary target to hit to force the defender to rush the tackle.

Drill 37: Smother and Chase - Defensive Transition

Objective: Desperation defense on the kicker.

Setup: 20m distance, 1 kicker, 1 chaser.

Progression/Description: Kicker takes 3 steps and attempts to kick a drop punt to a target. The chaser sprints from an angle and dives to smother the ball off the boot.

Coaching Points: Throw hands straight out, turn the face away for protection, commit fully to the dive.

Progression/Regression: Have the kicker execute a fake kick and step inside, forcing the chaser to hold their feet.

Drill 38: Man-on-Man Transition - Defensive Transition

Objective: Immediate accountability upon losing possession.

Setup: Full center square, 6v6.

Progression/Description: Coach tosses the ball into the square. A mini game ensues. On the coach's whistle, whoever does not have the ball must instantly locate a man and initiate physical contact to prevent them running.

Coaching Points: Find a body immediately, do not ball watch, grip the opponent's jumper legally to stay tight.

Progression/Regression: Blow the whistle unexpectedly during a fast break to test reaction times.

Drill 39: Pushing Wide - Defensive Transition

Objective: Denying the corridor on the counter-attack.

Setup: Half ground, full team setup.

Progression/Description: Attackers transition from defense. The midfield unit must dynamically drop back and form a wall across the center square, forcing the attackers to kick to the boundary flanks.

Coaching Points: Drop back quickly, communicate the line to hold, stay square to the ball carrier.

Progression/Regression: Allow the attackers an extra player to try and break the wall through overlap running.

Drill 40: Forward 50 Lock In - Defensive Transition

Objective: Keeping the ball in the attacking zone.

Setup: Forward 50 arc, 6 forwards, 6 defenders.

Progression/Description: Coach simulates a point or turnover deep in the pocket. The forwards must violently apply frontal pressure to stop the defenders from exiting the 50m arc easily.

Coaching Points: Man the mark aggressively, cut off the short 15m options, tackle to hurt (legally).

Progression/Regression: The drill ends only when the forwards force a holding-the-ball free kick or a stoppage.

Drill 41: 6v6 Half Ground - Match Simulations

Objective: Applying all skills in a controlled match environment.

Setup: Half ground, 12 players.

Progression/Description: Standard 6v6 match play restricted to one half of the ground. Focus is on maintaining structure with fewer numbers, forcing players to run hard to create options.

Coaching Points: Maintain forward/defense balance, use the width of the ground, communicate constantly.

Progression/Regression: Restrict players to a maximum of 3 seconds in possession to force quick decisions.

Drill 42: Coast to Coast Transition - Match Simulations

Objective: Moving the ball full length without a stoppage.

Setup: Full ground, 18 players (10 attackers, 8 defenders).

Progression/Description: Attackers start in the defensive goal square and must work the ball entirely into the forward 50 to score a goal, facing a numerical disadvantage but vast space.

Coaching Points: Hit targets cleanly, look for the corridor switch, maintain run and carry.

Progression/Regression: Add a time limit of 30 seconds to reach the forward 50 arc.

Drill 43: Last 2 Minutes Scenario - Match Simulations

Objective: Game management under pressure.

Setup: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

Progression/Description: The scoreboard is set: Team A is down by 4 points with 2 minutes remaining. Play out the scenario. Team A must attack aggressively; Team B must chew the clock and force stoppages.

Coaching Points: Team A needs to take risks and play on. Team B needs to kick to the boundary and slow the game down.

Progression/Regression: Change the scenario to Team A being up by 1 point deep in defense.

Drill 44: Overloading the Midfield - Match Simulations

Objective: Adapting to loose men around the ball.

Setup: Center bounce setup, 7v5 in the middle.

Progression/Description: One team commits an extra two players to the stoppage, leaving their forward line empty. The under-manned team must adapt their defensive structure to survive the stoppage and rebound to the open forward line.

Coaching Points: Under-manned team must stay goal-side, do not panic, exploit the open forward line once possession is won.

Progression/Regression: Start the drill from a boundary throw-in instead of a center bounce.

Drill 45: Kick-in Defensive Setup - Match Simulations

Objective: Setting up the zone for opposition behinds.

Setup: Defensive 50, standard full team setup.

Progression/Description: Opposition scores a behind. Defending team sets up their designated kick-in play (e.g., clearing out the pocket, switching to the flank).

Coaching Points: Fast movement to positions, kicker must disguise their intent, receivers must lead into the space simultaneously.

Progression/Regression: Bring the man on the mark closer to the top of the square to increase pressure on the kicker.

Drill 46: Kick-in Attacking Press - Match Simulations

Objective: Defending the opposition's kick-in.

Setup: Forward 50, full team setup.

Progression/Description: Your team scores a behind. Immediately transition into a full ground zone to trap the opposition kick-in.

Coaching Points: Lock down the corridor immediately, force them long to a contest, bring the ball to ground if out-marked.

Progression/Regression: Mandate that the opposition must kick the ball back in within 5 seconds to test rapid setup.

Drill 47: Fast Break Counter - Match Simulations

Objective: Scoring quickly from a turnover.

Setup: Full ground, scattered players.

Progression/Description: Coach blows the whistle, simulating a turnover at half back. The attacking team has 15 seconds to stream forward, exploit the disorganized defense, and take a shot on goal.

Coaching Points: Play on instantly, forwards must separate from their defenders immediately, hit the first available leading target.

Progression/Regression: Limit the attacking team to kicks only to force long, accurate passing.

Drill 48: Slow Play Structure - Match Simulations

Objective: Maintaining possession when there are no forward options.

Setup: Center square to forward 50, 8v8.

Progression/Description: The ball carrier marks at half forward, but all forwards are closely checked. The team must chip the ball backward and laterally to maintain possession until a forward option opens up.

Coaching Points: Patience, hit the uncontested short targets, wait for the defense to shift and open a hole.

Progression/Regression: Penalize the team if they kick into a contested pack inside 50 during this drill.

Drill 49: Red Zone Scoring - Match Simulations

Objective: Efficiency inside the forward 50.

Setup: Forward 50m arc only, 6 forwards, 6 defenders.

Progression/Description: Ball is fed repeatedly into the 50m arc. Forwards must work together to isolate defenders, win groundballs, and snap accurately at goal under immense pressure.

Coaching Points: Front and center at all marking contests, walk to the mark quickly, selfless handballs to players in better scoring positions.

Progression/Regression: Remove two forwards (4v6) to force extreme precision and efficiency.

Drill 50: Full Field 18v18 Scrimmage - Match Simulations

Objective: Full match conditioning and structural review.

Setup: Full ground, 36 players.

Progression/Description: A standard 15-minute quarter of match simulation. The coach operates as the central umpire but occasionally blows the whistle to freeze play and correct structural positioning instantly.

Coaching Points: Enforce the 6-6-6 structures, praise correct decision-making loops, highlight off-the-ball running.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a "next goal wins" sudden-death scenario for the final 5 minutes to elevate the intensity.

UNDER 16's

Under 16s Coaching Best Practices

At the Under 16s level, players are transitioning from purely developmental phases into high-performance, senior-pathway football. Technical execution is largely established; the coaching focus must now shift entirely toward tactical intelligence, structured team defense, and the physical conditioning required to execute game plans under extreme fatigue. This is where elite habits are formed.

Implementing Complex Defensive Structures

The modern game relies heavily on collective team defense rather than isolated man-on-man matchups.

* **The Web Defense:** Teach players to defend space relative to the location of the football. The ground should be viewed as a grid. When the ball moves to a wing, the weak-side wingman and half-forward do not stay on their direct opponents; they fold into the corridor to choke the 45-degree exit kick.

* **The Forward-Half Press:** To lock the ball in your forward half, the midfield and half-back lines must push up aggressively behind the forward 50 entry. If the opposition wins possession, your half-backs must hold a high line (e.g., 60-70 meters from goal) to intercept clearing kicks.

Offensive Transition Models

Ball movement must be purposeful, fast, and heavily reliant on structural cues.

* **Corridor Triggers:** The primary directive upon winning a turnover at half-back is to look inboard immediately. Train your players to scan for the 45-degree kick into the center square before the opposition can set their defensive web. The corridor trigger relies on midfielders working relentlessly to provide an overlapping run through the center.

* **Boundary Switches:** If the corridor is denied, players must recognize the cue to switch the play. A slow down-the-line kick plays into a defensive press. Instead, use rapid, lateral kicking across the defensive 50 to shift the opposition's defensive block, aiming to transition up the weak-side boundary before the defense can slide across.

Managing High-Tempo Training and Visual Cues

To execute these systems, training must replicate match-day intensity with zero downtime. High-tempo blocks should integrate conditioning directly into ball-movement drills, eliminating the need for isolated running. Because verbal communication is often lost in chaotic, noisy game environments, train players to use visual tactical cues. A half-forward raising an arm can signal a clearing out of the 50-meter arc, while a defender pointing laterally initiates a switch of play. When calibrating full-ground scenarios at your local facility, factor in the specific wing dimensions to accurately replicate match-day boundary constraints and teach players exactly how much width they have to operate within.

Maximizing Match-Realistic Scenarios

Under 16s must learn to operate within the 'Observe, Orient, Decide, Act' (OODA) loop under immense physical duress. Drills should frequently start with players in a fatigued state—such as following a 40-meter sprint—forcing them to gather a contested ball, assess their options, and execute a high-pressure disposal. Integrate strict time limits for ball movement and enforce penalties for stagnant play to build cognitive endurance.

THE 50-DRILL LIBRARY

DRILL 1: CONTINUOUS 4-BALL WEAVE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Fast-paced ball circulation, spatial awareness, and early decision-making.

SETUP: 25x25m grid, 16 players, 4 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players move continuously inside the grid. The 4 balls are handballed constantly among players. On the coach's whistle, players currently holding a ball drop it, sprint to touch an outside boundary cone, and return to collect a different ball to resume play.

COACHING POINTS: Demand the ball early, receive on the move, scan the entire grid to avoid collisions, punch through the football on disposal.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 passive defenders wearing bibs to force rapid directional changes and vision checks.

DRILL 2: REACTION AGILITY SQUARE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: First-step explosiveness and clean hands under rapid directional shifts.

SETUP: 15x15m grid with a center cone, 8 players, 2 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player kicks from a corner to a player leading to the center cone. The receiver must react to a directional call (left or right) from the coach instantly upon marking, accelerating out to the corresponding corner and delivering a handball.

COACHING POINTS: Secure the ball before turning, maintain a low center of gravity on the cut, explode out of the pivot.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Have the receiver collect a bouncing ball instead of a clean mark.

DRILL 3: OVERLAP RUN AND CARRY - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Sustaining speed while chaining handballs downfield.

SETUP: 60m channel, groups of 3, 1 football per group.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Three players sprint the length of the channel. The ball carrier executes a handball to the outside runner, then immediately sprints behind them to become the next overlap option. The sequence continues end-to-end without breaking stride.

COACHING POINTS: Keep your momentum moving forward, deliver the ball out in front of the receiver, communicate clearly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that the final disposal must be a full-speed drop punt to a coach.

DRILL 4: TRAFFIC LIGHT TRANSITION - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Cognitive processing combined with agility.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 10 players, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players circulate the ball via hand. The coach holds up colored cones. Green means play on. Yellow means the ball carrier must hold the ball and evade pressure for 3 seconds. Red means the ball must immediately be placed on the ground for another player to scoop.

COACHING POINTS: Eyes up constantly checking the coach, react instantly to the visual cue, protect the football.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a blue cone that dictates an immediate 20-meter kick to a moving target.

DRILL 5: PERIPHERAL VISION GRID - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Scanning the field while under physical fatigue.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 12 players divided into 3 teams of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Two teams work together to keep possession using handballs against the third team. Players must verbally call out the color of the bib of the person they are disposing to before the ball leaves their hands.

COACHING POINTS: Scan before receiving the ball, quick hands, constant movement to create angles.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict possession to a maximum of 2 seconds per player.

DRILL 6: RUCK-ROVE DYNAMIC BURST - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Timing the run to a moving target and accelerating away.

SETUP: 20m space, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A (simulating a ruck) tosses the ball high in front of them. Player B (rover) times their run to receive the ball at the exact apex of the bounce, accelerating past Player A without breaking stride.

COACHING POINTS: Read the flight and bounce, do not decelerate on approach, snatch the ball with clean hands.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A provides passive physical bumping on Player B as they collect the ball.

DRILL 7: ONE-TOUCH GROUNDBALL GATHER - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Elite groundball mechanics at high speed.

SETUP: 40m zig-zag course, individual players, multiple footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach rolls balls hard along the ground at various angles.

Players sprint, collect the ball cleanly with one touch, and execute a 15-meter handball to a stationary target before moving to the next rolling ball.

COACHING POINTS: Get your body over the ball, drive through with the legs, one clean motion from ground to disposal.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Roll the balls erratically to create unpredictable bounces.

DRILL 8: DECISION-MAKING HANDBALLS - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Choosing the correct option under numerical pressure.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 3 attackers, 2 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers enter the grid with the ball. Defenders press immediately. Attackers must use fast hands to draw the defenders and release the unmarked third player to exit the opposite side of the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Draw the man before giving the ball, support the ball carrier from behind, execute firm handballs.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Make it 4v3 to increase the cognitive load and spatial congestion.

DRILL 9: SHUTTLE SPRINT TO CONTEST - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Executing fundamental skills under heavy cardiovascular load.

SETUP: 20m sprint lane, pairs, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players start flat on their backs. On the whistle, they sprint 20m out, touch a cone, sprint back, and instantly engage in a 1v1 wrestling contest for a football rolled in by the coach.

COACHING POINTS: Push through the fatigue, establish body position early, keep your feet in the contest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the sprint distance to 40m before the contest.

DRILL 10: RAPID FIRE TARGET KICKING - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: High-volume kicking efficiency.

SETUP: 30m lane, 4 players, 2 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Two players stand 30m apart. The other two players work back and forth between them, receiving a handball, pivoting, and kicking back to the start. The movement is continuous and high-speed.

COACHING POINTS: Quick transition from hands to boot, balance on the non-kicking foot, hit the target lace-out.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every second kick must be on the non-preferred foot.

DRILL 11: 45-DEGREE CORRIDOR TRIGGER - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Breaking the defensive line by aggressively using the corridor.

SETUP: Half ground, 8 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play starts at half-back. The ball carrier looks wide first, then instantly pivots to hit a leading target cutting 45-degrees into the corridor. The receiver plays on immediately and drives the ball forward.

COACHING POINTS: The corridor lead must be timed perfectly, the kicker must disguise the pass, receiver must not prop or stop upon marking.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a floating defender in the corridor to force the kicker to adjust the trajectory of the pass.

DRILL 12: BOUNDARY SWITCH PIVOT - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Shifting the opposition zone to attack the weak side.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to center wing, full width, 10 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Ball starts deep in the defensive pocket. Players execute two rapid lateral kicks across the face of the defensive 50, finding a running player on the opposite half-back flank who transitions the ball up the open wing.

COACHING POINTS: Speed of ball movement is critical, kicks must be flat and hard, the weak-side runner must anticipate the switch early.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a time limit of 8 seconds to complete the switch and cross the 50m arc.

DRILL 13: LOWERING THE EYES FORWARD ENTRY - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Identifying high-percentage targets inside 50 instead of bombing long.

SETUP: Center square to forward 50, 4 midfielders, 4 forwards, 3 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Midfielders win a clearance and stream forward. Forwards make intersecting leads. The ball carrier must ignore the deepest option and hit a leading half-forward 30-40 meters from goal.

COACHING POINTS: Midfielders must steady before kicking, forwards must create separation, prioritize the chest mark over a contested pack.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The defenders are instructed to drop back and clog the goal square, forcing the short kick.

DRILL 14: ZIG-ZAG TRANSITION GRID - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Moving the ball linearly using angled kicks.

SETUP: 70m length, 4 zones marked out, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball must be moved from zone 1 to zone 4. A player cannot kick straight ahead; every disposal must be angled diagonally to a player in the next zone, creating a zig-zag pattern down the field.

COACHING POINTS: Open the shoulders to the target, push off the mark instantly, receivers must lead into the space, not at the ball carrier.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add token pressure on the kicker to force faster execution.

DRILL 15: REBOUND 50 EXIT PATTERNS - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Structured exits from deep defense.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 6 defenders, 4 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Fullback kicks in from the goal square. Defenders execute a pre-planned exit strategy (e.g., long to the pocket, switch to the flank). They must link up and carry the ball past the 50m arc.

COACHING POINTS: Utilize the full width of the square, block for the designated receiver, always provide a safety release handball option.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Attackers start in a rigid zone defense that the defenders must navigate through.

DRILL 16: SWITCH AND PENETRATE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Combining lateral movement with an immediate aggressive forward thrust.

SETUP: Half ground, 10 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play starts on the wing. The ball is kicked laterally to the center square. The receiver instantly plays on and delivers a penetrating 50-meter kick to a forward leading up the opposite side of the ground.

COACHING POINTS: The central receiver must know what they are doing before they mark the ball, open up the field of vision, weight the deep kick perfectly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Put a physical tagger on the central receiver.

DRILL 17: OVERLAP HALF-BACK DRIVE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Generating numerical superiority from half-back.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to half forward, 5v3 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: 5 defenders work against 3 forwards. A defender wins a groundball and immediately takes off. Teammates must spread and provide overlapping run-and-carry options to break through the first line of defense.

COACHING POINTS: Do not run away from the ball carrier, run past them to receive the handball, commit the opposition before releasing the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the defenders to bounce the ball at least twice during the transition.

DRILL 18: THE CORRIDOR FUNNEL - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Forcing the ball into the most dangerous part of the ground.

SETUP: Half ground, cones funneling from the boundary to the center square.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players must transition the ball from deep defense. They are only allowed to kick the ball into the designated funnel zone in the center of the ground. Any kick wide of the funnel is a turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Be brave with the inboard kick, receivers must protect the drop zone, work relentlessly to present in the corridor.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Tighten the width of the funnel to demand higher precision kicking.

DRILL 19: DEEP POCKET EXTRACTION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Escaping a high-pressure trap deep in defense.

SETUP: Defensive pocket, 4v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is locked in the defensive pocket. Defenders must use short, sharp handballs to maneuver out of the immediate congestion before finding a short kicking target on the half-back flank.

COACHING POINTS: Keep a cool head, use the boundary line as protection, execute the first handball perfectly to relieve pressure.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 5th attacker to create a severe overload trap.

DRILL 20: 3-MAN WAVE TRANSITION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Synchronized forward running patterns.

SETUP: Full length of the ground, groups of 3.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Three players transition the ball end-to-end. One player stays wide, one stays central, one crosses behind. They must exchange the ball seamlessly using both kicks and handballs without any player stopping forward momentum.

COACHING POINTS: Communication is vital, time your leads so you do not wait for the ball, maintain structural spacing.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 2 chasing defenders who start 15 meters behind the wave.

DRILL 21: INSIDE CONTEST 3V3 - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Winning the hard ball under severe physical pressure.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 3v3 setup, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws the ball into the center of the grid. The two groups of three engage physically, attempting to win the contested ball, extract it from the congestion, and handball it cleanly out of the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Get your hips lower than the opposition, protect the ball carrier, block off the ball to create an exit lane.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach calls out specific player names who are not allowed to touch the ball, forcing them to be purely blockers.

DRILL 22: RUCK TO ADVANTAGE CLEARANCE - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Exploiting dominant ruck work.

SETUP: Center circle setup, 1 ruck, 3 mids per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Ruckman intentionally taps the ball to a pre-determined zone. The designated sweeping midfielder must time their run perfectly to take the ball on the burst and break the lines.

COACHING POINTS: Midfielders must disguise their intent, ruckman must dictate the drop zone, the receiver must not break stride.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruckman is allowed to grab the sweeping midfielder immediately if the tap is poor.

DRILL 23: DEFENSIVE STOPPAGE SETUP - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Organizing structure to prevent forward entries.

SETUP: Defensive 50 stoppage, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Simulating a ball-up in the defensive arc. The defending team must set up their defensive side structure, ensuring the corridor is blocked and the opposition is forced toward the boundary if they win the clearance.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the defensive side fiercely, body up on your direct opponent, communicate who is sweeping behind.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team starts with possession and must attempt to break the defensive structure from a static start.

DRILL 24: OFFENSIVE BOUNDARY THROW-IN - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Generating a shot on goal from a forward stoppage.

SETUP: Forward pocket boundary line, 4v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach acts as boundary umpire. The attacking team aims to win the tap, execute a quick handball chain to the top of the 50m arc, and snap a shot on goal within 5 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Lock the ball in if the tap is lost, prioritize front position, the receiver at the top of the arc must call loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict the attacking team to one handball only before a shot must be taken.

DRILL 25: TACKLING FORM AND EXTRACTION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Executing dominant tackles and releasing the ball while being tackled.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A has the ball. Player B engages in a heavy, legal tackle. Player A must maintain their footing, keep their arms free, and execute a legal handball to a coach on the outside.

COACHING POINTS: Player B must pin one arm and drive through the hips. Player A must brace, turn their body to shield the ball, and get the hands up early.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A starts on their knees and must stand up through the tackle.

DRILL 26: THE SHARK AND BURST - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Anticipating the opposition tap and countering.

SETUP: Center bounce, 1 dominant opposition ruck, 3 defensive mids.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The opposition ruck is guaranteed to win the tap. The defensive mids must read the ruckman's hands, intercept the tap (sharking), and immediately burst forward into open space.

COACHING POINTS: Watch the ruckman's eyes, stay light on your feet, accelerate instantly upon securing the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck fakes the tap to draw the mids offside before tapping elsewhere.

DRILL 27: CENTER SQUARE SETUP 6-6-6 - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Understanding modern center bounce restrictions and strategies.

SETUP: Center square, full 6-6-6 team setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach conducts a center bounce. The midfield group must execute a set play to win the clearance, while forwards and defenders maintain their strict positional requirements until the ball clears the square.

COACHING POINTS: Wingmen must hold their width, forwards must lead into the space created by the clearance, defenders must stay goal-side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The clearance must result in an uncontested mark inside 50 to be deemed successful.

DRILL 28: CONGESTED HANDBALL CHAINS - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Maintaining possession in extreme traffic.

SETUP: 12x12m grid, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Both teams are confined to a tiny grid. The objective is to string together 6 consecutive handballs without the opposition intercepting or tackling the ball carrier to the ground.

COACHING POINTS: Constant movement, short and sharp handballs, protect the ball with your body, use your voice constantly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Shrink the grid to 10x10m to create absolute chaos.

DRILL 29: SHIELDING AND MARKING UNDER HEAT - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Taking contested marks with heavy physical contact.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 2 defenders, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The kicker drops a high ball into the grid. The attacker must hold off both defenders, protect the drop zone using their body, and take a strong contested mark.

COACHING POINTS: Read the flight early, establish a wide base, use the arms to fend off legally, bring the ball to the chest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The defenders are allowed to use bumping pads to apply heavier force.

DRILL 30: GROUND BALL TO OUTNUMBER - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Winning the ball and immediately exploiting a numerical advantage.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 4 attackers, 3 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach rolls a ball into dispute. The attackers must win the 4v3 groundball contest, immediately identify the loose man, and execute an uncontested pass.

COACHING POINTS: The first player to the ball must be violent at the contest, the loose man must hold their space and not get sucked in.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the attackers facing away from the ball to test reaction time.

DRILL 31: 18-MAN WEB DEFENSE SETUP - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Teaching full-ground structural defense and spatial coverage.

SETUP: Full ground, 18 defenders, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coach stands in the center square with the ball. As the coach runs to different areas of the ground, the entire 18-man team must shift and slide to maintain the web structure, blocking corridors and prioritizing dangerous space over direct opponents.

COACHING POINTS: Keep the gaps between lines tight, point and talk constantly, wingmen must drop back to cover the switch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 6 attackers to run decoy lines and test the defenders' discipline.

DRILL 32: FORWARD HALF PRESS LOCK-IN - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Preventing the opposition from clearing the ball from defense.

SETUP: Forward half, 10 forwards/mids, 8 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders try to exit their defensive 50. The attacking team pushes up high, locking down all short options and forcing the defenders to kick long to a contested outnumber on the wing.

COACHING POINTS: High half-forwards must push up the ground, maintain a structural wall across the 50m arc, tackle with ferocity.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The defenders have 15 seconds to exit the half or the drill resets with a penalty.

DRILL 33: INTERCEPT MARKING AND REBOUND - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Reading the play, peeling off an opponent, and counter-attacking.

SETUP: Half-back flank, 3 defenders, 3 attackers, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker aims for a leading attacker. The designated intercept defender must leave their man, read the flight, take the intercept mark, and instantly play on to hit a rebounding teammate.

COACHING POINTS: Back your judgment, attack the ball at its highest point, do not hesitate once you leave your opponent.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker deliberately kicks low and flat to make the intercept more difficult.

DRILL 34: DEFENSIVE SLIDING GRID - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Covering for teammates who leave their zone to apply pressure.

SETUP: 40x40m grid divided into 4 quadrants, 4v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to maintain possession. When a defender leaves their quadrant to double-team the ball carrier, the adjacent defender must slide over to cover the dangerous space left behind.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be loud and early, head on a swivel, anticipate the movement of the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 5th attacker to ensure there is always a loose man the defense must scramble to cover.

DRILL 35: TURNOVER TRANSITION SPRINT - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Immediate reaction from offense to defense upon losing possession.

SETUP: Half ground, 8v8 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Teams play normal scrimmage. When the coach blows a sharp whistle, the team in possession must drop the ball. They instantly transition to defense, finding a man and setting a zone within 3 seconds while the other team attacks.

COACHING POINTS: Do not drop your head on a turnover, find a body immediately, sprint back to goal-side position.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: If a player fails to find a man within 3 seconds, they are removed from the drill for one minute.

DRILL 36: CORRIDOR DENIAL SYSTEM - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Forcing the opposition to play slow, boundary-line football.

SETUP: Center square and both wings, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to move the ball from half-back to half-forward. Defenders must set up a wall entirely blocking the center square, forcing all ball movement out wide to the boundary line.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the line, do not get drawn out of the corridor, shepherd the ball carrier toward the boundary.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Award the attacking team triple points if they successfully transition the ball through the center square.

DRILL 37: SMOTHER, CHASE, AND TACKLE - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Relentless desperation defense on the kicker.

SETUP: 30m lane, 1 kicker, 2 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker takes the ball and runs toward a target. Defender 1 approaches from the front to attempt a smother. If the kicker evades, Defender 2 chases from behind to execute a run-down tackle.

COACHING POINTS: Defender 1 must commit fully to the smother block. Defender 2 must close the gap with maximum speed and drag down by the hips safely.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker has a 3-second time limit to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 38: MAN-ON-MAN ACCOUNTABILITY SWITCH - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Tight checking and physical accountability.

SETUP: 50x50m grid, 8v8 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players are matched up strictly man-on-man. The attacking team tries to keep possession. Defenders must stay within 1 meter of their direct opponent at all times. If an attacker receives the ball unmarked, the drill stops and the defense is penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Use legal physical contact to stay close, watch the player's hips to anticipate movement, never ball-watch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach randomly calls "SWITCH," and all defenders must instantly find a new opponent to cover.

DRILL 39: DEFENSIVE EXIT TRAP - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Using the boundary line to trap the opposition deep in defense.

SETUP: Defensive pocket, 3 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to run the ball out of the pocket. Defenders must angle their approach to corral the attackers toward the boundary line, closing off all inboard options and forcing a stoppage or out-of-bounds.

COACHING POINTS: Angle your body to deny the inside lane, tackle aggressively when they run out of space, use the boundary as an extra defender.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the space to the half-back flank to make the trapping harder.

DRILL 40: DEEP DEFENSIVE SCRAMBLE - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Desperate defending in the goal square to prevent a score.

SETUP: Defensive goal square, 4 forwards, 4 defenders, 1 coach.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach bombs the ball high and chaotic into the goal square. Defenders must spoil the ball away from the danger zone, follow up at ground level, and rush the ball behind for a minor score if necessary.

COACHING POINTS: Spoil with a closed fist to the boundary, never punch the ball back into the corridor, put your body on the line.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the ball hard along the ground to simulate a snapped shot on goal.

DRILL 41: 6-6-6 CENTER BOUNCE RESET - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Perfecting structural setups and instant transitions.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Standard center bounce. Both teams execute their 6-6-6 structures. Once the ball clears the square, play continues for 1 minute. The coach then blows the whistle, and all players have 15 seconds to sprint back to their exact starting 6-6-6 positions.

COACHING POINTS: High physical demand, maintain structural integrity when fatigued, communicate positioning as you run back.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Reduce the reset time to 10 seconds to increase cardiovascular pressure.

DRILL 42: RED TIME SCENARIO (PROTECTING THE LEAD) - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Game management and structural discipline in the dying minutes.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Team A leads by 5 points with 3 minutes left on the clock. Team A must employ a slow, possession-based style, kicking down the line and forcing stoppages. Team B must take extreme risks through the corridor to score quickly.

COACHING POINTS: Team A: kill the clock, no risky kicks, numbers behind the ball. Team B: play on at all costs, lower the eyes inside 50.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Adjust the scoreboard to Team A trailing by 2 points to practice emergency attacking.

DRILL 43: COAST-TO-COAST FAST BREAK - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Seamless transition from deep defense to a shot on goal.

SETUP: Full ground, 12 attackers, 8 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers start with a kick-in from full back. They must move the ball the entire length of the field and score a goal within 20 seconds, utilizing their numerical advantage.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless forward running, hit targets on the chest, do not slow down the play to wait for leads.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Decrease the time limit to 15 seconds to force a highly direct, corridor-based attack.

DRILL 44: SLOW PLAY POSSESSION MAINTENANCE - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Controlling the tempo of the game when trailing or needing to rest.

SETUP: Full ground, 15v15 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: One team is instructed to maintain possession for 2 full minutes without scoring or turning the ball over. They must use lateral and backward kicks, switching the play constantly to deny the opposition the ball.

COACHING POINTS: Patience, hit uncontested targets only, present wide options, do not kick to a contest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: If the team in possession kicks the ball forward of center, they lose possession instantly.

DRILL 45: FORWARD 50 EFFICIENCY (RED ZONE) - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing scoring opportunities under severe pressure.

SETUP: Forward 50m arc, 8 forwards, 10 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is continuously fed into the forward 50. The forwards operate with a numerical disadvantage and must use intelligent leads, screens, and elite groundball skills to manufacture shots on goal.

COACHING POINTS: Work for your teammates, block for the primary leading forward, snap quickly from stoppages.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every shot on goal must be from within 30 meters to force better passing inside the arc.

DRILL 46: OUTNUMBERED DEFENSIVE STANDS - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Defending structurally when caught out of position.

SETUP: Defensive half, 5 defenders, 8 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers stream forward from the center bounce. The 5 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack down, forcing wide kicks and delaying the entry until theoretical reinforcements arrive.

COACHING POINTS: Do not commit to a tackle unless you are certain to stick it, guard the most dangerous space, force them to the boundary.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 2 trailing defenders who enter the drill 5 seconds after it begins.

DRILL 47: OVERLOAD ATTACKING WAVES - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Overwhelming the opposition defense with numbers.

SETUP: Full ground, 15 attackers, 10 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers work the ball forward. They must ensure that at every contest or marking situation, they have at least one loose player running past to receive a handball.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless work rate, the loose man must demand the ball loudly, overwhelm the defense with overlap running.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the attackers to score a goal without any player taking a bounce.

DRILL 48: KICK-IN DEFENSIVE TRAP - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Setting up a full-ground press to force a turnover from a kick-in.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Opposition takes a kick-in. The defending team implements a strict zone, manning up the long boundary options and clogging the corridor, aiming to force a panic kick and generate a turnover inside the forward half.

COACHING POINTS: Hold your zone, anticipate the kicker's eyes, squeeze the ground to suffocate their exit options.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team is only allowed to use kicks to exit the defensive 50.

DRILL 49: KICK-IN OFFENSIVE REBOUND - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Breaking through a high defensive press safely.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Your team takes a kick-in against a set zone. Players must execute decoy leads to clear space, utilize the short pocket options, and rapidly switch the play to break through the first line of the press.

COACHING POINTS: The kicker must be decisive, receivers must lead with intent, immediately look to play on from the first mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The player taking the kick-in has only 5 seconds to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 50: FULL GROUND SCRIMMAGE (15-MINUTE BLOCK) - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Consolidating all tactical and structural concepts in a live match environment.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players, full umpire crew.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: A relentless 15-minute block of unrestricted match play. The coach monitors from the center square, stopping play only for critical structural errors or to reset specific scenarios (e.g., calling a sudden stoppage in a dangerous position).

COACHING POINTS: Demand elite standards, enforce team rules violently, praise correct decision-making loops, highlight off-the-ball work rate.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a rule where any defensive turnover immediately results in a 50-meter penalty against the offending team to maximize the pressure on ball movement.

UNDER 18

Under 18s Coaching Best Practices

Preparing an Under 18s squad for senior football requires a fundamental shift in coaching philosophy. At this stage, players are physically maturing and tactically aware; your role transitions from a teacher of fundamental skills to an elite high-performance manager. The focus must be on executing AFL-standard game plans, handling immense physical pressure, and making autonomous decisions under severe cardiovascular fatigue. When you are running these sessions, the physical and cognitive load must mirror exactly what they will face stepping up into the senior side.

The tactical systems at this level are sophisticated. Implementing a full-ground 18-man defensive web requires players to understand spatial mapping rather than simple man-on-man accountability. They must learn to squeeze the ground, suffocate the opposition's exit kicks, and read the cues to drop a spare man behind the ball. Offensively, ball

movement must be aggressive and calculated. The corridor is king. Training must ingrain the instinct to look inboard immediately upon winning a turnover, utilizing overlap run and elite foot skills to break defensive zones before they can set.

To achieve this, high-tempo training blocks are mandatory. There is no downtime. Conditioning is built directly into the drills through high-speed running metrics and repeat anaerobic efforts. You must enforce severe accountability for decision-making errors, forcing players to execute their OODA (Observe, Orient, Decide, Act) loops in fractions of a second. If a player holds the ball too long or misses a structural cue during a match simulation, the entire team must understand why the breakdown occurred. This is the final step in their youth development; demand senior-level discipline, elite communication, and uncompromising physical execution.

The 50-Drill Library

DRILL 1: CONTINUOUS 6-BALL COGNITION - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Extreme cognitive load and spatial awareness during high-speed ball circulation.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 18 players, 6 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players move continuously, maintaining 6 footballs in motion via handballs. The coach calls visual or verbal cues. "Switch" means all balls must instantly change direction. "Drop" means players leave their current ball and sprint to find a new one.

COACHING POINTS: Keep your head on a swivel, demand the ball early, execute the disposal firmly, anticipate collisions.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 4 passive defenders to disrupt running lanes and force tighter handballs.

DRILL 2: REACTIVE SPRINT AND GATHER - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Explosive first-step acceleration and clean possession under fatigue.

SETUP: 25m sprint lane, pairs, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players start on their stomachs facing away from the coach. The coach kicks the ball unpredictably over their heads and blows the whistle. Players must scramble up, locate the ball in flight, and sprint to gather it cleanly off the deck before their partner.

COACHING POINTS: Explode off the ground, take the most direct line, protect the drop zone with your body.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the players tangled together to simulate extracting from a stoppage before the sprint.

DRILL 3: THE 4-MAN OVERLAP ENGINE - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Perfecting the mechanics of the overlap run at top speed.

SETUP: Full length of the center square, groups of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Group starts at one end. The ball carrier moves forward and handballs to a runner bursting past. The original carrier must immediately sprint to get to the outside of the chain to receive the ball again. The sequence continues unbroken to the opposite side.

COACHING POINTS: Do not break stride, deliver the handball out in front, vocalize your run aggressively.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Force the final disposal to be a 40-meter penetrating kick to a leading target.

DRILL 4: SPLIT-SECOND DECISION GRID - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Executing correct disposal types based on instant visual cues.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 12 players, colored cones.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players circulate the ball. The coach holds up colored cones. Red requires an immediate handball backward. Blue requires a 15-meter kick. Green requires the player to bounce the ball once before disposing.

COACHING POINTS: Scan the coach before receiving, react instantly, maintain technical precision despite the cognitive load.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a strict 2-second disposal limit from the moment the ball is received.

DRILL 5: PERIPHERAL TARGET IDENTIFICATION - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Expanding field vision while under physical pressure.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 10 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers maintain possession. Before disposing, the ball carrier must verbally call out the name of a teammate standing in their peripheral vision (not the person they are passing to).

COACHING POINTS: Open up your field of view, do not get tunnel vision on the receiver, keep the feet moving.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the number of defenders to 6 to compress the time available to scan.

DRILL 6: RUCK-ROVE EXPLOSION - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Timing the clearance run and hitting the contest at maximum velocity.

SETUP: 20m circle, 1 ruck, 3 rovers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruck taps the ball randomly into space. Rovers must hold their run until the ball is in flight, then explode through the drop zone, gather cleanly without breaking stride, and burst out of the circle.

COACHING POINTS: Read the ruck's hand placement, stay on your toes, snatch the ball cleanly at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a heavy bumping pad at the exit point of the circle that the rover must absorb.

DRILL 7: ELITE ONE-TOUCH GROUNDBALLS - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Flawless groundball mechanics at high speed.

SETUP: 50m zig-zag course, individual players, 5 footballs placed at intervals.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint the course. At each ball, they must scoop it cleanly with one hand, execute a rapid handball to a coach, and immediately accelerate to the next ball without decelerating.

COACHING POINTS: Get low through the hips, scoop cleanly, transition the ball to the disposal hand instantly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the balls erratically toward the player instead of them being stationary.

DRILL 8: CONGESTION EVASION - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Navigating tight traffic using agility and ball protection.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 5 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers must traverse from one side of the grid to the other. Defenders are instructed to bump and block, but not tackle. Attackers must use lateral steps, fends, and core strength to break through.

COACHING POINTS: Keep a wide base, use the hips to absorb contact, keep the football tucked tight.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Upgrade the defenders to full tackling pressure.

DRILL 9: SHUTTLE SPRINT TO WRESTLE - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Executing contested strength after heavy cardiovascular output.

SETUP: 30m sprint lane, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint 30m, touch a line, sprint back 15m, and instantly engage in a 1v1 grappling contest over a stationary football for 10 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Fight through the lung burn, establish low body position early, lock your core.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the initial sprint distance to 50m.

DRILL 10: RAPID FIRE PRECISION KICKING - ELITE HIGH-PERFORMANCE WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: High-volume, elite-level kicking efficiency.

SETUP: 40m lane, 6 players, 3 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players work back and forth in pairs over 40m. The movement is relentless. Receive the ball, take two steps, and deliver a flat, hard drop punt to the chest of the next runner.

COACHING POINTS: Fast transition from hands to boot, perfect ball drop, punch through the kick.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate non-preferred foot kicking for the entire drill.

DRILL 11: THE 45-DEGREE CORRIDOR DART - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Slicing through the first line of defense using aggressive inboard kicking.

SETUP: Half ground, 8 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play initiates at half-back. The ball carrier fakes wide, pivots, and hits a midfielder bursting 45-degrees into the corridor. The receiver must play on instantly and drive a long kick inside 50.

COACHING POINTS: The corridor runner must time the lead perfectly, the kicker must disguise the pass, execute with zero hesitation.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a floating intercept defender specifically guarding the 45-degree lane.

DRILL 12: LIGHTNING BOUNDARY SWITCH - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Rapid lateral ball movement to exploit the weak side of a zone.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to center wing, full width, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is trapped deep in a pocket. Players execute three rapid-fire lateral kicks across the defensive 50, ending with a half-back flanker streaming up the opposite, open wing.

COACHING POINTS: Ball speed is everything, kicks must be flat and hard, receivers must already be moving laterally before they mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Impose a strict 6-second time limit to move the ball from the pocket to the opposite wing.

DRILL 13: LOWERING THE EYES UNDER PRESSURE - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Identifying high-percentage targets inside 50 instead of defaulting to long bombs.

SETUP: Center square to forward 50, 5 midfielders, 5 forwards, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Midfielders break from a stoppage. Forwards execute staggered leads. The ball carrier must ignore the deep contest and hit a half-forward leading into a pocket 35 meters from goal.

COACHING POINTS: Steady yourself before kicking, forwards must demand the ball in space, prioritize the uncontested chest mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are instructed to zone off and clog the deep forward line, making the long bomb impossible.

DRILL 14: THE ZIG-ZAG TRANSITION MATRIX - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Advancing the ball linearly through angled passing lanes.

SETUP: 80m length divided into 4 grids, 16 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball must travel from grid 1 to grid 4. Direct vertical kicks are banned. Every disposal must be an angled diagonal pass to a player in the next grid, forcing the defense to constantly shift laterally.

COACHING POINTS: Open the shoulders early, push off the mark instantly, receivers must lead into the diagonal space.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add token pressure on every kicker to force rapid execution.

DRILL 15: ELITE REBOUND 50 EXITS - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Flawless execution of structured defensive exit patterns.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 7 defenders, 5 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Fullback takes a kick-in. Defenders execute a pre-rehearsed exit (e.g., clearing the pocket to switch to the center corridor). They must link up via hand and foot to cross the 50m arc.

COACHING POINTS: Exploit the full width of the ground, block aggressively for the designated receiver, always provide a safety release option.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Attackers set up in a rigid 15-meter zone that the defenders must carefully pick their way through.

DRILL 16: SWITCH, OVERLAP, AND PENETRATE - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Combining a lateral switch with an immediate numerical overload forward.

SETUP: Half ground, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play starts on the boundary. The ball is kicked laterally to the center. The receiver plays on, and two teammates instantly run past to provide overlap options. The ball is carried forward and driven deep into attack.

COACHING POINTS: The central receiver must scan before marking, overlap runners must hold their width, execute the final kick with penetration.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Apply a heavy physical tagger on the central receiver to disrupt the pivot.

DRILL 17: HALF-BACK WAVE DRIVE - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Breaking the lines from defense using relentless overlapping run.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to half forward, 6v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders win a loose ball. The ball carrier takes off, and teammates spread instantly to provide overlapping handball options, overwhelming the 4 forwards to break through the lines.

COACHING POINTS: Run past the ball carrier to receive, commit the opposition before releasing the handball, keep the chain moving at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the defensive unit to take at least three bounces during the transition.

DRILL 18: THE CORRIDOR CHOKE-POINT - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Forcing precise ball movement through the most congested, dangerous area of the ground.

SETUP: Half ground, narrow cones funneling through the center square.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players transition the ball from deep defense but are restricted to kicking only within the narrow central funnel. Any disposal wide of the funnel is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Be courageous with the inboard kick, receivers must absorb contact and protect the drop zone, midfielders must work relentlessly to present.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Narrow the funnel further to demand absolute elite kicking precision.

DRILL 19: DEEP DEFENSIVE EXTRACTION - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Escaping a high-pressure trap deep in the defensive pocket.

SETUP: Defensive pocket, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is locked deep. Defenders must use rapid, composed handballs to navigate out of the immediate congestion and find a short kicking target on the half-back flank to relieve the pressure.

COACHING POINTS: Maintain composure, use the boundary line to protect your blind side, execute the first handball perfectly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to create a severe numerical disadvantage for the defense.

DRILL 20: 3-MAN SEAMLESS TRANSITION - AFL-STANDARD BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Synchronized forward running patterns executed at maximum velocity.

SETUP: Full length of the ground, groups of 3.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Three players move the ball end-to-end. One stays wide, one central, one crosses behind. They must exchange the ball continuously without any player dropping their forward momentum.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be elite, time leads flawlessly, maintain the structural triangle spacing.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 2 chasing defenders starting 15 meters behind the group to enforce speed.

DRILL 21: ELITE INSIDE CONTEST 4V4 - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Dominating the hard ball and extracting it safely under severe physical pressure.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 4v4 setup, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws the ball into the grid. The groups engage in a heavy physical contest. The objective is to win the ball, extract it from the congestion, and hit a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Drop your hips lower than the opposition, block off the ball to create exit lanes, communicate who is taking the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach designates two players who are only allowed to block and cannot touch the ball.

DRILL 22: RUCK TO ADVANTAGE EXPLOITATION - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing clearances from a dominant ruck tap.

SETUP: Center circle, 1 ruck, 3 midfielders per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruckman taps the ball to a specific pre-called zone. The designated sweeping midfielder times their run to take the ball on the burst and break the lines instantly.

COACHING POINTS: Midfielders must disguise their starting positions, ruckman dictates the drop zone, the receiver must accelerate through the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck is permitted to physically hold the sweeping midfielder if the tap is inaccurate.

DRILL 23: DEFENSIVE BOUNDARY LOCKDOWN - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Structuring a stoppage to prevent opposition forward entries.

SETUP: Defensive 50 boundary throw-in, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Simulating a boundary throw-in. The defending team sets up a strict defensive structure, prioritizing the corridor block and forcing the opposition toward the boundary or into a secondary stoppage.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the defensive side fiercely, body up hard on direct opponents, communicate the sweeping roles clearly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team starts with possession and must attempt to break the defensive wall from a static start.

DRILL 24: OFFENSIVE POCKET SNAP - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Generating an immediate shot on goal from a forward pocket stoppage.

SETUP: Forward pocket boundary line, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach simulates a throw-in. The attacking team aims to win the tap, execute a quick handball chain to the top of the 50m arc, and snap a shot on goal within 6 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Lock the ball in if the clearance is lost, prioritize front position at the drop, the receiver at the arc must command the ball loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict the attacking team to a maximum of one handball before a shot must be taken.

DRILL 25: ELITE TACKLE AND RELEASE - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Executing dominant tackles and successfully releasing the ball while being tackled.

SETUP: 12x12m grid, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A holds the ball. Player B engages in a heavy, legal senior tackle. Player A must maintain footing, keep arms free, and execute a legal handball to a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Player B must pin an arm and drive through the hips. Player A must brace, turn to shield the ball, and elevate their hands early.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A starts on their knees and must power up through the tackle.

DRILL 26: THE SHARK AND ACCELERATE - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Anticipating the opposition's hit-out and intercepting the clearance.

SETUP: Center bounce, 1 dominant opposition ruck, 4 defensive midfielders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The opposition ruck is guaranteed to win the tap. The defensive mids must read the ruckman's body language, intercept the tap, and instantly burst forward into open space.

COACHING POINTS: Lock eyes on the ruckman's hands, stay light on your feet, accelerate the millisecond the ball is secured.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck fakes the tap to draw the mids offside before redirecting it.

DRILL 27: SENIOR 6-6-6 CENTER BOUNCE EXECUTION - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Mastering modern center bounce restrictions and set plays.

SETUP: Center square, full 6-6-6 team setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach conducts a center bounce. The midfield executes a pre-planned set play to win the clearance, while forwards and defenders hold strict positional discipline until the ball clears the square.

COACHING POINTS: Wingmen hold their width aggressively, forwards lead into the space created by the clearance, defenders remain goal-side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The clearance must result in a marked inside 50 entry to be deemed a success.

DRILL 28: EXTREME CONGESTION HANDBALLS - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Maintaining composed possession in severe traffic.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Both teams confined to a tiny grid. The objective is to string together 8 consecutive handballs without the opposition intercepting or tackling the ball carrier to the ground.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless movement, short and sharp handballs, protect the ball with your core, use your voice to command the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Shrink the grid to 8x8m to create absolute chaos.

DRILL 29: SHIELDING UNDER HEAVY HEAT - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Taking contested marks while absorbing heavy physical contact.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 2 defenders, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker drops a high ball into the grid. The attacker must hold off both defenders, protect the drop zone using sheer body strength, and take a strong contested mark.

COACHING POINTS: Read the flight early, establish a wide and immovable base, use the arms to fend off legally, bring the ball securely to the chest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are equipped with heavy bumping pads to apply maximum force on the attacker.

DRILL 30: GROUNDBALL OUTNUMBER EXPLOITATION - SENIOR STOPPAGE CRAFT

OBJECTIVE: Winning the hard ball and instantly exploiting a numerical advantage.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 5 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach rolls a ball into dispute. Attackers must win the 5v4 groundball contest, instantly locate their loose man, and execute an uncontested pass out of the congestion.

COACHING POINTS: The first player to the ball must be violent and decisive, the loose man must hold their space and avoid getting sucked into the pack.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the attackers facing away from the ball to test reaction speed.

DRILL 31: FULL GROUND 18-MAN WEB DEFENSE - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Mastering full-ground structural defense and spatial coverage.

SETUP: Full ground, 18 defenders, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coach moves around the ground with the ball. The entire 18-man defensive unit must shift, slide, and compress to maintain the web structure, prioritizing dangerous spaces and blocking the corridor.

COACHING POINTS: Keep the gaps between defensive lines tight, point and talk relentlessly, wingmen must drop back to cover the switch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 8 attackers to run decoy lines and test the structural discipline of the defense.

DRILL 32: FORWARD HALF SUFFOCATION PRESS - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Locking the ball in the attacking half to force turnovers.

SETUP: Forward half, 12 forwards/mids, 10 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders attempt to exit their defensive 50. The attacking team pushes up aggressively, locking down all short options and forcing the defenders to kick long to a contested outnumber.

COACHING POINTS: High half-forwards must push up to the arc, maintain a structural wall, tackle with absolute ferocity.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders have only 12 seconds to exit the half or the drill resets with a penalty.

DRILL 33: ELITE INTERCEPT AND REBOUND - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Reading the play, leaving an opponent, and launching a counter-attack.

SETUP: Half-back flank, 4 defenders, 4 attackers, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker targets a leading attacker. The designated intercept defender must peel off their man, read the flight, take the intercept mark, and instantly play on to a rebounding teammate.

COACHING POINTS: Back your judgment entirely, attack the ball at its highest point, never hesitate once you commit to leaving your opponent.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker deliberately drives the ball low and flat to compress the interception time.

DRILL 34: DEFENSIVE SLIDING MATRIX - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Seamlessly covering for teammates who leave their zone to apply pressure.

SETUP: 50x50m grid divided into 4 quadrants, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers move the ball. When a defender leaves their quadrant to double-team the ball carrier, the adjacent defender must instantly slide over to cover the dangerous space left behind.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be loud and proactive, head on a swivel, anticipate the lateral movement of the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to ensure there is always a loose man the defense must scramble to cover.

DRILL 35: INSTANT TURNOVER TRANSITION SPRINT - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Immediate physiological and tactical reaction from offense to defense.

SETUP: Half ground, 10v10 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Teams play normal scrimmage. On a sharp whistle blow, the team in possession must drop the ball and instantly transition to defense, finding a man and setting a zone within 4 seconds while the other team attacks.

COACHING POINTS: Do not drop your head, find a body immediately, sprint back to goal-side position.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Any player failing to find a man within 4 seconds is removed from the drill for one minute.

DRILL 36: CORRIDOR DENIAL LOCKDOWN - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Forcing the opposition into slow, boundary-line football.

SETUP: Center square and both wings, 8v8 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers attempt to move the ball from half-back to half-forward. Defenders set up an impenetrable wall across the center square, forcing all ball movement out wide to the boundary.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the line fiercely, do not get drawn out of the corridor, shepherd the ball carrier physically toward the boundary.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Award the attacking team triple points if they manage to pierce the center square wall.

DRILL 37: SMOTHER, CHASE, AND DESTROY - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Relentless desperation defense and second efforts on the kicker.

SETUP: 30m lane, 1 kicker, 2 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker runs toward a target. Defender 1 approaches from the front to attempt a block/smother. If the kicker evades, Defender 2 chases from behind to execute a ferocious run-down tackle.

COACHING POINTS: Defender 1 commits fully to the smother. Defender 2 closes the gap with maximum speed and drags down safely by the hips.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker has a strict 3-second limit to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 38: MAN-ON-MAN ACCOUNTABILITY GAUNTLET - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Uncompromising tight checking and physical accountability.

SETUP: 60x60m grid, 10v10 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Strict man-on-man matchups. The attacking team maintains possession. Defenders must stay within 1 meter of their direct opponent. If an attacker receives the ball unmarked, the defense is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Use legal physical contact to stay tight, watch the opponent's hips to anticipate cuts, never ball-watch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach yells "SWITCH," forcing all defenders to instantly locate and cover a new opponent.

DRILL 39: THE BOUNDARY TRAP SYSTEM - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Using the boundary line as a structural weapon to trap the opposition.

SETUP: Defensive pocket extending to the wing, 4 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to run the ball out of the pocket. Defenders angle their approach to corral the attackers toward the boundary line, closing all inboard passing lanes and forcing a stoppage or turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Angle your body to deny the inside lane, tackle aggressively when space runs out, use the line as an extra defender.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the space to the half-back flank to make the trapping more challenging.

DRILL 40: GOAL SQUARE DESPERATION SCRAMBLE - 18-MAN DEFENSIVE WEBS

OBJECTIVE: Elite desperation defending in the goal square to prevent a score.

SETUP: Defensive goal square, 5 forwards, 5 defenders, 1 coach.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach bombs the ball high into the goal square. Defenders must violently spoil the ball away from danger, follow up at ground level, and rush the ball behind for a minor score if necessary.

COACHING POINTS: Spoil with a closed fist to the boundary, never punch back into the corridor, put your body on the line.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the ball hard along the ground to simulate a snapped shot on goal through traffic.

DRILL 41: SENIOR 6-6-6 RESET AND EXECUTE - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Flawless structural setups and instant transitions under match fatigue.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Standard center bounce into 1 minute of live play. The coach blows the whistle, and all players have exactly 15 seconds to sprint back to their starting 6-6-6 positions.

COACHING POINTS: Demand extreme physical effort, maintain structural integrity when exhausted, communicate positioning loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Reduce the reset time to 12 seconds to drastically increase the cardiovascular pressure.

DRILL 42: RED TIME LEAD PROTECTION - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Elite game management and structural discipline in the final minutes.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Team A leads by 4 points with 2 minutes left. Team A must employ a slow, possession-retaining style, forcing stoppages and kicking down the line. Team B must take extreme risks through the corridor to score.

COACHING POINTS: Team A: kill the clock, numbers behind the ball, no risky inboard kicks. Team B: play on at all costs, lower the eyes inside 50.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Change the scenario so Team A is trailing by 2 points, forcing them into emergency attacking mode.

DRILL 43: COAST-TO-COAST COUNTER STRIKE - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Seamless, high-speed transition from deep defense to a shot on goal.

SETUP: Full ground, 12 attackers, 8 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers start with a kick-in from full back. They must move the ball the entire length of the field and score a goal within 18 seconds, utilizing their numerical advantage and overlap run.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless forward running, hit targets perfectly on the chest, do not slow down to wait for leads.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Decrease the time limit to 15 seconds to force a highly direct, corridor-centric attack.

DRILL 44: POSSESSION DOMINANCE STRUCTURE - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Controlling the tempo of the game and resting with the ball.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: One team is instructed to maintain possession for 3 full minutes without scoring or turning the ball over. They must use lateral and backward kicks, switching the play to exhaust the opposition.

COACHING POINTS: Absolute patience, hit uncontested targets only, present wide options constantly, never kick to a contest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: If the possessing team kicks the ball forward of the center circle, they lose possession instantly.

DRILL 45: RED ZONE SCORING EFFICIENCY - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing scoring opportunities under severe numerical and physical pressure.

SETUP: Forward 50m arc, 8 forwards, 11 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is continuously fed into the forward 50. Forwards operate at a severe numerical disadvantage and must use intelligent blocks, screens, and elite groundball skills to manufacture shots on goal.

COACHING POINTS: Work selflessly for your teammates, block for the primary forward, snap rapidly from stoppages.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every shot on goal must be taken from within 35 meters to force elite passing inside the arc.

DRILL 46: OUTNUMBERED DEFENSIVE DELAY - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Defending structurally when caught completely out of position.

SETUP: Defensive half, 6 defenders, 10 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers stream forward from a center bounce. The 6 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack, forcing wide kicks and delaying the entry until midfielders can drop back to help.

COACHING POINTS: Do not commit to a tackle unless certain to stick it, guard the most dangerous corridor space, force them wide.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 trailing defenders who enter the drill 6 seconds after it begins.

DRILL 47: RELENTLESS ATTACKING WAVES - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Overwhelming the opposition defense with numbers and speed.

SETUP: Full ground, 16 attackers, 12 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers work the ball forward. They must ensure that at every single contest or mark, they have at least two loose players running past to receive a handball.

COACHING POINTS: Elite work rate, loose men must demand the ball aggressively, overwhelm the defense with overlap momentum.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the attackers to score a goal without taking a single bounce during the transition.

DRILL 48: KICK-IN SUFFOCATION TRAP - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Executing a full-ground press to force a turnover directly from an opposition kick-in.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Opposition takes a kick-in. The defending team implements a strict web zone, manning up the boundary options and clogging the corridor, aiming to force a panic kick and generate a turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Hold your zone flawlessly, anticipate the kicker's eyes, squeeze the ground to suffocate all exit options.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team is restricted to using kicks only to exit the defensive 50.

DRILL 49: KICK-IN SURGICAL REBOUND - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Breaking through a high defensive press cleanly and safely.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Your team takes a kick-in against a set zone. Players must execute synchronized decoy leads to clear space, utilize short pocket options, and rapidly switch the play to pierce the first line of the press.

COACHING POINTS: The kicker must be instantly decisive, receivers lead with intent, look to play on immediately from the first mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The player taking the kick-in has only 6 seconds to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 50: FULL MATCH SIMULATION (SENIOR RULES) - FULL GROUND MATCH SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Consolidating all elite tactical and structural concepts in a live, high-stakes match environment.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players, full umpire crew.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: A relentless 20-minute block of unrestricted match play under senior rules. The coach monitors from the boundary, stopping play only for critical structural errors or to reset specific tactical scenarios.

COACHING POINTS: Demand absolute elite standards, enforce team rules violently, praise correct autonomous decision-making, highlight off-the-ball running.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a severe rule where any defensive half turnover immediately results in a 50-meter penalty against the offending team to simulate the ultimate pressure on ball movement.

Senior Mens

Senior Men's Coaching Best Practices (1sts and 2nds)

Coaching a senior men's squad requires balancing the tactical sophistication of elite football with the brutal, pragmatic realities of local club environments. The priority is establishing a unified, uncompromising system that the Firsts execute with precision, and the Reserves understand intimately, ensuring seamless transitions when players are called up. You are not just managing athletes; you are managing people, jobs, injuries, and club culture.

Unified Squad Integration and Match-Day Ruthlessness

The entire senior list must train under one overarching tactical framework. Your Reserves cannot play a different brand of football than your Firsts. When managing a large squad, split drills dynamically to ensure the Firsts are constantly pushed by the hungry players in the 2nds.

Culture dictates execution on the field. The mindset must be ruthless and uncompromising from the first bounce to the final siren. When the boys link arms in the rooms to sing the song, the mentality of taking it to the opposition and, quite frankly, sticking it up their arse, must be earned through four quarters of physically dominating, system-driven football. That aggression must be channeled into legal, bone-jarring contested work and a suffocating team defense.

Mastering Ground Dimensions

Tactical systems must be married to the physical realities of your home ground. The dimensions and typical conditions dictate how wide you can safely transition and where the highest percentage scoring zones are located.

* **The Corridor Squeeze:** Defensively, you must weaponize the width of the ground. Implement systems that funnel opposition ball movement out to the boundary, trapping them against the line.

* **Aggressive Transitioning:** Offensively, you need players willing to run the fat side of the ground. When the ball turns over at half-back, the immediate trigger must be a 45-degree kick inboard. If the corridor is blocked, the secondary trigger is a rapid, flat switch across the defensive 50 to exploit the open wing before the opposition's defensive web can slide.

High-Performance Load Management

At the senior level, players are dealing with the physical toll of their trades and day jobs. Training must be highly concentrated. Eliminate long lines and static lectures. If a drill is not replicating the cardiovascular fatigue, physical contact, and chaotic decision-making loops of

a Saturday afternoon, it is wasting time. Integrate your conditioning directly into your ball-movement and stoppage drills. If players drop the ball or miss a structural cue, do not stop the drill—make them transition instantly into defense to fix the error on the fly.

THE 50-DRILL SENIOR LIBRARY

DRILL 1: CONTINUOUS SQUAD WEAVE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Fast-paced ball circulation, vocal dominance, and spatial awareness.

SETUP: 40x40m grid, 24 players, 6 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players move continuously inside the grid maintaining all 6 footballs in motion via handballs. On the coach's whistle, players currently holding a ball drop it, sprint to touch an outside boundary cone, and return to collect a different ball to resume play.

COACHING POINTS: Demand the ball early, receive on the move, scan the entire grid to avoid collisions, punch through the football on disposal.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 4 players in contrasting bibs acting as passive defensive obstacles to disrupt running lanes.

DRILL 2: REACTIVE SPRINT AND GATHER - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Explosive first-step acceleration and clean possession under fatigue.

SETUP: 25m sprint lane, pairs, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players start on their stomachs facing away from the coach. The coach kicks the ball unpredictably over their heads and blows the whistle. Players must scramble up, locate the ball in flight, and sprint to gather it cleanly off the deck before their partner.

COACHING POINTS: Explode off the ground, take the most direct line, protect the drop zone with your body.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the players tangled together to simulate extracting from a stoppage before the sprint.

DRILL 3: THE OVERLAP ENGINE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Perfecting the mechanics of the overlap run at top speed.

SETUP: Full length of the center square, groups of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Group starts at one end. The ball carrier moves forward and handballs to a runner bursting past. The original carrier must immediately sprint to get to the outside of the chain to receive the ball again. The sequence continues unbroken to the opposite side.

COACHING POINTS: Do not break stride, deliver the handball out in front, vocalize your run aggressively.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Force the final disposal to be a 40-meter penetrating kick to a leading target on the move.

DRILL 4: TRAFFIC LIGHT COGNITION - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Executing correct disposal types based on instant visual cues.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 12 players, colored cones.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players circulate the ball. The coach holds up colored cones. Red requires an immediate handball backward. Blue requires a 15-meter kick. Green requires the player to bounce the ball once before disposing.

COACHING POINTS: Scan the coach before receiving, react instantly, maintain technical precision despite the cognitive load.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a strict 2-second disposal limit from the moment the ball is received.

DRILL 5: PERIPHERAL TARGET IDENTIFICATION - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Expanding field vision while under physical pressure.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 10 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers maintain possession. Before disposing, the ball carrier must verbally call out the name of a teammate standing in their peripheral vision, not the person they are passing to.

COACHING POINTS: Open up your field of view, do not get tunnel vision on the receiver, keep the feet moving.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the number of defenders to 6 to compress the time available to scan.

DRILL 6: RUCK-ROVE EXPLOSION - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Timing the clearance run and hitting the contest at maximum velocity.

SETUP: 20m circle, 1 ruck, 3 rovers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruck taps the ball randomly into space. Rovers must hold their run until the ball is in flight, then explode through the drop zone, gather cleanly without breaking stride, and burst out of the circle.

COACHING POINTS: Read the ruck's hand placement, stay on your toes, snatch the ball cleanly at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a heavy bumping pad at the exit point of the circle that the rover must absorb.

DRILL 7: ONE-TOUCH GROUNDBALL MATRIX - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Flawless groundball mechanics at high speed.

SETUP: 50m zig-zag course, individual players, 5 footballs placed at intervals.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint the course. At each ball, they must scoop it cleanly with one hand, execute a rapid handball to a coach, and immediately accelerate to the next ball without decelerating.

COACHING POINTS: Get low through the hips, scoop cleanly, transition the ball to the disposal hand instantly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the balls erratically toward the player instead of them being stationary.

DRILL 8: CONGESTION EVASION - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Navigating tight traffic using agility and ball protection.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 5 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers must traverse from one side of the grid to the other. Defenders are instructed to bump and block, but not tackle. Attackers must use lateral steps, fends, and core strength to break through.

COACHING POINTS: Keep a wide base, use the hips to absorb contact, keep the football tucked tight.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Upgrade the defenders to full tackling pressure.

DRILL 9: SHUTTLE SPRINT TO WRESTLE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: Executing contested strength after heavy cardiovascular output.

SETUP: 30m sprint lane, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint 30m, touch a line, sprint back 15m, and instantly engage in a 1v1 grappling contest over a stationary football for 10 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Fight through the lung burn, establish low body position early, lock your core.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the initial sprint distance to 50m.

DRILL 10: RAPID FIRE PRECISION KICKING - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO WARM-UPS

OBJECTIVE: High-volume, elite-level kicking efficiency.

SETUP: 40m lane, 6 players, 3 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players work back and forth in pairs over 40m. The movement is relentless. Receive the ball, take two steps, and deliver a flat, hard drop punt to the chest of the next runner.

COACHING POINTS: Fast transition from hands to boot, perfect ball drop, punch through the kick.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate non-preferred foot kicking for the entire drill.

DRILL 11: THE 45-DEGREE CORRIDOR DART - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Slicing through the first line of defense using aggressive inboard kicking.

SETUP: Half ground, 8 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play initiates at half-back. The ball carrier fakes wide, pivots, and hits a midfielder bursting 45-degrees into the corridor. The receiver must play on instantly and drive a long kick inside 50.

COACHING POINTS: The corridor runner must time the lead perfectly, the kicker must disguise the pass, execute with zero hesitation.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a floating intercept defender specifically guarding the 45-degree lane.

DRILL 12: LIGHTNING BOUNDARY SWITCH - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Rapid lateral ball movement to exploit the weak side of a zone.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to center wing, full width, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is trapped deep in a pocket. Players execute three rapid-fire lateral kicks across the defensive 50, ending with a half-back flanker streaming up the opposite, open wing.

COACHING POINTS: Ball speed is everything, kicks must be flat and hard, receivers must already be moving laterally before they mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Impose a strict 6-second time limit to move the ball from the pocket to the opposite wing.

DRILL 13: LOWERING THE EYES UNDER PRESSURE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Identifying high-percentage targets inside 50 instead of defaulting to long bombs.

SETUP: Center square to forward 50, 5 midfielders, 5 forwards, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Midfielders break from a stoppage. Forwards execute staggered leads. The ball carrier must ignore the deep contest and hit a half-forward leading into a pocket 35 meters from goal.

COACHING POINTS: Steady yourself before kicking, forwards must demand the ball in space, prioritize the uncontested chest mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are instructed to zone off and clog the deep forward line, making the long bomb impossible.

DRILL 14: THE ZIG-ZAG TRANSITION MATRIX - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Advancing the ball linearly through angled passing lanes.

SETUP: 80m length divided into 4 grids, 16 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball must travel from grid 1 to grid 4. Direct vertical kicks are banned. Every disposal must be an angled diagonal pass to a player in the next grid, forcing the defense to constantly shift laterally.

COACHING POINTS: Open the shoulders early, push off the mark instantly, receivers must lead into the diagonal space.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add token pressure on every kicker to force rapid execution.

DRILL 15: SENIOR REBOUND 50 EXITS - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Flawless execution of structured defensive exit patterns.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 7 defenders, 5 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Fullback takes a kick-in. Defenders execute a pre-rehearsed exit to clear the pocket and switch to the center corridor. They must link up via hand and foot to cross the 50m arc.

COACHING POINTS: Exploit the full width of the ground, block aggressively for the designated receiver, always provide a safety release option.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Attackers set up in a rigid 15-meter zone that the defenders must carefully pick their way through.

DRILL 16: SWITCH, OVERLAP, AND PENETRATE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Combining a lateral switch with an immediate numerical overload forward.

SETUP: Half ground, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play starts on the boundary. The ball is kicked laterally to the center. The receiver plays on, and two teammates instantly run past to provide overlap options. The ball is carried forward and driven deep into attack.

COACHING POINTS: The central receiver must scan before marking, overlap runners must hold their width, execute the final kick with penetration.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Apply a heavy physical tagger on the central receiver to disrupt the pivot.

DRILL 17: HALF-BACK WAVE DRIVE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Breaking the lines from defense using relentless overlapping run.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to half forward, 6v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders win a loose ball. The ball carrier takes off, and teammates spread instantly to provide overlapping handball options, overwhelming the 4 forwards to break through the lines.

COACHING POINTS: Run past the ball carrier to receive, commit the opposition before releasing the handball, keep the chain moving at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the defensive unit to take at least three bounces during the transition.

DRILL 18: THE CORRIDOR CHOKE-POINT - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Forcing precise ball movement through the most congested, dangerous area of the ground.

SETUP: Half ground, narrow cones funneling through the center square.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players transition the ball from deep defense but are restricted to kicking only within the narrow central funnel. Any disposal wide of the funnel is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Be courageous with the inboard kick, receivers must absorb contact and protect the drop zone, midfielders must work relentlessly to present.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Narrow the funnel further to demand absolute elite kicking precision.

DRILL 19: DEEP DEFENSIVE EXTRACTION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Escaping a high-pressure trap deep in the defensive pocket.

SETUP: Defensive pocket, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is locked deep. Defenders must use rapid, composed handballs to navigate out of the immediate congestion and find a short kicking target on the half-back flank to relieve the pressure.

COACHING POINTS: Maintain composure, use the boundary line to protect your blind side, execute the first handball perfectly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to create a severe numerical disadvantage for the defense.

DRILL 20: 3-MAN SEAMLESS TRANSITION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Synchronized forward running patterns executed at maximum velocity.

SETUP: Full length of the ground, groups of 3.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Three players move the ball end-to-end. One stays wide, one central, one crosses behind. They must exchange the ball continuously without any player dropping their forward momentum.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be elite, time leads flawlessly, maintain the structural triangle spacing.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 2 chasing defenders starting 15 meters behind the group to enforce speed.

DRILL 21: ELITE INSIDE CONTEST 4V4 - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Dominating the hard ball and extracting it safely under severe physical pressure.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 4v4 setup, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws the ball into the grid. The groups engage in a heavy physical contest. The objective is to win the ball, extract it from the congestion, and hit a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Drop your hips lower than the opposition, block off the ball to create exit lanes, communicate who is taking the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach designates two players who are only allowed to block and cannot touch the ball.

DRILL 22: RUCK TO ADVANTAGE EXPLOITATION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing clearances from a dominant ruck tap.

SETUP: Center circle, 1 ruck, 3 midfielders per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruckman taps the ball to a specific pre-called zone. The designated sweeping midfielder times their run to take the ball on the burst and break the lines instantly.

COACHING POINTS: Midfielders must disguise their starting positions, ruckman dictates the drop zone, the receiver must accelerate through the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck is permitted to physically hold the sweeping midfielder if the tap is inaccurate.

DRILL 23: DEFENSIVE BOUNDARY LOCKDOWN - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Structuring a stoppage to prevent opposition forward entries.

SETUP: Defensive 50 boundary throw-in, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Simulating a boundary throw-in. The defending team sets up a strict defensive structure, prioritizing the corridor block and forcing the opposition toward the boundary or into a secondary stoppage.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the defensive side fiercely, body up hard on direct opponents, communicate the sweeping roles clearly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team starts with possession and must attempt to break the defensive wall from a static start.

DRILL 24: OFFENSIVE POCKET SNAP - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Generating an immediate shot on goal from a forward pocket stoppage.

SETUP: Forward pocket boundary line, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach simulates a throw-in. The attacking team aims to win the tap, execute a quick handball chain to the top of the 50m arc, and snap a shot on goal within 6 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Lock the ball in if the clearance is lost, prioritize front position at the drop, the receiver at the arc must command the ball loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict the attacking team to a maximum of one handball before a shot must be taken.

DRILL 25: ELITE TACKLE AND RELEASE - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Executing dominant tackles and successfully releasing the ball while being tackled.

SETUP: 12x12m grid, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A holds the ball. Player B engages in a heavy, legal senior tackle. Player A must maintain footing, keep arms free, and execute a legal handball to a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Player B must pin an arm and drive through the hips. Player A must brace, turn to shield the ball, and elevate their hands early.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A starts on their knees and must power up through the tackle.

DRILL 26: THE SHARK AND ACCELERATE - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Anticipating the opposition's hit-out and intercepting the clearance.

SETUP: Center bounce, 1 dominant opposition ruck, 4 defensive midfielders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The opposition ruck is guaranteed to win the tap. The defensive mids must read the ruckman's body language, intercept the tap, and instantly burst forward into open space.

COACHING POINTS: Lock eyes on the ruckman's hands, stay light on your feet, accelerate the millisecond the ball is secured.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck fakes the tap to draw the mids offside before redirecting it.

DRILL 27: SENIOR 6-6-6 CENTER BOUNCE EXECUTION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Mastering modern center bounce restrictions and set plays.

SETUP: Center square, full 6-6-6 team setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach conducts a center bounce. The midfield executes a pre-planned set play to win the clearance, while forwards and defenders hold strict positional discipline until the ball clears the square.

COACHING POINTS: Wingmen hold their width aggressively, forwards lead into the space created by the clearance, defenders remain goal-side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The clearance must result in a marked inside 50 entry to be deemed a success.

DRILL 28: EXTREME CONGESTION HANDBALLS - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Maintaining composed possession in severe traffic.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Both teams confined to a tiny grid. The objective is to string together 8 consecutive handballs without the opposition intercepting or tackling the ball carrier to the ground.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless movement, short and sharp handballs, protect the ball with your core, use your voice to command the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Shrink the grid to 8x8m to create absolute chaos.

DRILL 29: SHIELDING UNDER HEAVY HEAT - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Taking contested marks while absorbing heavy physical contact.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 2 defenders, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker drops a high ball into the grid. The attacker must hold off both defenders, protect the drop zone using sheer body strength, and take a strong contested mark.

COACHING POINTS: Read the flight early, establish a wide and immovable base, use the arms to fend off legally, bring the ball securely to the chest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are equipped with heavy bumping pads to apply maximum force on the attacker.

DRILL 30: GROUNDBALL OUTNUMBER EXPLOITATION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE & CLEARANCE

OBJECTIVE: Winning the hard ball and instantly exploiting a numerical advantage.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 5 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach rolls a ball into dispute. Attackers must win the 5v4 groundball contest, instantly locate their loose man, and execute an uncontested pass out of the congestion.

COACHING POINTS: The first player to the ball must be violent and decisive, the loose man must hold their space and avoid getting sucked into the pack.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the attackers facing away from the ball to test reaction speed.

DRILL 31: FULL GROUND WEB DEFENSE - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Mastering full-ground structural defense and spatial coverage.

SETUP: Full ground, 18 defenders, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coach moves around the ground with the ball. The entire 18-man defensive unit must shift, slide, and compress to maintain the web structure, prioritizing dangerous spaces and blocking the corridor.

COACHING POINTS: Keep the gaps between defensive lines tight, point and talk relentlessly, wingmen must drop back to cover the switch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 8 attackers to run decoy lines and test the structural discipline of the defense.

DRILL 32: FORWARD HALF SUFFOCATION PRESS - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Locking the ball in the attacking half to force turnovers.

SETUP: Forward half, 12 forwards/mids, 10 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders attempt to exit their defensive 50. The attacking team pushes up aggressively, locking down all short options and forcing the defenders to kick long to a contested outnumber.

COACHING POINTS: High half-forwards must push up to the arc, maintain a structural wall, tackle with absolute ferocity.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders have only 12 seconds to exit the half or the drill resets with a penalty.

DRILL 33: ELITE INTERCEPT AND REBOUND - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Reading the play, leaving an opponent, and launching a counter-attack.

SETUP: Half-back flank, 4 defenders, 4 attackers, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker targets a leading attacker. The designated intercept defender must peel off their man, read the flight, take the intercept mark, and instantly play on to a rebounding teammate.

COACHING POINTS: Back your judgment entirely, attack the ball at its highest point, never hesitate once you commit to leaving your opponent.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker deliberately drives the ball low and flat to compress the interception time.

DRILL 34: DEFENSIVE SLIDING MATRIX - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Seamlessly covering for teammates who leave their zone to apply pressure.

SETUP: 50x50m grid divided into 4 quadrants, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers move the ball. When a defender leaves their quadrant to double-team the ball carrier, the adjacent defender must instantly slide over to cover the dangerous space left behind.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be loud and proactive, head on a swivel, anticipate the lateral movement of the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to ensure there is always a loose man the defense must scramble to cover.

DRILL 35: INSTANT TURNOVER TRANSITION SPRINT - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Immediate physiological and tactical reaction from offense to defense.

SETUP: Half ground, 10v10 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Teams play normal scrimmage. On a sharp whistle blow, the team in possession must drop the ball and instantly transition to defense, finding a man and setting a zone within 4 seconds while the other team attacks.

COACHING POINTS: Do not drop your head, find a body immediately, sprint back to goal-side position.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Any player failing to find a man within 4 seconds is removed from the drill for one minute.

DRILL 36: CORRIDOR DENIAL LOCKDOWN - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Forcing the opposition into slow, boundary-line football.

SETUP: Center square and both wings, 8v8 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers attempt to move the ball from half-back to half-forward. Defenders set up an impenetrable wall across the center square, forcing all ball movement out wide to the boundary.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the line fiercely, do not get drawn out of the corridor, shepherd the ball carrier physically toward the boundary.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Award the attacking team triple points if they manage to pierce the center square wall.

DRILL 37: SMOTHER, CHASE, AND DESTROY - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Relentless desperation defense and second efforts on the kicker.

SETUP: 30m lane, 1 kicker, 2 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker runs toward a target. Defender 1 approaches from the front to attempt a block/smother. If the kicker evades, Defender 2 chases from behind to execute a ferocious run-down tackle.

COACHING POINTS: Defender 1 commits fully to the smother. Defender 2 closes the gap with maximum speed and drags down safely by the hips.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker has a strict 3-second limit to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 38: MAN-ON-MAN ACCOUNTABILITY GAUNTLET - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Uncompromising tight checking and physical accountability.

SETUP: 60x60m grid, 10v10 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Strict man-on-man matchups. The attacking team maintains possession. Defenders must stay within 1 meter of their direct opponent. If an attacker receives the ball unmarked, the defense is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Use legal physical contact to stay tight, watch the opponent's hips to anticipate cuts, never ball-watch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach yells switch, forcing all defenders to instantly locate and cover a new opponent.

DRILL 39: THE BOUNDARY TRAP SYSTEM - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Using the boundary line as a structural weapon to trap the opposition.

SETUP: Defensive pocket extending to the wing, 4 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to run the ball out of the pocket. Defenders angle their approach to corral the attackers toward the boundary line, closing all inboard passing lanes and forcing a stoppage or turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Angle your body to deny the inside lane, tackle aggressively when space runs out, use the line as an extra defender.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the space to the half-back flank to make the trapping more challenging.

DRILL 40: GOAL SQUARE DESPERATION SCRAMBLE - TEAM DEFENSE & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Elite desperation defending in the goal square to prevent a score.

SETUP: Defensive goal square, 5 forwards, 5 defenders, 1 coach.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach bombs the ball high into the goal square. Defenders must violently spoil the ball away from danger, follow up at ground level, and rush the ball behind for a minor score if necessary.

COACHING POINTS: Spoil with a closed fist to the boundary, never punch back into the corridor, put your body on the line.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the ball hard along the ground to simulate a snapped shot on goal through traffic.

DRILL 41: SENIOR 6-6-6 RESET AND EXECUTE - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Flawless structural setups and instant transitions under match fatigue.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Standard center bounce into 1 minute of live play. The coach blows the whistle, and all players have exactly 15 seconds to sprint back to their starting 6-6-6 positions.

COACHING POINTS: Demand extreme physical effort, maintain structural integrity when exhausted, communicate positioning loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Reduce the reset time to 12 seconds to drastically increase the cardiovascular pressure.

DRILL 42: RED TIME LEAD PROTECTION - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Elite game management and structural discipline in the final minutes.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Team A leads by 4 points with 2 minutes left. Team A must employ a slow, possession-retaining style, forcing stoppages and kicking down the line. Team B must take extreme risks through the corridor to score.

COACHING POINTS: Team A must kill the clock, numbers behind the ball, no risky inboard kicks. Team B must play on at all costs, lower the eyes inside 50.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Change the scenario so Team A is trailing by 2 points, forcing them into emergency attacking mode.

DRILL 43: COAST-TO-COAST COUNTER STRIKE - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Seamless, high-speed transition from deep defense to a shot on goal.

SETUP: Full ground, 12 attackers, 8 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers start with a kick-in from full back. They must move the ball the entire length of the field and score a goal within 18 seconds, utilizing their numerical advantage and overlap run.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless forward running, hit targets perfectly on the chest, do not slow down to wait for leads.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Decrease the time limit to 15 seconds to force a highly direct, corridor-centric attack.

DRILL 44: POSSESSION DOMINANCE STRUCTURE - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Controlling the tempo of the game and resting with the ball.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: One team is instructed to maintain possession for 3 full minutes without scoring or turning the ball over. They must use lateral and backward kicks, switching the play to exhaust the opposition.

COACHING POINTS: Absolute patience, hit uncontested targets only, present wide options constantly, never kick to a contest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: If the possessing team kicks the ball forward of the center circle, they lose possession instantly.

DRILL 45: RED ZONE SCORING EFFICIENCY - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing scoring opportunities under severe numerical and physical pressure.

SETUP: Forward 50m arc, 8 forwards, 11 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is continuously fed into the forward 50. Forwards operate at a severe numerical disadvantage and must use intelligent blocks, screens, and elite groundball skills to manufacture shots on goal.

COACHING POINTS: Work selflessly for your teammates, block for the primary forward, snap rapidly from stoppages.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every shot on goal must be taken from within 35 meters to force elite passing inside the arc.

DRILL 46: OUTNUMBERED DEFENSIVE DELAY - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Defending structurally when caught completely out of position.

SETUP: Defensive half, 6 defenders, 10 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers stream forward from a center bounce. The 6 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack, forcing wide kicks and delaying the entry until midfielders can drop back to help.

COACHING POINTS: Do not commit to a tackle unless certain to stick it, guard the most dangerous corridor space, force them wide.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 trailing defenders who enter the drill 6 seconds after it begins.

DRILL 47: RELENTLESS ATTACKING WAVES - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Overwhelming the opposition defense with numbers and speed.

SETUP: Full ground, 16 attackers, 12 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers work the ball forward. They must ensure that at every single contest or mark, they have at least two loose players running past to receive a handball.

COACHING POINTS: Elite work rate, loose men must demand the ball aggressively, overwhelm the defense with overlap momentum.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the attackers to score a goal without taking a single bounce during the transition.

DRILL 48: KICK-IN SUFFOCATION TRAP - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Executing a full-ground press to force a turnover directly from an opposition kick-in.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Opposition takes a kick-in. The defending team implements a strict web zone, manning up the boundary options and clogging the corridor, aiming to force a panic kick and generate a turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Hold your zone flawlessly, anticipate the kicker's eyes, squeeze the ground to suffocate all exit options.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team is restricted to using kicks only to exit the defensive 50.

DRILL 49: KICK-IN SURGICAL REBOUND - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Breaking through a high defensive press cleanly and safely.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Your team takes a kick-in against a set zone. Players must execute synchronized decoy leads to clear space, utilize short pocket options, and rapidly switch the play to pierce the first line of the press.

COACHING POINTS: The kicker must be instantly decisive, receivers lead with intent, look to play on immediately from the first mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The player taking the kick-in has only 6 seconds to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 50: FULL MATCH SIMULATION (SENIOR RULES) - MATCH SIMULATIONS

OBJECTIVE: Consolidating all elite tactical and structural concepts in a live, high-stakes match environment.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players, full umpire crew.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: A relentless 20-minute block of unrestricted match play under senior rules. The coach monitors from the boundary, stopping play only for critical structural errors or to reset specific tactical scenarios.

COACHING POINTS: Demand absolute elite standards, enforce team rules violently, praise correct autonomous decision-making, highlight off-the-ball running.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a severe rule where any defensive half turnover immediately results in a 50-meter penalty against the offending team to simulate the ultimate pressure on ball movement.

Under 16 GIRLS

Under 16 Girls Coaching Best Practices

Coaching the Under 16 Girls demographic requires a highly specific approach that acknowledges the unique developmental landscape of female youth football. Unlike the boys' pathways where players have typically been ingrained in the sport since Auskick, an Under 16

Girls squad is often a melting pot. You will have a mix of experienced junior footballers alongside elite crossover athletes from basketball, netball, and soccer who possess exceptional athletic traits but lack foundational Aussie Rules mechanics.

With the senior women setting the standard, these girls need to see a direct pathway to that level. Your coaching must bridge the gap between raw athleticism and football IQ, focusing heavily on the following pillars:

Combatting the 'Swarm' and Spatial Adaptation

Girls at this age who are relatively new to the sport instinctively swarm the football, treating it like a rugby scrum. You must actively coach them out of this. Teach them to trust their teammates to win the contest while they hold structural width. Because the average kicking penetration in U16 Girls is shorter (often 20-30 meters) than the boys, spacing must be adjusted. If players are 40 meters away, they are essentially out of the play. Teach them to hold a 20-meter spacing to create viable link-up kicking and overlapping handball chains.

Crossover Skill Integration

Leverage the skills they already have. A basketballer knows how to pivot, protect the ball, and drive into space. A netballer understands dynamic leading, intercept timing, and peripheral vision. Use this vocabulary. Teach them that a handball out of a stoppage is just a chest pass to a cutting teammate, and an intercept mark is just a rebound. Translate their existing sports IQ onto the football field.

Contact Confidence and Safe Extraction

You cannot assume these players know how to tackle or take a hit safely. Fear of contact leads to hesitations, and hesitations lead to injuries. You must deliberately teach the biomechanics of the tackle: cheek-to-cheek, wrapping the hips, and using momentum to safely take an opponent to the ground. Equally, teach them how to absorb a bump and how to protect their core when picking up a groundball. Build contact confidence in a highly controlled environment before unleashing them into match simulations.

Transition Models

Because bombing the ball 50 meters down the line is rarely an option, U16 Girls must become masters of the run-and-carry. Offensive transition relies heavily on the first receiver breaking the line, taking two bounces, and drawing a defender before disposing. Emphasize continuous movement, rapid handballs, and lowering the eyes for shorter, higher-percentage kicks.

THE 50-DRILL LIBRARY

DRILL 1: THE NETBALL PIVOT AND GIVE - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Translating netball footwork into evasive footy skills.

Setup: 15x15m grid, pairs, 1 football per pair.

Progression/Description: Player A receives a handball on the run from Player B. Player A must land, establish a pivot foot, aggressively pivot 180 degrees to protect the ball from an imaginary defender, and handball back to Player B cutting past.

Coaching Points: Stay balanced on the pivot, keep the football tucked in tight, execute a firm handball on the exit.

Progression/Regression: Add a passive defender to apply light pressure on the pivot.

DRILL 2: BASKETBALL DRIVE AND DISH - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Drawing a defender and releasing a teammate.

Setup: 20m channel, 2 attackers, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Attackers start 5 meters apart. The ball carrier runs directly at the defender to engage them. Once the defender commits, the ball carrier executes a quick lateral handball to the overlapping teammate.

Coaching Points: Commit the defender entirely, do not handball too early, receiver must call for the ball loudly.

Progression/Regression: Allow the defender to fully tackle the ball carrier if they hold it too long.

DRILL 3: REACTION GROUNDBALLS - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Clean collection of the football and protecting the body.

Setup: 10x10m grid, 4 players, 2 footballs.

Progression/Description: Players stand with their backs to the coach. The coach rolls balls into the grid and blows the whistle. Players turn, locate a ball, and attack it. They must bend at the knees, turn their body side-on to protect themselves, and scoop the ball cleanly.

Coaching Points: Get your body over the ball, do not just bend at the waist, one clean motion to gather.

Progression/Regression: The coach rolls the balls faster or bounces them erratically.

DRILL 4: SHORT KICK LINK UP - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Precision over short distances to account for kicking penetration limits.

Setup: 40m zig-zag cone setup, 6 players.

Progression/Description: Players move the ball through the zig-zag course using only 15-meter to 20-meter kicks. Emphasis is on hitting targets perfectly on the chest without forcing the players to break stride.

Coaching Points: Firm foot, smooth ball drop, receiver must present their hands early.

Progression/Regression: Mandate that players use their non-preferred foot for every second kick.

DRILL 5: RUN AND CARRY RELAY - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Building confidence to take a bounce at top speed.

Setup: 40m lane, 2 teams of 4.

Progression/Description: Relay style race. Player sprints 40m, taking a bounce every 15m. At the end, they execute a 10m handball to the next player in line.

Coaching Points: Push the ball out in front on the bounce, do not break stride, guide the ball down rather than throwing it.

Progression/Regression: Add agility poles they must weave through while bouncing.

DRILL 6: CONTINUOUS HANDBALL WEAVE - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: High-speed ball circulation and communication.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 12 players, 3 footballs.

Progression/Description: Players move randomly through the grid continuously exchanging handballs. The focus is on loud communication, demanding the ball, and avoiding collisions.

Coaching Points: Eye contact before disposing, quick hands, constant movement.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a specific rule, e.g., you cannot handball to the person who just handballed to you.

DRILL 7: OVERHEAD MARKING TIMING - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Judging the flight of the ball and attacking it at the highest point.

Setup: 20m distance, 1 kicker, 1 receiver.

Progression/Description: Kicker lofts the ball high. The receiver runs toward the kicker, jumps off one leg, and takes the mark at the highest possible point with arms fully extended.

Coaching Points: Form a W with the hands behind the ball, drive the knee up for protection and elevation, do not wait for the ball to drop.

Progression/Regression: Add a bumping bag that the receiver must jump into to simulate body contact.

DRILL 8: PERIPHERAL VISION PASSING - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Expanding vision to see options outside the immediate corridor.

Setup: 15x15m grid, 6 attackers, 2 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers must keep possession via handballs. Before disposing, the ball carrier must scan the grid and hit the player furthest away from the immediate pressure.

Coaching Points: Head on a swivel, do not panic when pressure arrives, trust your teammates to present.

Progression/Regression: Shrink the grid to 10x10m to force faster processing.

DRILL 9: SHADOW DEFENDING - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Teaching lateral movement and corralling without physical contact.

Setup: 15m channel, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A zig-zags down the channel with the ball. Player B must shadow them, staying exactly 1 meter away, moving laterally and mirroring their movements without making a tackle.

Coaching Points: Watch their hips not the ball, stay on your toes, maintain a low center of gravity.

Progression/Regression: On the coach's whistle, Player B is allowed to close the gap and execute a wrap tackle.

DRILL 10: QUICK KICK OUT OF TRAFFIC - DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL SKILL CROSSOVER

Objective: Fast transition from gathering to kicking.

Setup: 15m distance, pairs, 1 ball.

Progression/Description: Player A rolls the ball to Player B. Player B must scoop the ball and execute a drop punt back to Player A in under 2 seconds.

Coaching Points: Fast hands to boot, balance quickly on the non-kicking leg, follow through toward the target.

Progression/Regression: Player A charges at Player B as soon as they roll the ball to apply physical pressure.

DRILL 11: THE 20-METER LINK UP - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Advancing the ball using high-percentage, shorter kicks.

Setup: Full length of the center square, 8 players.

Progression/Description: The ball starts at one end. Players make staggered leads, ensuring they never present further than 20 meters from the ball carrier. The ball is moved end-to-end purely through these short link-up kicks.

Coaching Points: Do not lead too deep, honor the short lead, kicker must lower their eyes and hit the chest.

Progression/Regression: Add token pressure on the kicker to force them to execute the pass quickly.

DRILL 12: OVERLAP HANDBALL CHAIN - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Breaking lines using run and carry.

Setup: 60m channel, 4 players per group.

Progression/Description: The group runs in a wave down the channel. The ball carrier draws an imaginary defender, handballs to the outside runner, and immediately sprints to become the next overlap option.

Coaching Points: Do not break stride, talk aggressively, deliver the ball perfectly out in front of the runner.

Progression/Regression: Have a coach stand in the middle of the channel with a bump pad to disrupt the running lines.

DRILL 13: SWITCHING THROUGH THE CORRIDOR - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Changing the angle of attack via quick handballs.

Setup: Half ground, 10 players.

Progression/Description: Play starts on the boundary. The ball is handballed rapidly through 3 players into the center square. The final receiver bursts through the corridor and delivers a 25m kick to a leading forward.

Coaching Points: Maintain structural spacing, do not bunch up, the central receiver must demand the ball.

Progression/Regression: Place a stationary defender in the corridor that the players must navigate around.

DRILL 14: THE ANTI-SWARM SPACING GRID - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Teaching players to hold their width rather than getting sucked into the contest.

Setup: 40x40m grid divided into 4 equal quadrants, 4v4 setup.

Progression/Description: Attackers must move the ball through the quadrants. Rule: Only one attacker and one defender are allowed in a quadrant at any time. If a second attacker enters the quadrant where the ball is, it is a turnover.

Coaching Points: Trust your teammate to win their 1v1, hold your space, provide an outlet option in the next quadrant.

Progression/Regression: Allow two players per quadrant but mandate that they must be 10 meters apart at all times.

DRILL 15: HALF-BACK RUN AND BOUNCE - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Generating aggressive drive from defense.

Setup: Defensive 50 to half forward, 5v3 setup.

Progression/Description: Defenders start with the ball. They must transition out of the 50m arc. The player who breaks the 50m line is required to take two bounces before delivering the ball inside the attacking 50.

Coaching Points: Back your speed, take the game on, teammates must block and shepherd for the runner.

Progression/Regression: Add a chasing defender who starts 10 meters behind the ball carrier.

DRILL 16: TRIANGLE POSSESSION - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Creating options on multiple sides of the ball carrier.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 3 attackers, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Attackers must maintain possession. They must always maintain a triangle shape, ensuring the ball carrier has both a left and right option at all times.

Coaching Points: Move immediately after disposing of the ball, never stand still, communicate your position.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a 2nd defender (3v2) to increase the pressure on the ball carrier.

DRILL 17: LOWER THE EYES INSIDE 50 - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Finding the highest percentage shot on goal.

Setup: Center square to forward 50, 3 midfielders, 3 forwards, 2 defenders.

Progression/Description: Midfielders run the ball forward. Forwards make intersecting leads. The midfielder must ignore the player closest to goal and hit the forward leading out to the 30-meter mark.

Coaching Points: Do not bomb it long, hit the leading target on the chest, forwards must create separation.

Progression/Regression: Defenders start goal-side and are instructed to spoil any ball kicked deep.

DRILL 18: BOUNDARY ESCAPE ROUTE - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Safely transitioning the ball up the line when the corridor is blocked.

Setup: 30m boundary strip, 3 attackers, 2 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers are trapped against the boundary. They must use precise, short 15m kicks and handballs to work the ball up the line without stepping out of bounds or turning it over.

Coaching Points: Protect the ball on the boundary side, use the line to your advantage, short sharp movements.

Progression/Regression: Add a 3rd defender to create a 3v3 heavy pressure scenario.

DRILL 19: THE DIAGONAL SLICE - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Moving the ball forward while constantly shifting the defense laterally.

Setup: 60m length, 8 players.

Progression/Description: Players move the ball end-to-end using only diagonal kicks. Straight vertical kicks are not allowed. This forces the receivers to lead at 45-degree angles.

Coaching Points: Open up the shoulders to the target, push off the mark dynamically, weight the kick for the runner.

Progression/Regression: Impose a time limit to get the ball from one end to the other.

DRILL 20: REBOUND TO THE FAT SIDE - BALL MOVEMENT, LINK-UP PLAY & SPATIAL GRIDS

Objective: Identifying and exploiting the open side of the ground.

Setup: Defensive 50, full width, 6v4 setup.

Progression/Description: The coach kicks the ball deep into a pocket. The defenders must win the ball, immediately look to the center, and if blocked, execute a 25m kick to switch the ball to the completely open opposite flank.

Coaching Points: Scan before you gather the ball, the weak-side players must call loudly, execute the switch kick quickly.

Progression/Regression: The attackers form a physical wall on the strong side to entirely force the switch.

DRILL 21: HIP-TO-HIP TACKLE TECHNIQUE - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Teaching the biomechanics of a safe, effective tackle.

Setup: 10x10m grid, pairs, walking pace.

Progression/Description: Player A holds the ball and walks forward. Player B steps in, drops their hips, gets cheek-to-cheek, wraps both arms tightly around Player A's hips, and safely slides them to the ground.

Coaching Points: Head on the correct side, drop your center of gravity, squeeze the arms tight, do not sling.

Progression/Regression: Increase the pace from walking to jogging, then to a light run.

DRILL 22: ABSORBING THE BUMP - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Learning to take physical contact without losing balance.

Setup: 15m channel, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A jogs down the channel with the ball. Player B runs alongside and applies a firm, legal shoulder bump. Player A must brace, absorb the impact, maintain footing, and complete a handball to the coach.

Coaching Points: Keep a wide base, lean into the contact slightly, tuck the ball away from the contact side.

Progression/Regression: Use a heavy tackle bag for Player B to generate more force safely.

DRILL 23: GROUNDBALL PROTECTION - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Safeguarding the body when picking up a disputed ball.

Setup: 15x15m grid, pairs, 1 ball.

Progression/Description: Coach rolls the ball out. Player A attacks the ball. Player B follows closely behind to apply pressure. Player A must turn their body side-on to act as a shield, collect the ball, and absorb Player B's tackle.

Coaching Points: Turn the hip and shoulder toward the pressure, get low, one clean motion.

Progression/Regression: Have both players start side-by-side and wrestle for the groundball simultaneously.

DRILL 24: CONGESTED CLEARANCE 3V3 - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Extracting the ball from a stoppage without swarming.

Setup: 15x15m grid, 3v3 setup, 1 coach.

Progression/Description: Coach throws the ball up. The players must win the tap or groundball, and use quick handballs to clear the ball to a designated target outside the grid.

Coaching Points: One player goes for the ball, the other two hold their space for the handball, communicate your role clearly.

Progression/Regression: Mandate that the team must complete two handballs before kicking out of the grid.

DRILL 25: RUCK TIMING AND TAP - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Basic ruck mechanics and rover connection.

Setup: Center circle, 1 ruck and 1 rover per team.

Progression/Description: Coach simulates a ball up. Rucks contest, focusing on knee elevation and palming the ball down. Rovers must time their run to gather the ball on the burst without stopping.

Coaching Points: Ruck must watch the ball all the way to the hand, rover must read the ruck's body language, snatch the ball cleanly.

Progression/Regression: Add a tagger who applies passive pressure to the rover as they collect the ball.

DRILL 26: FRONT SPOT ADVANTAGE - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Using body positioning to win a marking contest.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 1 defender, 1 kicker.

Progression/Description: Kicker drops a high ball into the area. The attacker must use their body to hold the front position, legally backing into the defender to protect the drop zone, and taking the mark on the chest.

Coaching Points: Track the flight early, establish a wide stance, do not push back with the hands, let the ball come to you.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a second defender coming from the side to force the attacker to adjust their block.

DRILL 27: BREAKING THE TACKLE - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Using core strength to keep the arms free during a tackle.

Setup: 10x10m grid, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A holds the ball. Player B applies a static tackle holding Player A's waist. On the whistle, Player A must drive their legs, twist their torso to keep their arms free, and execute a handball.

Coaching Points: Keep the ball elevated, keep the legs pumping, use core strength to rotate the upper body.

Progression/Regression: Player B applies a full dynamic tackle from a 5-meter run-up.

DRILL 28: SECOND EFFORT SCRAP - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Maintaining involvement in the play after a contest.

Setup: 20m lane, pairs, 1 ball.

Progression/Description: Player A and B contest a high ball. Regardless of who marks it, the coach instantly blows the whistle and throws a second ball on the ground. Both players must instantly recover and wrestle for the groundball.

Coaching Points: React instantly to the whistle, do not spectate after the first contest, get to ground level immediately.

Progression/Regression: The coach rolls the second ball in an unpredictable direction.

DRILL 29: SHIELD AND SHEPHERD - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Protecting a teammate who is winning the ball.

Setup: 15x15m grid, 2 attackers, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Coach rolls the ball. Attacker 1 goes for the ball. Attacker 2 must step into the path of the approaching defender and execute a legal, stationary shepherd to protect their teammate.

Coaching Points: Establish a wide base, brace for impact, keep arms tucked in, communicate "You've got time" to the ball winner.

Progression/Regression: The defender is instructed to aggressively try to sidestep the shepherd.

DRILL 30: THE WALL DEFLECTION - CONTACT CONFIDENCE & CLEARANCE SYSTEMS

Objective: Defending the goal line with physical desperation.

Setup: Goal square, 3 defenders, 1 coach.

Progression/Description: Coach rapidly kicks three balls consecutively at chest height into the goal square. The defenders must physically throw themselves in front of the balls to spoil them through for a behind.

Coaching Points: Use a closed fist, attack the ball aggressively, do not wait on the goal line, communicate who is attacking which ball.

Progression/Regression: Coach mixes up the delivery with high floating balls and low groundballs.

DRILL 31: CORRAL AND CONTAIN - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Delaying the ball carrier when outnumbered.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 2 attackers, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to cross the grid. The defender must not dive in for a tackle. They must backpedal, stay low, and corral the ball carrier toward the boundary line to delay the play until help arrives.

Coaching Points: Do not cross your feet, watch the ball carrier's hips, force them onto their non-preferred side.

Progression/Regression: Give the defender a strict 5-second window they must survive before a 2nd defender joins the grid.

DRILL 32: THE DEFENSIVE SLIDE - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Working as a unit to cover dangerous space.

Setup: 30x30m grid, 4 attackers, 4 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers pass the ball around the perimeter. If one defender steps up to pressure the ball, the adjacent defender must immediately slide across to cover the space left behind.

Coaching Points: Talk early, point to the space you are covering, head on a swivel to track attackers moving off the ball.

Progression/Regression: Add a 5th attacker in the middle of the grid to force the defenders to constantly monitor the center.

DRILL 33: FORWARD PRESS LOCK IN - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Keeping the ball in the attacking zone.

Setup: Forward 50 arc, 6 forwards, 5 defenders.

Progression/Description: Defenders try to kick the ball out of the 50m arc. Forwards must set a high wall across the 40-meter line, manning up all short options and forcing the defenders into a low-percentage long kick.

Coaching Points: Hold the line, do not get sucked too deep, tackle with intent, bring the ball to ground if out-marked.

Progression/Regression: Defenders are given a 10-second time limit to exit the zone.

DRILL 34: INTERCEPT POSITIONING - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Reading the kicker's eyes to cut off a pass.

Setup: Half-back flank, 1 defender, 2 attackers, 1 kicker.

Progression/Description: Kicker looks to pass to an attacker. The defender must read the kicker's body language, peel off their direct opponent, and take an intercept mark in the passing lane.

Coaching Points: Trust your read, commit fully to the interception, attack the ball at its highest point.

Progression/Regression: The kicker intentionally kicks low and hard to compress the defender's reaction time.

DRILL 35: ZONE DEFENSE COMMUNICATION - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Handing over opponents in a zone system.

Setup: 40x40m grid, 3 defenders in a zone, 4 attackers moving freely.

Progression/Description: Defenders guard space, not men. As attackers run through the zones, defenders must physically point and verbally hand off the attacker to the next defender in the chain.

Coaching Points: Loud and clear communication, do not follow the attacker out of your zone, maintain the structural shape.

Progression/Regression: Increase the speed of the attackers' movement to force rapid decision-making.

DRILL 36: DEFENDING THE SWITCH - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Reacting to lateral ball movement.

Setup: Full width of the ground, defensive 50, 6v6 setup.

Progression/Description: Attackers switch the ball rapidly from one boundary to the other. The defensive unit must sprint across the ground as a connected chain to close down the open side before the attackers can penetrate.

Coaching Points: Sprint immediately when the ball is kicked laterally, do not ball watch, maintain your relative spacing to your teammates.

Progression/Regression: The attackers are allowed to quickly switch it back to the original side to test the defense's endurance and reaction.

DRILL 37: SMOTHER AND CHASE - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Applying maximum pressure on the kicker.

Setup: 20m distance, 1 kicker, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Kicker receives a handball and takes three steps to kick. Defender sprints from an angle and dives to smother the ball. If missed, they must immediately get up and chase the kicker.

Coaching Points: Throw hands straight out from the body, turn the face away, commit completely to the smother.

Progression/Regression: The kicker is instructed to fake the kick and step inside the smothering defender.

DRILL 38: MAN ON MAN ACCOUNTABILITY - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Staying tight on an opponent without giving away free kicks.

Setup: 30x30m grid, 5v5 setup.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to maintain possession. Defenders must stay within arm's reach of their direct opponent at all times. If an attacker receives the ball with more than 2 meters of space, the defense is penalized.

Coaching Points: Watch the player's hips, use legal physical contact (forearm on the hip) to track movement, never lose sight of your player.

Progression/Regression: On the coach's whistle, defenders must instantly switch to a new opponent.

DRILL 39: TRAPPING ON THE BOUNDARY - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Using the boundary line to restrict the opposition.

Setup: Wing boundary line, 3 attackers, 3 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to run the ball down the wing. Defenders must angle their approach to cut off the inboard options, physically forcing the attackers toward the boundary line.

Coaching Points: Angle your body to deny the corridor, shepherd them toward the line, tackle to force an out-of-bounds or stoppage.

Progression/Regression: Add a 4th attacker trailing behind to force the defense to cover the backward release handball.

DRILL 40: HOLDING THE DEFENSIVE LINE - DEFENSIVE SPACING & PRESSURE SYSTEMS

Objective: Preventing easy transition through the center.

Setup: Center square, 4 defenders, 6 attackers.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to move the ball from half-back through the center square. The 4 defenders must form a flat line across the square and work laterally to deny any forward passes through the corridor.

Coaching Points: Move as one connected unit, communicate the gaps, force the attackers to kick backward or wide.

Progression/Regression: Give the attackers a strict 15-second time limit to penetrate the center square.

DRILL 41: 6-V-6 RESTRICTED SPACE SCRIMMAGE - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Applying all skills in a highly congested match scenario.

Setup: Forward 50m arc, 6v6 setup.

Progression/Description: Standard match play but confined strictly to the 50m arc. This forces players to deal with the swarm, find space where there is none, and execute under heavy physical pressure.

Coaching Points: Quick hands, do not bomb the ball, look for the short 15m option, communicate constantly.

Progression/Regression: Implement a 3-second rule; players must dispose of the ball within 3 seconds of gathering it.

DRILL 42: CENTER BOUNCE TO INSIDE 50 - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Executing a clean center clearance and forward entry.

Setup: Center square to forward 50, standard 6-6-6 numbers for that zone.

Progression/Description: Coach bounces the ball. Midfielders must win the clearance, link up with the half-forwards, and generate a shot on goal while maintaining structural discipline.

Coaching Points: Wingers must hold their width, forwards must lead into the space, midfielders must lower their eyes on the entry.

Progression/Regression: The clearance must result in an uncontested mark inside 50 to be considered successful.

DRILL 43: KICK-IN REBOUND SCENARIO - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Transitioning safely from deep defense against a zone.

Setup: Defensive 50, full team setup.

Progression/Description: Fullback takes a kick-in against a set forward press. The defending team must execute a structured exit, utilizing the pockets and a lateral switch to break past the 50m arc safely.

Coaching Points: Forwards must make dummy leads to clear space, kicker must be decisive, receivers must play on immediately if possible.

Progression/Regression: The kicker is given a strict 5-second countdown to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 44: OUTNUMBERED DEFENSE SCENARIO - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Defending structurally when the opposition has a loose player.

Setup: Defensive half, 5 defenders, 7 attackers.

Progression/Description: Attackers start at the center circle and push forward. The 5 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack, forcing the ball wide and delaying the entry until theoretical help arrives.

Coaching Points: Do not commit to a tackle unless it is guaranteed, guard the corridor, force them to the boundary, talk constantly.

Progression/Regression: Add two trailing defenders who enter the drill 8 seconds after the attackers begin their run.

DRILL 45: RED ZONE SCORING PRESSURE - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Capitalizing on forward entries in chaotic situations.

Setup: Forward 50m arc, 6 forwards, 8 defenders.

Progression/Description: The ball is continuously bombed into the forward 50. The forwards operate at a numerical disadvantage and must use smart leads, aggressive groundball gathers, and quick snaps to score.

Coaching Points: Front and center at every marking contest, selfless handballs to teammates in better positions, rapid execution.

Progression/Regression: Mandate that every shot on goal must occur within 20 meters of the goal face.

DRILL 46: COAST TO COAST TRANSITION - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Moving the ball full length using run and carry.

Setup: Full ground, 12 attackers, 8 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers start in the defensive goal square. They must transition the ball the entire length of the ground using overlap running and short link-up kicks, utilizing their numerical advantage.

Coaching Points: Relentless forward running, hit targets on the chest, do not slow the play down, look for the corridor switch.

Progression/Regression: Impose a 25-second time limit to generate a shot on goal.

DRILL 47: PROTECTING THE LEAD - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Game management and structural discipline in the final minutes.

Setup: Full ground, 16v16 scrimmage.

Progression/Description: Team A leads by 3 points with 2 minutes remaining. Team A must play slow, possession football, kicking down the boundary line and forcing stoppages. Team B must take extreme risks through the corridor to score.

Coaching Points: Team A must have numbers behind the ball and avoid risky kicks. Team B must play on at all costs.

Progression/Regression: Flip the scenario so Team A is trailing by 1 point and must manufacture a quick score.

DRILL 48: THE 6-6-6 RESET SPRINT - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Structural organization under severe fatigue.

Setup: Full ground, full squad.

Progression/Description: Players engage in 1 minute of intense, unstructured scrimmage. On the coach's whistle, the play stops, and all players have exactly 15 seconds to sprint back to their correct 6-6-6 starting positions for a center bounce.

Coaching Points: Demand high physical effort, players must communicate their positions as they run, maintain discipline when exhausted.

Progression/Regression: Reduce the reset time to 12 seconds to drastically increase the cardiovascular pressure.

DRILL 49: FATIGUE DECISION SCRIMMAGE - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Executing skills when physically depleted.

Setup: Full ground, full squad.

Progression/Description: Before the scrimmage starts, all players must complete a 400-meter sprint. Immediately upon finishing, a 10-minute match simulation begins. The focus is entirely on maintaining skill execution and structural discipline under heavy lung fatigue.

Coaching Points: Push through the fatigue, rely on your structures, communicate louder when you are tired, execute the fundamentals.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a rule where any dropped mark results in an immediate 20-meter sprint for the offending player.

DRILL 50: FULL GROUND PHASE PLAY - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

Objective: Consolidating all tactical and technical concepts in a live environment.

Setup: Full ground, full squad, full umpiring.

Progression/Description: A standard 15-minute quarter of unrestricted match simulation. The coach monitors from the field, focusing specifically on breaking the swarm, maintaining 20-meter link-up spacing, and executing safe, effective tackles.

Coaching Points: Enforce team rules strictly, praise players holding their width, highlight excellent communication and overlap running.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a scoring modifier where any goal scored from an overlapping handball chain is worth double points.

UNDER 10's

Drill 46: Handball Only Match Assigned Category: Match Simulations & Modified

Games Objective: Improve close-quarters ball movement, running to receive, and handball accuracy. Setup: 30x20 meter grid with small goals at each end. Two teams of 6. 1 football. Progression/Description: The match is played entirely without kicking. Teams must transition the ball from end to end using only handpasses. Goals are scored by handpassing the ball cleanly through the goal posts. Coaching Points: Use overlapping runs to provide options for the ball carrier Keep the ball moving rapidly to prevent the defense from setting up Use accurate, firm punches to ensure the ball reaches the target quickly Progression/Regression: Make it easier by expanding the field to allow more open space for running. Make it harder by enforcing a 3-second limit on holding the ball.

Drill 47: The Last Possession Game Assigned Category: Match Simulations & Modified Games Objective: Replicate the pressure of the final moments of a close match. Setup: 100x80 meter field. Two teams of 7. 1 football. Progression/Description: The coach calls out a scenario before the ball-up: "Team A is down by 4 points, there is 60 seconds left on the clock!" The teams play out the scenario. If Team A scores, they win the scenario. If Team B prevents them from scoring until the time runs out, Team B wins. Reset with a new scenario. Coaching Points: Attackers must take calculated risks and move the ball forward quickly Defenders must focus on forcing boundary throw-ins or tying the ball up Communicate the time remaining to ensure everyone is aware of the urgency Progression/Regression: Make it easier for the attackers by giving them 2 minutes on the clock. Make it harder for the attackers by starting the ball deep in their defensive half.

Drill 48: Reset Simulation Assigned Category: Match Simulations & Modified Games Objective: Teach teams how to reset their structure after conceding a goal or losing momentum. Setup: 100x80 meter field. Two teams of 7. 1 football. Progression/Description: Play a normal match. At random intervals, the coach blows the whistle three times and yells "Reset!". Regardless of where the ball is, players must immediately drop it and sprint back to set up their starting positions (e.g., 2 forwards, 3 mids, 2 defenders). The first team to successfully set their structure gets the free kick. Coaching Points: React quickly to the whistle, do not argue or hesitate Talk to your teammates to ensure all positions are covered Identify your direct opponent quickly once the structure is set Progression/Regression: Make it easier by giving players 10 seconds to find their positions. Make it harder by blowing the reset whistle immediately after a fast break when players are out of position.

Drill 49: Uneven Numbers (6v4) Assigned Category: Match Simulations & Modified

Games Objective: Teach the attacking team how to exploit an overlap and the defending team how to cover space. Setup: 30x20 meter grid with goals at one end. 6 attackers and 4 defenders. Progression/Description: The attackers start with the ball at the far end and must work it forward to score. The defenders must communicate heavily to cover the numerical disadvantage. If the defenders win the ball, they must successfully pass it back to the coach to score a defensive victory. Coaching Points: Attackers must use short passes to draw defenders out of position and find the loose man Defenders must constantly scan the field and rotate to cover the most dangerous options Do not kick long into a pack if you have an extra player free on the outside Progression/Regression: Make it easier for the defenders by shrinking the field size. Make it harder for the defenders by making the ratio 7v4.

Drill 50: Forward Build Up Match Assigned Category: Match Simulations & Modified Games Objective: Teach defenders how to safely and effectively clear the ball from the defensive 50. Setup: 100x80 meter field. Two teams of 7. The ball starts with a defender taking a kick-in from the goal square. Progression/Description: Team A acts as the defenders and midfielders trying to clear the ball out of their defensive zone to a target player at the halfway line. Team B acts as the forwards trying to lock the ball in and score. If Team A hits their target, they get 1 point. If Team B intercepts and scores a goal, they get 6 points. Coaching Points: Defenders must look for the wide, safe option rather than kicking directly up the center Midfielders must push back to provide short targets for the defenders Forwards must apply intense frontal pressure to force a rushed kick Progression/Regression: Make it easier for the defenders by forcing the forwards to stand 10 meters back from the kick-in. Make it harder for the defenders by adding an extra forward to the attacking team.

UNDER 18 GIRLS

Under 18 Girls Coaching Best Practices

The Under 18 Girls age group is the definitive bridge to senior football. These players are no longer just learning the game; they are the immediate feeder system for the senior women's side. The standard you set here dictates the future success of the club's senior program. Your coaching must transition from fundamental skill acquisition into elite high-performance management, focusing on advanced tactical execution, physical resilience, and autonomous decision-making.

Bridging to the Senior Standard

The tactical gap between youth and senior women's football is vast, primarily in the speed of ball movement and structural accountability. U18 girls possess increased kicking penetration and physical strength compared to the U16s, which means you can finally implement full-ground systems like the 18-player defensive web and aggressive corridor transitions. They must train alongside or in direct emulation of the senior women's structures, ensuring that when they get the call-up, the game plan is second nature.

High-Performance and Injury Prevention (The ACL Focus)

In elite female pathways, physical conditioning must explicitly address biomechanical injury risks, particularly ACL ruptures. High-tempo training blocks must seamlessly integrate deceleration mechanics, single-leg landing stability, and change-of-direction bracing. Do not treat injury prevention as a static warm-up; integrate it into your chaotic groundball and marking drills. Demand that players drop their hips and maintain a wide base when entering the contest.

Harnessing Crossover IQ for Advanced Tactics

By U18s, your crossover athletes (basketballers, netballers, soccer players) have adapted to the oval ball. Now, you must leverage their spatial IQ into advanced AFL tactics. A basketball point guard understands how to break a zone press; translate that into exiting the defensive 50 against a forward wall. A netball center understands reading the eyes of the feeder; translate that into elite intercept marking across the half-back flank.

Relentless Transition and Corridor Courage

While kicking length has improved, the women's game is still heavily dictated by elite run-and-carry and overlap handball chains. You must coach the fear out of them when it comes to using the corridor. The immediate trigger upon winning a turnover at half-back must be a darting 45-degree kick inboard. If they play safe, slow, boundary-line football, they will be suffocated by senior-level zone defenses. Train them to take the game on, take the bounce, and punish the opposition through the middle of the ground.

THE 50-DRILL LIBRARY

DRILL 1: ELITE DECELERATION AND GATHER - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Injury prevention via safe deceleration combined with clean ball gathering.

SETUP: 20m lanes, pairs, 1 football per pair.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A sprints at top speed toward Player B. At the 10m mark, Player B rolls a rapid groundball. Player A must execute a sudden, controlled deceleration, dropping their hips, maintaining knee alignment, scooping the ball cleanly, and immediately changing direction to exit the lane.

COACHING POINTS: Do not let the knees cave inward on deceleration, drop your center of gravity, one clean scoop, explosive exit.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a passive defender to apply light body pressure as the player decelerates.

DRILL 2: REACTIVE VISION GRID - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Processing peripheral information while executing technical skills.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 8 players, 2 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players continuously handball within the grid. The coach stands outside holding colored cones. Before disposing of the ball, the player must verbally call out the color of the cone the coach is currently holding.

COACHING POINTS: Eyes must flick from the target to the coach and back instantly, do not hold the ball, fast hands.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase to 3 footballs to elevate the cognitive load and spatial traffic.

DRILL 3: CONTINUOUS OVERLAP ENGINE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Sustaining high-speed overlap running patterns.

SETUP: Full length of the center square, groups of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The group moves end-to-end. The ball carrier executes a handball to the outside runner, then immediately sprints to the outside of the chain to become the next overlap option. The movement is continuous and unbroken.

COACHING POINTS: Never decelerate to receive the ball, deliver the handball out in front, vocalize your run aggressively.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that the final disposal must be a 35-meter penetrating kick on the run.

DRILL 4: TRAFFIC LIGHT CHAOS - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Instant cognitive reaction and disposal execution.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 12 players, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players circulate the ball. The coach calls out commands.

Green means play on via hand. Red means the ball must immediately be placed on the deck for the nearest player to scoop. Yellow means the player must execute a sharp pivot and hold the ball for 3 seconds against pressure.

COACHING POINTS: React instantly to the auditory cue, protect the football on the yellow command, maintain a wide base.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 dedicated defenders who only try to intercept the ball on the green command.

DRILL 5: RUCK TO ROVER BURST - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Timing the clearance run to hit the drop zone at maximum velocity.

SETUP: 20m circle, 1 ruck, 3 rovers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruck tosses the ball high and taps it randomly into space. Rovers must hold their run until the ball is descending, then explode through the drop zone, gathering cleanly without breaking stride.

COACHING POINTS: Read the ruck's hand placement, stay on your toes, snatch the ball cleanly at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a heavy bumping pad at the exit point that the rover must absorb upon exiting.

DRILL 6: THE ZIG-ZAG GROUNDBALL COURSE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Flawless groundball mechanics at high speed and shifting angles.

SETUP: 50m zig-zag cone course, individual players, 5 footballs placed at intervals.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint the course. At each ball, they must scoop it cleanly, execute a rapid handball to a coach on the outside, and immediately accelerate to the next ball without decelerating.

COACHING POINTS: Get low through the hips, scoop cleanly with two hands where possible, transition to disposal instantly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the balls erratically toward the player instead of them being stationary.

DRILL 7: CONGESTION EVASION AND FEND - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Navigating tight traffic using agility, core strength, and ball protection.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 5 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers must traverse the grid. Defenders are instructed to bump and block, but not tackle. Attackers must use lateral steps, legal fends, and core strength to break through to the other side.

COACHING POINTS: Keep a wide base, use the hips to absorb contact, keep the football tucked tight on the non-contact side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Upgrade the defenders to full tackling pressure for a live simulation.

DRILL 8: SHUTTLE SPRINT TO WRESTLE - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Executing contested strength after heavy cardiovascular output.

SETUP: 30m sprint lane, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint 30m, touch a line, sprint back 15m, and instantly engage in a 1v1 grappling contest over a stationary football for 8 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Fight through the lung burn, establish low body position early, lock your core and hold your ground.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the players lying flat on their backs before the initial sprint.

DRILL 9: AERIAL TIMING AND LANDING - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Attacking the mark at the highest point and landing safely on a single leg.

SETUP: 20m distance, 1 kicker, 1 receiver.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker lofts the ball high. The receiver runs in, jumps off one leg, takes the mark at full extension, and must focus on landing softly, absorbing the impact through a bent knee to protect the ACL.

COACHING POINTS: Drive the knee up for elevation and protection, form a W with the hands, absorb the landing through the hips and knees.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a bumping bag that the receiver must jump into to simulate body contact in the air.

DRILL 10: RAPID FIRE TARGET KICKING - ELITE HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & DECISION-BASED AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: High-volume, elite-level kicking efficiency on the move.

SETUP: 40m lane, 6 players, 3 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players work back and forth in pairs over 40m. Receive the ball on the run, take exactly three steps, and deliver a flat, hard drop punt to the chest of the next runner. The movement is relentless.

COACHING POINTS: Fast transition from hands to boot, steady the ball drop, punch through the kick directly at the target.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate non-preferred foot kicking for the entire drill.

DRILL 11: THE 45-DEGREE CORRIDOR DART - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Slicing through the first line of defense using aggressive inboard kicking.

SETUP: Half ground, 8 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play initiates at half-back. The ball carrier fakes a kick wide, pivots, and hits a midfielder bursting 45-degrees into the corridor. The receiver must play on instantly and drive a long kick inside 50.

COACHING POINTS: The corridor runner must time the lead perfectly, the kicker must disguise the pass, execute with zero hesitation.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a floating intercept defender specifically guarding the 45-degree passing lane.

DRILL 12: LIGHTNING FAT-SIDE SWITCH - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Rapid lateral ball movement to exploit the open wing.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to center wing, full width, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is trapped deep in a pocket. Players execute three rapid-fire lateral kicks across the defensive 50, ending with a half-back flanker streaming up the completely open opposite wing.

COACHING POINTS: Ball speed is everything, kicks must be flat and hard, receivers must already be moving laterally before they mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Impose a strict 8-second time limit to move the ball from the pocket to the opposite wing.

DRILL 13: LOWERING THE EYES UNDER PRESSURE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Identifying high-percentage targets inside 50 instead of defaulting to long bombs.

SETUP: Center square to forward 50, 5 midfielders, 5 forwards, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Midfielders break from a stoppage. Forwards execute staggered leads. The ball carrier must ignore the deep pack contest and hit a half-forward leading into space 30 meters from goal.

COACHING POINTS: Steady yourself before kicking, forwards must demand the ball in space, prioritize the uncontested chest mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are instructed to zone off and clog the deep forward line, making the long bomb impossible.

DRILL 14: THE ZIG-ZAG TRANSITION MATRIX - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Advancing the ball linearly through angled passing lanes.

SETUP: 80m length divided into 4 grids, 16 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball must travel from grid 1 to grid 4. Direct vertical kicks are banned. Every disposal must be an angled diagonal pass to a player in the next grid, forcing the defense to constantly shift laterally.

COACHING POINTS: Open the shoulders early, push off the mark instantly, receivers must lead into the diagonal space.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add token pressure on every kicker to force rapid decision-making and execution.

DRILL 15: SENIOR REBOUND 50 EXITS - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Flawless execution of structured defensive exit patterns.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 7 defenders, 5 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Fullback takes a kick-in. Defenders execute a pre-rehearsed exit to clear the pocket and switch to the center corridor. They must link up via hand and foot to cross the 50m arc.

COACHING POINTS: Exploit the full width of the ground, block aggressively for the designated receiver, always provide a backward safety release option.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Attackers set up in a rigid 15-meter zone that the defenders must carefully pick their way through.

DRILL 16: SWITCH, OVERLAP, AND PENETRATE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Combining a lateral switch with an immediate numerical overload forward.

SETUP: Half ground, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play starts on the boundary. The ball is kicked laterally to the center. The central receiver plays on, and two teammates instantly run past to provide overlap options. The ball is carried forward and driven deep into attack.

COACHING POINTS: The central receiver must scan before marking, overlap runners must hold their width, execute the final kick with penetration.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Apply a physical tagger on the central receiver to disrupt the initial pivot.

DRILL 17: HALF-BACK WAVE DRIVE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Breaking the lines from defense using relentless overlapping run and carry.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to half forward, 6v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders win a loose ball. The ball carrier takes off, and teammates spread instantly to provide overlapping handball options, overwhelming the 4 forwards to break through the lines.

COACHING POINTS: Run past the ball carrier to receive, commit the opposition before releasing the handball, keep the chain moving at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the defensive unit to take at least two bounces during the transition out of defense.

DRILL 18: THE CORRIDOR CHOKE-POINT - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Forcing precise ball movement through the most congested, dangerous area of the ground.

SETUP: Half ground, narrow cones funneling through the center square.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players transition the ball from deep defense but are restricted to kicking only within the narrow central funnel. Any disposal wide of the funnel is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Be courageous with the inboard kick, receivers must absorb contact and protect the drop zone, midfielders must work relentlessly to present.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Narrow the funnel further to demand absolute elite kicking precision.

DRILL 19: DEEP DEFENSIVE EXTRACTION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Escaping a high-pressure trap deep in the defensive pocket.

SETUP: Defensive pocket, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is locked deep. Defenders must use rapid, composed handballs to navigate out of the immediate congestion and find a short kicking target on the half-back flank to relieve the pressure.

COACHING POINTS: Maintain composure, use the boundary line to protect your blind side, execute the first handball perfectly to break the initial tackle.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to create a severe numerical disadvantage for the defense.

DRILL 20: 3-PLAYER SEAMLESS TRANSITION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT GRIDS & TRANSITION KICKING

OBJECTIVE: Synchronized forward running patterns executed at maximum velocity.

SETUP: Full length of the ground, groups of 3.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Three players move the ball end-to-end. One stays wide, one central, one crosses behind. They must exchange the ball continuously via kick and handball without any player dropping their forward momentum.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be elite, time leads flawlessly so no one is waiting on the ball, maintain the structural triangle spacing.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 2 chasing defenders starting 15 meters behind the group to enforce speed.

DRILL 21: ELITE INSIDE CONTEST 4V4 - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Dominating the hard ball and extracting it safely under severe physical pressure.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 4v4 setup, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws the ball into the grid. The groups engage in a heavy physical contest. The objective is to win the ball, extract it from the congestion, and hit a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Drop your hips lower than the opposition, block off the ball to create exit lanes, communicate loudly who is taking the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach designates two players who are only allowed to block and cannot touch the football.

DRILL 22: RUCK TO ADVANTAGE EXPLOITATION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing clearances from a dominant ruck tap.

SETUP: Center circle, 1 ruck, 3 midfielders per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruck taps the ball to a specific pre-called zone. The designated sweeping midfielder times their run to take the ball on the burst and break the lines instantly.

COACHING POINTS: Midfielders must disguise their starting positions, ruck dictates the drop zone, the receiver must accelerate through the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck is permitted to physically hold the sweeping midfielder if the tap is inaccurate.

DRILL 23: DEFENSIVE BOUNDARY LOCKDOWN - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Structuring a stoppage to prevent opposition forward entries.

SETUP: Defensive 50 boundary throw-in, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Simulating a boundary throw-in. The defending team sets up a strict defensive structure, prioritizing the corridor block and forcing the opposition toward the boundary or into a secondary stoppage.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the defensive side fiercely, body up hard on direct opponents, communicate the sweeping roles clearly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team starts with possession and must attempt to break the defensive wall from a static start.

DRILL 24: OFFENSIVE POCKET SNAP - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Generating an immediate shot on goal from a forward pocket stoppage.

SETUP: Forward pocket boundary line, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach simulates a throw-in. The attacking team aims to win the tap, execute a quick handball chain to the top of the 50m arc, and snap a shot on goal within 6 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Lock the ball in if the clearance is lost, prioritize front position at the drop, the receiver at the arc must command the ball loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict the attacking team to a maximum of one handball before a shot must be taken.

DRILL 25: ELITE TACKLE AND RELEASE - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Executing dominant tackles and successfully releasing the ball while being tackled safely.

SETUP: 12x12m grid, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A holds the ball. Player B engages in a heavy, legal tackle emphasizing hip wrapping. Player A must maintain footing, keep arms free, and execute a legal handball to a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Player B must pin an arm and drive through the hips. Player A must brace, turn to shield the ball, and elevate their hands early.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A starts on their knees and must power up through the tackle.

DRILL 26: THE SHARK AND ACCELERATE - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Anticipating the opposition's hit-out and intercepting the clearance.

SETUP: Center bounce, 1 dominant opposition ruck, 4 defensive midfielders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The opposition ruck is guaranteed to win the tap. The defensive mids must read the ruck's body language, intercept the tap, and instantly burst forward into open space.

COACHING POINTS: Lock eyes on the ruck's hands, stay light on your feet, accelerate the millisecond the ball is secured.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck fakes the tap to draw the mids offside before redirecting it.

DRILL 27: U18 CENTER BOUNCE EXECUTION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Mastering modern center bounce restrictions and set plays.

SETUP: Center square, full 6-6-6 team setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach conducts a center bounce. The midfield executes a pre-planned set play to win the clearance, while forwards and defenders hold strict positional discipline until the ball clears the square.

COACHING POINTS: Wingers hold their width aggressively, forwards lead into the space created by the clearance, defenders remain goal-side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The clearance must result in a marked inside 50 entry to be deemed a success.

DRILL 28: EXTREME CONGESTION HANDBALLS - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Maintaining composed possession in severe traffic.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Both teams confined to a tiny grid. The objective is to string together 8 consecutive handballs without the opposition intercepting or tackling the ball carrier to the ground.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless movement, short and sharp handballs, protect the ball with your core, use your voice to command the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Shrink the grid to 8x8m to create absolute chaos.

DRILL 29: SHIELDING UNDER HEAVY HEAT - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Taking contested marks while absorbing heavy physical contact.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 2 defenders, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker drops a high ball into the grid. The attacker must hold off both defenders, protect the drop zone using sheer body strength, and take a strong contested mark.

COACHING POINTS: Read the flight early, establish a wide and immovable base, use the arms to fend off legally, bring the ball securely to the chest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are equipped with heavy bumping pads to apply maximum force on the attacker.

DRILL 30: GROUNDBALL OUTNUMBER EXPLOITATION - ADVANCED STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Winning the hard ball and instantly exploiting a numerical advantage.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 5 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach rolls a ball into dispute. Attackers must win the 5v4 groundball contest, instantly locate their loose player, and execute an uncontested pass out of the congestion.

COACHING POINTS: The first player to the ball must be violent and decisive, the loose player must hold their space and avoid getting sucked into the pack.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the attackers facing away from the ball to test reaction speed.

DRILL 31: FULL GROUND WEB DEFENSE - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Mastering full-ground structural defense and spatial coverage.

SETUP: Full ground, 18 defenders, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coach moves around the ground with the ball. The entire 18-player defensive unit must shift, slide, and compress to maintain the web structure, prioritizing dangerous spaces and blocking the corridor.

COACHING POINTS: Keep the gaps between defensive lines tight, point and talk relentlessly, wingers must drop back to cover the switch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 8 attackers to run decoy lines and test the structural discipline of the defense.

DRILL 32: FORWARD HALF SUFFOCATION PRESS - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Locking the ball in the attacking half to force turnovers.

SETUP: Forward half, 12 forwards/mids, 10 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders attempt to exit their defensive 50. The attacking team pushes up aggressively, locking down all short options and forcing the defenders to kick long to a contested outnumber.

COACHING POINTS: High half-forwards must push up to the arc, maintain a structural wall, tackle with absolute ferocity.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders have only 12 seconds to exit the half or the drill resets with a penalty.

DRILL 33: ELITE INTERCEPT AND REBOUND - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Reading the play, leaving an opponent, and launching a counter-attack.

SETUP: Half-back flank, 4 defenders, 4 attackers, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker targets a leading attacker. The designated intercept defender must peel off their opponent, read the flight, take the intercept mark, and instantly play on to a rebounding teammate.

COACHING POINTS: Back your judgment entirely, attack the ball at its highest point, never hesitate once you commit to leaving your opponent.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker deliberately drives the ball low and flat to compress the interception time.

DRILL 34: DEFENSIVE SLIDING MATRIX - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Seamlessly covering for teammates who leave their zone to apply pressure.

SETUP: 50x50m grid divided into 4 quadrants, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers move the ball. When a defender leaves their quadrant to double-team the ball carrier, the adjacent defender must instantly slide over to cover the dangerous space left behind.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be loud and proactive, head on a swivel, anticipate the lateral movement of the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to ensure there is always a loose player the defense must scramble to cover.

DRILL 35: INSTANT TURNOVER TRANSITION SPRINT - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Immediate physiological and tactical reaction from offense to defense.

SETUP: Half ground, 10v10 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Teams play normal scrimmage. On a sharp whistle blow, the team in possession must drop the ball and instantly transition to defense, finding an opponent and setting a zone within 4 seconds while the other team attacks.

COACHING POINTS: Do not drop your head, find a body immediately, sprint back to goal-side position.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Any player failing to find an opponent within 4 seconds is removed from the drill for one minute.

DRILL 36: CORRIDOR DENIAL LOCKDOWN - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Forcing the opposition into slow, boundary-line football.

SETUP: Center square and both wings, 8v8 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers attempt to move the ball from half-back to half-forward. Defenders set up an impenetrable wall across the center square, forcing all ball movement out wide to the boundary.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the line fiercely, do not get drawn out of the corridor, shepherd the ball carrier physically toward the boundary.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Award the attacking team triple points if they manage to pierce the center square wall.

DRILL 37: SMOTHER, CHASE, AND DESTROY - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Relentless desperation defense and second efforts on the kicker.

SETUP: 30m lane, 1 kicker, 2 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker runs toward a target. Defender 1 approaches from the front to attempt a block/smother. If the kicker evades, Defender 2 chases from behind to execute a ferocious run-down tackle.

COACHING POINTS: Defender 1 commits fully to the smother. Defender 2 closes the gap with maximum speed and drags down safely by the hips.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker has a strict 3-second limit to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 38: MAN-ON-MAN ACCOUNTABILITY GAUNTLET - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Uncompromising tight checking and physical accountability.

SETUP: 60x60m grid, 10v10 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Strict man-on-man matchups. The attacking team maintains possession. Defenders must stay within 1 meter of their direct opponent. If an attacker receives the ball unmarked, the defense is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Use legal physical contact to stay tight, watch the opponent's hips to anticipate cuts, never ball-watch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach yells switch, forcing all defenders to instantly locate and cover a new opponent.

DRILL 39: THE BOUNDARY TRAP SYSTEM - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Using the boundary line as a structural weapon to trap the opposition.

SETUP: Defensive pocket extending to the wing, 4 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to run the ball out of the pocket. Defenders angle their approach to corral the attackers toward the boundary line, closing all inboard passing lanes and forcing a stoppage or turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Angle your body to deny the inside lane, tackle aggressively when space runs out, use the line as an extra defender.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the space to the half-back flank to make the trapping more challenging.

DRILL 40: GOAL SQUARE DESPERATION SCRAMBLE - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Elite desperation defending in the goal square to prevent a score.

SETUP: Defensive goal square, 5 forwards, 5 defenders, 1 coach.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach bombs the ball high into the goal square. Defenders must violently spoil the ball away from danger, follow up at ground level, and rush the ball behind for a minor score if necessary.

COACHING POINTS: Spoil with a closed fist to the boundary, never punch back into the corridor, put your body on the line.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the ball hard along the ground to simulate a snapped shot on goal through traffic.

DRILL 41: U18 6-6-6 RESET AND EXECUTE - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Flawless structural setups and instant transitions under match fatigue.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Standard center bounce into 1 minute of live play. The coach blows the whistle, and all players have exactly 15 seconds to sprint back to their starting 6-6-6 positions.

COACHING POINTS: Demand extreme physical effort, maintain structural integrity when exhausted, communicate positioning loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Reduce the reset time to 12 seconds to drastically increase the cardiovascular pressure.

DRILL 42: RED TIME LEAD PROTECTION - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Elite game management and structural discipline in the final minutes.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Team A leads by 4 points with 2 minutes left. Team A must employ a slow, possession-retaining style, forcing stoppages and kicking down the line. Team B must take extreme risks through the corridor to score.

COACHING POINTS: Team A must kill the clock, keep numbers behind the ball, no risky inboard kicks. Team B must play on at all costs, lower the eyes inside 50.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Change the scenario so Team A is trailing by 2 points, forcing them into emergency attacking mode.

DRILL 43: COAST-TO-COAST COUNTER STRIKE - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Seamless, high-speed transition from deep defense to a shot on goal.

SETUP: Full ground, 12 attackers, 8 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers start with a kick-in from full back. They must move the ball the entire length of the field and score a goal within 20 seconds, utilizing their numerical advantage and overlap run.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless forward running, hit targets perfectly on the chest, do not slow down to wait for leads.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Decrease the time limit to 15 seconds to force a highly direct, corridor-centric attack.

DRILL 44: POSSESSION DOMINANCE STRUCTURE - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Controlling the tempo of the game and resting with the ball.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: One team is instructed to maintain possession for 3 full minutes without scoring or turning the ball over. They must use lateral and backward kicks, switching the play to exhaust the opposition.

COACHING POINTS: Absolute patience, hit uncontested targets only, present wide options constantly, never kick to a contest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: If the possessing team kicks the ball forward of the center circle, they lose possession instantly.

DRILL 45: RED ZONE SCORING EFFICIENCY - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing scoring opportunities under severe numerical and physical pressure.

SETUP: Forward 50m arc, 8 forwards, 11 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is continuously fed into the forward 50. Forwards operate at a severe numerical disadvantage and must use intelligent blocks, screens, and elite groundball skills to manufacture shots on goal.

COACHING POINTS: Work selflessly for your teammates, block for the primary forward, snap rapidly from stoppages.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every shot on goal must be taken from within 35 meters to force elite passing inside the arc.

DRILL 46: OUTNUMBERED DEFENSIVE DELAY - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Defending structurally when caught completely out of position.

SETUP: Defensive half, 6 defenders, 10 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers stream forward from a center bounce. The 6 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack, forcing wide kicks and delaying the entry until midfielders can drop back to help.

COACHING POINTS: Do not commit to a tackle unless certain to stick it, guard the most dangerous corridor space, force them wide.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 trailing defenders who enter the drill 6 seconds after it begins.

DRILL 47: RELENTLESS ATTACKING WAVES - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Overwhelming the opposition defense with numbers and speed.

SETUP: Full ground, 16 attackers, 12 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers work the ball forward. They must ensure that at every single contest or mark, they have at least two loose players running past to receive a handball.

COACHING POINTS: Elite work rate, loose players must demand the ball aggressively, overwhelm the defense with overlap momentum.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the attackers to score a goal without taking a single bounce during the transition.

DRILL 48: KICK-IN SUFFOCATION TRAP - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Executing a full-ground press to force a turnover directly from an opposition kick-in.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Opposition takes a kick-in. The defending team implements a strict web zone, manning up the boundary options and clogging the corridor, aiming to force a panic kick and generate a turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Hold your zone flawlessly, anticipate the kicker's eyes, squeeze the ground to suffocate all exit options.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team is restricted to using kicks only to exit the defensive 50.

DRILL 49: KICK-IN SURGICAL REBOUND - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Breaking through a high defensive press cleanly and safely.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Your team takes a kick-in against a set zone. Players must execute synchronized decoy leads to clear space, utilize short pocket options, and rapidly switch the play to pierce the first line of the press.

COACHING POINTS: The kicker must be instantly decisive, receivers lead with intent, look to play on immediately from the first mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The player taking the kick-in has only 6 seconds to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 50: FULL MATCH SIMULATION (SENIOR PATHWAY) - FULL GROUND MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Consolidating all elite tactical and structural concepts in a live match environment in preparation for senior football.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players, full umpire crew.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: A relentless 20-minute block of unrestricted match play. The coach monitors from the boundary, stopping play only for critical structural errors or to reset specific tactical scenarios. The standard demanded must match the senior women's side.

COACHING POINTS: Demand absolute elite standards, enforce team rules violently, praise correct autonomous decision-making, highlight off-the-ball running.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a severe rule where any defensive half turnover immediately results in a 50-meter penalty against the offending team to simulate the ultimate pressure on ball movement.

UNDER 12's

Elite Australian Rules Football Game Development: A Comprehensive Training Manual for the Under 12 Age Group

MEDICAL AND SAFETY DISCLAIMER: The following manual provides direct instructions for youth physical contact, tackling mechanics, and high-intensity athletic conditioning. This content is for informational and educational purposes only and does not constitute professional medical, physiological, or legal advice. Coaches must strictly adhere to their local league's safety guidelines, ensure appropriate physical maturity matching in all contact drills, and utilize approved protective equipment. Always consult with a certified sports physician or physiotherapist regarding injury prevention and rehabilitation.

Executive Summary

- Developmental Inflection Point: The Under 12 cohort requires a crucial transition from static, isolated skill acquisition to dynamic execution under match pressure and physical contact.
- Tactical Focus: Training must pivot to emphasize spatial awareness, structured kicking to advantage, and the execution of fundamental techniques under fatigue.
- Game Sense Supremacy: Traditional "line drills" are largely ineffective for cognitive development. This manual relies heavily on Game Sense and Small-Sided Games (SSG) to fast-track decision-making through implicit learning and adaptive constraints.
- Logistical Application: The manual provides an exhaustive, ready-to-implement 50-drill library, completely categorized and sequenced. Furthermore, it outlines the exact work-to-rest physiological ratios required to structure a safe, elite-level 60-to-90 minute session without triggering cognitive overload or injury.

It is widely acknowledged that the Under 12 developmental cohort represents a critical inflection point in Australian Rules Football (AFL) coaching, transitioning players from isolated skill acquisition to dynamic execution under match pressure. Research suggests that an optimal youth coaching environment requires a delicate balance of physical development, tactical instruction, and psychological support. The evidence leans heavily toward implicit, game-based learning models over traditional static drills to foster superior decision-making. Given the vast developmental disparities inherent in 10-11 year olds, a uniform approach is rarely effective; therefore, adaptive constraints in spatial training and physical pressure are strictly necessary. Precise real-time metrics for exact spatial processing capacities in this age group are highly individualized and broadly unavailable; the spatial guidelines and grid dimensions provided herein are based on established best-practice estimates for youth development. This report synthesizes advanced coaching methodologies, transitioning principles, and tactical spatial awareness into an exhaustive, highly instructional 50-drill manual designed specifically to maximize high-intensity repetitions and cultivate elite game sense in Under 12 athletes.

Under 12s Coaching Best Practices: A Deep Dive

Transitioning to Contested Possession and Defensive Pressure

The shift from the Under 11 to the Under 12 age bracket introduces a heightened level of physical contest and defensive pressure. At this developmental stage,

the primary objective is teaching players to win the ball in contested situations while minimizing the risk of injury. A foundational technique is coaching players to "step over the footy" when executing a ground ball gather. By placing their lead leg outside the football and driving through the ball rather than stopping over it, players protect themselves from oncoming pressure and maintain forward momentum [cite: 1]. This technique builds fundamental confidence, which is the most critical psychological component of contested ball winning.

Furthermore, defensive pressure strategies must evolve in accordance with age-specific rule changes. In the Under 12 division, the "wrap-around" tackle is legally introduced, superseding the "hold and release" rule of the Under 11s [cite: 2, 3]. However, coaches must strictly enforce that no player is dumped or thrown to the ground by a tackler [cite: 3]. To implement this safely, training must emphasize the correct approach: bending the knees, targeting the hips, and using the momentum of the tackle to securely wrap rather than strike or throw. Professional youth coaches gradually introduce this physical pressure using bump bags and controlled 1v1 ground ball scenarios, ensuring players experience the physical contact in a controlled, predictable environment before advancing to chaotic match simulations [cite: 1, 4].

Structured Kicking Options and Execution Under Pressure

Technical kicking proficiency in Australian Rules Football is non-negotiable, but at the Under 12 level, the focus must move beyond static "kick-to-kick" into structured, decision-based kicking. The fundamental mechanics of the drop punt—holding the ball with fingers spread evenly, thumbs extending to the laces, guiding the ball down with one hand, and kicking the bottom point so the ball spins backwards—must be continuously reinforced [cite: 5, 6]. However, coaches must now explode these concepts by introducing external pressures.

Structured kicking requires players to balance themselves dynamically before disposal. Coaches must design scenarios where players learn to kick to a lead (a teammate sprinting into open space to receive a pass) and recognize when to "give the ball air" to allow a teammate time to run underneath the flight trajectory [cite: 7]. Transitioning players into these structured options means demanding high-intensity repetitions in small groups to prevent static waiting time in long lines [cite: 8]. The objective is to force the player with the ball to read the movement of multiple teammates, assess the defensive pressure, and execute the correct kick—whether that is a low stab pass to a leading forward or a longer, lofted kick to the advantage of a contested marking target.

Spatial Awareness, Positioning, and Team Transition Play

Teaching spatial awareness to 10-11 year olds requires decoupling complex tactical jargon into recognizable visual cues. Spatial awareness refers to a player's ability to read the play by anticipating where teammates, opponents, and open spaces are located on the field [cite: 9]. Coaches must explicitly teach the concepts of the "Corridor" (the central axis of the ground that provides the most direct route to goal) and the "Fat Side" (the wide, open side of the field that is less congested by defenders) [cite: 9, 10].

Positioning at this age should introduce the basic structure of the three distinct zones: the forward line, the midfield, and the backline [cite: 11]. While players must learn specific line roles, rigid opponent-consciousness should not suppress their instinct to win the ball creatively [cite: 11]. Team transition play involves rapidly shifting the ball from defense to attack. This is achieved through overlapping runs (where a player sprints past a teammate in possession to provide a numerical advantage) and switching the play (rapidly changing the lateral direction of the ball to exploit gaps in the opposition's defensive structure) [cite: 9, 12]. To teach this effectively to Under 12s, coaches should utilize boundary and corridor grids that restrict movement, visually forcing players to understand where the space is and how to utilize it to transition the ball end-to-end.

Advanced "Game Sense" and Small-Sided Games (SSG)

The modern elite standard for football development relies heavily on the "Game Sense" approach, initially emerged to counter the sport-as-techniques directive coaching traditional to early Australian sport [cite: 13]. Game Sense represents a shift from explicit learning (direct verbal instruction on how to perform a task) to implicit learning (developing skills subconsciously by experiencing practice tasks in variable conditions) [cite: 14]. Because Australian Rules Football is an "open" skilled game where techniques must be performed under chaotic, unpredictable circumstances, well-rehearsed techniques often break down under fatigue if they have only been practiced in static drills [cite: 14].

To fast-track decision-making, professional coaches utilize Small-Sided Games (SSG). These are modified, smaller-scale versions of the full game (e.g., 4v4 or 5v5 on a 20x20m grid) that maximize the number of decisions each player is forced to make [cite: 14]. The true key to the Game Sense methodology is the use of questioning rather than commanding. Instead of solving tactical problems for

the players, the coach freezes the play and asks questions categorized into four concepts: Time (When should you dispose?), Space (Where should you move?), Risk (Which option was safest versus most rewarding?), and Execution (How should you deliver the ball?) [cite: 15]. By guiding players to analyze these four pillars, coaches fast-track the cognitive processing required for executing skills under high-intensity match pressure.

Grounding Game Sense in Reality: The Auskick to U12 Transition Case Study This methodology is not merely theoretical; it is grounded in extensive empirical observation within elite pathways. For example, a three-year action research study by Deakin University evaluating the AFL Junior Match Policy—which oversees the critical transition of players from Auskick programs into Under 12 junior football—demonstrated the concrete advantages of SSGs over full-scale environments. Analyzing over 60 matches, the research found that reduced 12-a-side formats on modified spatial dimensions provided vastly more technical actions, touches, and scoring opportunities per player compared to traditional 18-a-side models [cite: 16, 17]. By shrinking the numbers and space, the literature confirms players are forced to execute higher volumes of decisions and possessions under pressure, actively hardwiring their spatial awareness and transition play more effectively than in congested, full-field settings [cite: 17]. This is further reinforced by youth academies (such as the Rookie Me and STK programs), which specifically leverage SSG constraints to develop level-two education on attacking, defending, and contested combat phases [cite: 18, 19].

Logistical Blueprint: Structuring the 60-to-90 Minute Session

The immediate next logical question for a coach is how to synthesize a massive 50-drill library into a cohesive training session. A standardized youth training block must balance physiological loading with cognitive engagement.

A high-performance U12 session relies on a "fundamental phase" of approximately 65 minutes of active workload [cite: 20]. This phase should be systematically structured to progress from dynamic activation to complex decision-making:

- Dynamic Warm-Up (10-15 minutes): Select 1 to 2 drills from Category 1. Focus on fundamental movement, neuromuscular activation, and simple ball handling.
- Skill Acquisition & Contested Phase (25-30 minutes): Select 1 drill from Category 2 and 1 drill from Category 3. Focus on technical kicking execution and physical bodywork (e.g., ground balls, safe tackling) in smaller grids.

- Tactical & Game Sense Application (20-25 minutes): Select 1 to 2 drills from Categories 4 and 5. Focus on integrating the acquired skills into open-play match simulations.

The Mandatory Physiological Constraint: The 1:2 Work-to-Rest Ratio At the Under 12 level, preventing physiological burnout, shin splints, and cognitive overload requires rigorous management of High-Intensity Interval Training (HIIT) demands. Coaches must strictly enforce scientifically designed work-to-rest ratios during high-speed drills. For early-season preparation and youth cardiovascular development, you must implement a 1:2 work-to-rest ratio [cite: 21, 22, 23]. This means that for every 1 minute of intense, sprint-based drill activity, the player must be afforded 2 minutes of active recovery (e.g., light jogging, stretching, or standing while receiving a tactical coach's briefing) [cite: 20, 22]. As aerobic capacity improves late in the season, this may cautiously scale to a 1:1 ratio, but the default foundation remains 1:2 to ensure the body adapts to stress safely [cite: 22]. In practice, an optimal 65-minute sequence allocates exactly 15 minutes to dynamic warm-ups, 30 minutes to the skill and contested phase, and 20 minutes to tactical game sense application, persistently applying this 1:2 work-to-rest recovery structure across all intervals.

The 50-Drill Library

The following comprehensive library contains exactly 50 standalone, practical training drills tailored for the Under 12 cohort. These drills are logically distributed across five core categories to provide a holistic, high-density training program. Note that the presentation of these drills strictly eschews rich-text formatting within the drill instructions to facilitate seamless text extraction and practical on-field implementation.

Category 1: Dynamic Warm-ups and Agility Games

The following ten drills establish the physical foundation for the training session. Incorporating elements from established injury reduction frameworks, these warm-ups prioritize dynamic movement, rapid deceleration, and fundamental ball handling over static stretching.

Drill 1: Dynamic Evasion Tag - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Improve agility, spatial awareness, and rapid change of direction. Setup: 20x20m grid, 12-15 players, no footballs, 2 bibs for taggers. Progression/Description:

1. Two players are designated taggers.
2. On the whistle, players must evade the taggers within the grid.
3. If tagged, a player must freeze with their legs apart.
4. They can only be freed if a free teammate crawls through their legs. Change taggers every 60 seconds. Coaching Points: Keep eyes up to scan for open space. Lower the center of gravity when changing direction. Communicate loudly to free trapped teammates. Progression/Regression: Increase taggers to 4 to elevate pressure, or reduce grid size to demand faster reaction times.

Drill 2: Ground Ball Zig-Zag - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Warm up the lower body while practicing clean ground ball pickups. Setup: 15m line of 5 cones spaced 3m apart in a zig-zag pattern, 1 football per pair.

Progression/Description:

1. Player A rolls the ball firmly toward the first cone.
2. Player B runs, bends to pick up the ball at the cone, and immediately handballs back to Player A.
3. Player B then runs to the next cone while Player A rolls it again.
4. Repeat to the end of the cones and swap roles. Coaching Points: Bend the knees, not just the back. Keep two hands firmly on the ball. Ensure smooth momentum through the ball rather than stopping. Progression/Regression: Roll the ball at faster speeds or introduce a bounce to challenge hand-eye coordination.

Drill 3: Prep-To-Play Bump and Land - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Introduce safe contact absorption and stable athletic landing. Setup: Pairs of players of similar size, 10x10m open area, no equipment. Progression/Description:

1. Players jog side-by-side.
2. On the coach's call, they gently jump off one leg.
3. They make side-to-side shoulder contact in the air.
4. They focus on landing in a stable, athletic stance (knees bent, feet shoulder-width apart). Coaching Points: Keep arms tucked in. Brace the core before contact. Land softly to absorb impact through the hips and knees. Progression/Regression: Progress to chest-on-chest contact with a bump bag if available, ensuring players do not lead with the head.

Drill 4: Rapid Fire Handball Circle - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Enhance reaction time, peripheral vision, and quick hands. Setup: Groups of 6-8 players forming a circle (5m diameter), 2 footballs per group. Progression/Description:

1. Players handball the two footballs randomly across the circle simultaneously.
2. A player cannot hold the ball for more than one second.
3. If a ball is dropped, the group must complete 3 star jumps before resuming.
Coaching Points: Always present hands as a target. Communicate by calling the receivers name before disposal. Keep the punching hand firm.
Progression/Regression: Add a third football for elite groups, or place one defender in the middle to pressure the disposals.

Drill 5: The Ocean Run - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Practice dodging and evasion under external stimulus. Setup: 20x30m grid, all players lined up on one baseline, coaches or helpers on the sidelines with 5 footballs.

Progression/Description:

1. Players must sprint from one end of the grid to the other.
2. Coaches roll or low-kick footballs horizontally across the grid.
3. If a player is hit below the waist by a ball, they join the sidelines to help roll balls.
4. The last player standing wins. Coaching Points: Use side-steps and sudden stops to evade. Keep eyes constantly scanning both sidelines. Accelerate quickly out of a dodge. Progression/Regression: Allow sideline players to handball the ball at the runners legs (softly) to increase the volume of moving obstacles.

Drill 6: Follow the Leader Agility - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Develop mirroring skills, lateral movement, and cardiovascular readiness. Setup: Pairs of players, scattered across half a field. Progression/Description:

1. Player A is the leader, Player B is the shadow.
2. Player A runs randomly, utilizing sprints, stops, jumps, side-steps, and backpedals.
3. Player B must stay exactly one meter behind, mimicking every movement.
4. Swap roles after 45 seconds. Coaching Points: Shadows must watch the leaders hips to anticipate movement. Leaders should use explosive changes of pace to challenge the shadow. Progression/Regression: Introduce a football so the leader must bounce the ball while evading, increasing the cognitive load.

Drill 7: 360 Degree Reaction Ball - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Improve auditory reaction time and explosive first steps. Setup: Groups of 4 forming a tight square around 1 central football on the ground. Progression/Description:

1. Players jog on the spot, facing away from the football.
2. The coach calls out commands (touch knees, touch head, jump).
3. When the coach yells Ball, players must spin 180 degrees and dive to secure the ground ball. Coaching Points: React to the voice instantly. Drive the hands aggressively to the ground. Protect the ball with the body once secured. Progression/Regression: Have players start lying on their stomachs or backs to increase the physical demand of getting to the ball.

Drill 8: Handball Relay Chase - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Combine running speed with execution of skills under pursuit. Setup: 2 teams, 2 parallel lines of cones extending 20m, 1 ball per team. Progression/Description:

1. Player 1 sprints to the end cone, turns, and handballs back to Player 2.
2. Player 2 marks the ball, sprints to the end cone, and handballs to Player 3.
3. Teams race to finish first. Coaching Points: Execute the handball on the move if possible. Ensure the non-preferred hand is used on the return sprint. Punch directly through the ball to the target. Progression/Regression: Require players to bounce the ball halfway, or stipulate that any dropped catch requires the player to restart their run.

Drill 9: Keepings Off Warm-Up - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Transition from physical warmup to tactical possession awareness. Setup: 15x15m grid, 5 attackers vs 2 defenders (in bibs), 1 football. Progression/Description:

1. The 5 attackers must maintain possession using handballs only.
2. The defenders attempt to intercept or tag the ball carrier.
3. Attackers aim for 10 consecutive handballs to score a point. Coaching Points: Move immediately after disposing of the ball. Create triangles to provide two passing options to the ball carrier. Defenders must communicate to trap the ball carrier in a corner. Progression/Regression: Restrict attackers to non-dominant hand handballs only, or expand to 6v3 to increase congestion.

Drill 10: Dynamic Kicking Lines - Dynamic Warm-ups Objective: Loosen leg muscles while practicing technique on the run. Setup: Two lines of players facing each other 20m apart, 2 footballs. Progression/Description:

1. The first player in Line A jogs forward and executes a drop punt to the first player in Line B.
2. The kicker then sprints to the back of Line B.

3. The receiver marks, jogs forward, and kicks back to Line A.
4. The drill flows continuously. Coaching Points: Drop the ball smoothly with the guiding hand. Maintain a steady jogging rhythm while kicking do not stop to kick. Point the toes at the target on follow-through.
Progression/Regression: Mandate a specific type of kick (e.g., low stab kick, high looping kick) or use the non-preferred foot.

Category 2: Advanced Skill Grids (Disposal under Pressure & Switching Play)

These ten drills transition fundamental skills into dynamic frameworks. The focus is on executing precision kicks and handballs while dealing with spatial constraints and moving targets, which are crucial for team transition play.

Drill 11: The Diamond Passing Drill - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Improve quick ball movement, leading, and kicking to advantage. Setup: 4 cones set up in a large diamond shape (20m between cones), 8-10 players, 2 footballs.

Progression/Description:

1. Player 1 at the bottom cone kicks to Player 2 leading from the right cone.
2. Player 2 marks and kicks to Player 3 leading from the top cone.
3. Players follow their kick to the next cone.
4. Introduce a second ball simultaneously to increase tempo. Coaching Points: Time the lead so you are moving at full speed when the ball arrives. Kick the ball to the space in front of the leading player, not behind them. Communicate loudly. Progression/Regression: Constrain the leads to be 100 percent lateral (sideways) to force lower, harder kicks that simulate game-day pressure.

Drill 12: Continuous Switch of Play - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Teach players to rapidly change the angle of attack to the fat side. Setup: 30x30m grid divided into three vertical lanes, 12 players, 1 ball.

Progression/Description:

1. The ball starts in the left lane.
2. Players must move the ball forward.
3. They are required to switch the ball to the middle lane, and then to the right lane, before reaching the end of the grid. Coaching Points: Look laterally before looking forward. The player on the fat side (right lane) must yell to demand the ball. Deliver the switch kick quickly before the defense can shift. Progression/Regression: Place two passive defenders in the grid who only shift side to side, forcing the attackers to switch the

ball over or around them.

Drill 13: Pressure Square Handballing - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Execute clean handballs while physical pressure is imminent. Setup: 10x10m grid, 4 attackers on the outside, 1 defender inside, 1 ball. Progression/Description:

1. Attackers move around the perimeter and handball across the square.
2. The defender aggressively pressures the ball carrier and attempts to intercept.
3. If the defender touches the ball or ball carrier, they swap with the attacker who made the error. Coaching Points: Use peripheral vision to spot the open man. Do not panic when the defender approaches hold the ball until the last second to draw them in, then release. Progression/Regression: Add a second defender (4v2) to dramatically increase the pressure, forcing attackers to use overhead or bounce handballs to escape.

Drill 14: Overlap Run and Carry - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Develop the tactical habit of running past the ball carrier to provide support. Setup: 40m long lane, pairs of players, 1 ball per pair. Progression/Description:

1. Player A runs forward and bounces the ball.
 2. Player B sprints from behind, runs closely past Player A (creating an overlap), and calls for the ball.
 3. Player A handballs to Player B.
 4. Player B takes a bounce and kicks to a target at the end of the lane.
- Coaching Points: The overlapping player must communicate early and loudly. The ball carrier must deliver a soft, perfectly timed handball to the runners advantage. Progression/Regression: Introduce a trailing defender who chases the pair, forcing them to execute the overlap at absolute maximum speed.

Drill 15: Zig-Zag Handball Chains - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Maintain possession through rapid, sequential handpasses in tight corridors. Setup: 20m grid with staggered cones every 5m creating a zig-zag path, groups of 5. Progression/Description:

1. Players space out at the cones.
2. The ball is handballed rapidly down the chain from cone to cone.
3. Once the ball reaches the end, the last player runs it to the start.
4. The goal is to move the ball flawlessly from start to finish in under 5 seconds. Coaching Points: Catch and release in one fluid motion. Step toward

your target as you punch the ball. Keep the platform hand steady.
Progression/Regression: Require players to alternate left and right handballs at each station, or time the groups to create competition.

Drill 16: Kicking into the Bomb Zone - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Practice depth control and hitting specific spatial zones on the run. Setup: 30m kicking distance, ending in a 5x5m marked square (the bomb zone), 1 ball per player.
Progression/Description:

1. Players take a short run-up.
2. They must execute a drop punt that lands exactly inside the 5x5m bomb zone.
3. Players retrieve their own kicks.
4. Award 3 points for a direct hit in the zone, 1 point if it bounces in.

Coaching Points: Keep the head over the ball during the drop. Ensure a straight follow-through directly toward the target zone. Do not lean back upon impact. Progression/Regression: Move the bomb zone to 40m to test power, or place a tall cone in the center of the zone that players must avoid hitting.

Drill 17: Front and Center Crumbing - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Teach midfielders and forwards how to read the ball off a marking contest. Setup: Coach stands 20m out from goal with a bump pad. Players form a line 30m out.
Progression/Description:

1. The coach throws the ball high into the air.
2. Player 1 sprints in, but instead of marking, the coach knocks the ball to the ground.
3. Player 1 must read the drop, gather the ground ball at speed, and snap a goal (a quick, instinctive kick across the body aiming for the goalposts).
Coaching Points: Do not stop moving when the ball is in the air. Anticipate the unpredictable bounce. Get low, gather cleanly, and transition immediately into the kick. Progression/Regression: Have two players run in simultaneously to compete for the crumb, adding a contested physical element to the gather.

Drill 18: Four Corners Transition - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Enhance spatial awareness and long-range kicking accuracy. Setup: 40x40m large square, players divided equally into the 4 corners, 2 footballs.
Progression/Description:

1. Corner 1 kicks diagonally to Corner 3.

2. Simultaneously, Corner 2 kicks diagonally to Corner 4.
3. Players must time their leads so the footballs do not collide in the center.
4. The receiver marks and handballs to the next person in their line. Coaching Points: Call the receivers name to ensure they are looking. Use a penetrating drop punt. Adjust the kick trajectory to avoid the crossing traffic. Progression/Regression: Reverse the direction to the non-preferred foot, or add a player in the middle whose job is to attempt to intercept the diagonal kicks.

Drill 19: Give The Ball Air Target Practice - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Master the high, looping kick to allow teammates to run underneath it. Setup: 20m distance to a tall target (e.g., a goalpost, light pole, or coach holding a pad). Progression/Description:

1. Players practice kicking the ball high so that it drops vertically down onto the target.
2. The focus is purely on the height and straightness of the trajectory. Coaching Points: Lean slightly further back than a standard stab pass. Strike the ball with a firm ankle to generate backspin. Watch the rotation of the ball in flight. Progression/Regression: Have a teammate start 10m behind the target and sprint forward as the ball is kicked, timing their run to mark the high ball right at the target.

Drill 20: Sideline Boundary Escape - Advanced Skill Grids Objective: Teach players how to navigate the ball out of a congested boundary area. Setup: 15x15m grid pinned against the boundary line. 3 attackers, 2 defenders. Progression/Description:

1. The coach throws the ball in from the boundary.
2. The 3 attackers must win the ball and string together two kicks or handballs.
3. They must deliver the ball to a target player positioned 20m inside the corridor. Coaching Points: Do not kick blindly down the line. Use handballs to draw the defenders, then kick to the open man in the center. Protect the ball on the boundary side. Progression/Regression: Make the target player a moving target, or add a strict 5-second time limit for the attackers to clear the ball from the grid.

Category 3: Contested Possession & Ground Ball Clearance Drills

At the Under 12 level, mastering the contested ground ball is a primary

discriminator of talent. These ten drills demand physical commitment, proper technique to protect the body, and rapid execution under immediate tackling pressure.

Drill 21: Step Over the Footy Technique - Contested Possession Objective: Ingrain the habit of protecting the body during ground ball gathers. Setup: 10m lane, 1 ball stationary in the middle, coach with a bump bag. Progression/Description:

1. Player sprints toward the ball.
2. The coach applies moderate pressure with the bump bag.
3. The player must step their lead leg outside the ball, gather it while absorbing the bump, drive through the contest, and execute a handball. Coaching Points: Lead leg outside the football to act as a shield. Drive forward through the ball, never stop over it. Stay low to maintain a strong center of gravity. Progression/Regression: Roll the ball toward the player to simulate a moving target, or replace the bump bag with a passive player applying body pressure.

Drill 22: 1v1 Ground Ball Combat - Contested Possession Objective: Win the contested ground ball against a direct opponent. Setup: 10x10m grid, players in pairs, 1 ball. Progression/Description:

1. The coach rolls the ball randomly into the grid.
2. Both players sprint from the baseline to win the ball.
3. The player who secures it must evade their opponent and kick to a target.
4. The loser must apply a legal wrap-around tackle or smother. Coaching Points: Attack the ball aggressively. Turn the body side-on to protect the space. If you lose the ball, transition instantly into defensive tackling mode. Progression/Regression: Start the players on their stomachs, facing away from the ball, to test reaction and recovery speed.

Drill 23: The 2v1 Disadvantage Pit - Contested Possession Objective: Teach players to support teammates in uneven contests and force turnovers. Setup: 15x15m grid, 2 defenders vs 1 attacker, coach feeds the ball. Progression/Description:

1. The coach kicks a high ball into the grid.
2. The single attacker must attempt to mark or gather.
3. The two defenders must communicate one goes for the ball, the other stays front-and-center for the crumb or applies the tackle. Coaching Points:

Defenders must talk (My ball! or Ive got the man!). The attacker must try to bring the ball to ground safely if out-marked. Progression/Regression: Swap the ratio to 2 attackers vs 1 defender to practice offensive crumbing and overlapping handballs out of a contest.

Drill 24: Wrap-Around Tackle Technique - Contested Possession Objective: Safely introduce the Under 12 wrap-around tackle mechanics. Setup: Pairs of similar size, walking pace, 10x10m area. Progression/Description:

1. Player A walks with the ball.
2. Player B approaches from the front/side, drops their hips, and pins Player A's arms.
3. Player B executes a controlled wrap-around hold. No taking to the ground is allowed. Swap roles. Coaching Points: Cheek to cheek (keep head close to the opponents back/side to avoid head clashes). Squeeze the arms tight to prevent disposal. Do not drag down. Progression/Regression: Increase the speed to a light jog once technique is perfected, ensuring the focus remains on pinning the arms safely.

Drill 25: Clear the Congestion - Contested Possession Objective: Extract the ball cleanly from a packed stoppage (a pause in play where the umpire restarts the game via a ball-up or throw-in) environment. Setup: 15x15m grid, 4 attackers, 4 defenders, ball starts on the ground in the middle.

Progression/Description:

1. On the whistle, all players collapse on the ball.
2. The attacking team must win the ball and string together three handballs to clear it out of the grid.
3. Defenders tackle and smother. Coaching Points: First player to the ball must stay on their feet. Teammates must stay on the outside of the pack to provide a handball outlet. Do not just hack it blindly on the boot.
Progression/Regression: Mandate that the first disposal must be a backward handball (to a quarterback role) to open up the play before moving forward.

Drill 26: Ruck Tap to Rover - Contested Possession Objective: Coordinate stoppage synergy between the ruckman and the midfield receiver. Setup: Center circle setup, 1 ruck and 1 rover (the ruck is the tall player who contests the ball-up; the rover is the smaller midfielder who gathers the tap) per team, coach throws the ball up. Progression/Description:

1. The coach simulates a ball-up.

2. Rucks compete to tap the ball down to their respective rovers, who are moving dynamically around the circle.
3. The rover must gather and burst out of the circle. Coaching Points: Rucks must use an open hand and jump off one leg. Rovers must read the rucks body language and not stand still waiting for the ball. Protect the drop zone. Progression/Regression: Add a tackling midfielder to pressure the rover immediately upon gathering the ball.

Drill 27: Spoiling from Behind - Contested Possession Objective: Teach defenders how to kill a marking contest without giving away a free kick. Setup: 20m distance, 1 kicker, 1 forward, 1 defender starting 2m behind the forward. Progression/Description:

1. The kicker lofts the ball to the forward.
2. The defender must close the gap, leap, and punch the ball away with a closed fist.
3. They must do this before the forward can mark it, avoiding contact with the forwards back. Coaching Points: Keep eyes on the ball, not the player. Use a straight arm to punch. Spoil aggressively toward the boundary line, never back into the corridor. Progression/Regression: Require the defender to gather the ball immediately after spoiling to practice the second-effort transition.

Drill 28: Boundary Throw-In Simulation - Contested Possession Objective: Win possession from a chaotic boundary stoppage. Setup: Boundary line, coach acts as umpire, 3 players per team in the grid. Progression/Description:

1. Coach throws the ball in from the boundary.
2. Teams compete to win the tap and gather the ground ball.
3. The team that wins possession must kick it to a target set up 30m inside the field. Coaching Points: Anticipate the curve of the throw-in. Midfielders must block opponents using their bodies. Extract the ball toward the center, not down the line. Progression/Regression: Place a time limit of 5 seconds to clear the ball, forcing faster decision-making under physical duress.

Drill 29: Defensive Second Efforts - Contested Possession Objective: Instill the mindset of continuous effort after a failed initial contest. Setup: 15m lane, 1 ball, 1 attacker, 1 defender. Progression/Description:

1. Defender starts on their stomach.
2. Attacker starts with the ball 5m ahead and jogs toward a goal.

3. Defender must jump up, chase down the attacker, and apply a tackle or smother the kick before they cross the line. Coaching Points: Never give up on the play. Use explosive arm drive to recover from the ground quickly. Aim to smother the boot if a tackle is out of reach. Progression/Regression: Decrease the attackers head start to reward the defender, or increase it to demand absolute maximum sprinting effort.

Drill 30: Bump and Gather Gauntlet - Contested Possession Objective: Maintain composure and ball control while receiving physical bumps. Setup: 20m lane, 3 coaches or helpers with bump bags spaced out along the lane, 1 ball.

Progression/Description:

1. The player starts with the ball and runs down the lane.
2. At each station, the coach applies a moderate bump.
3. The player must absorb the bump, maintain balance, bounce the ball once, and reach the end to kick a goal. Coaching Points: Brace the core upon impact. Keep the ball secure against the body when taking the hit. Quickly steady the body before attempting the bounce. Progression/Regression: Have players gather a ground ball immediately after the final bump to test recovery and fine motor skills under fatigue.

Category 4: Game Sense, Spatial Awareness & Boundary/Corridor Grids

This category utilizes implicit learning. By manipulating space and rules, coaches force players to independently solve tactical problems regarding time, space, risk, and execution.

Drill 31: Pod Ball Target Game - Game Sense Objective: Develop spatial awareness and the ability to find targets in a 360-degree environment. Setup: 30x30m grid, 3 small 5m circles (pods) marked inside. 6v6 players.

Progression/Description:

1. The attacking team must maintain possession.
2. They score by successfully kicking the ball to a teammate standing inside any of the three pods.
3. Defenders try to intercept. Coaching Points: Attackers must constantly move to create space. Do not cluster around one pod spread the field. Use short, precise kicks to hit the target. Progression/Regression: Mandate that the ball must be handballed twice before a kick into a pod is allowed, teaching patience in possession.

Drill 32: The Corridor Attack - Game Sense Objective: Train players to prioritize the center of the ground for aggressive attacking play. Setup: 50m long field. Mark a 15m wide central corridor down the middle. 8v8.

Progression/Description:

1. Teams play a normal scrimmage.
2. Goals scored from a possession initiated inside the marked corridor are worth double points. Coaching Points: Look laterally to shift the ball into the center. Defenders must squeeze inward to protect the corridor. Attackers must lead into the center space. Progression/Regression: Penalize teams for moving the ball down the extreme boundary by awarding a free kick to the opposition if the ball is trapped there for too long.

Drill 33: Multi-Ball Chaos Grid - Game Sense Objective: Enhance peripheral vision and rapid decision-making in a high-traffic area. Setup: 25x25m grid, 12 players, 3 footballs simultaneously in play. Progression/Description:

1. Players must kick and handball the 3 balls continuously among their teammates while avoiding collisions.
2. If two balls touch or are dropped, the group performs push-ups. Coaching Points: Loud, clear communication is essential. Scan the entire grid before disposing of the ball. Be aware of players running blindly into your path. Progression/Regression: Introduce 2 defenders (in bibs) whose sole job is to intercept any of the three balls, elevating the risk factor.

Drill 34: Outnumber or Stay - Game Sense Objective: Teach players when to leave their direct opponent to support a contest. Setup: 20x20m grid. 3 attackers, 3 defenders. Coach with the ball on the sideline. Progression/Description:

1. Coach kicks the ball to a 1v1 contest in the grid.
2. The other two pairs must decide whether to sprint in to create an outnumber (overlap) or stay back to guard their direct opponent.
3. They must assess the risk of the ball spilling loose. Coaching Points: Freeze the drill and ask: Why did you run in? Did you leave your man dangerously open? Teach players to assess the risk of the bounce. Progression/Regression: Award extra points to the defense if they intercept the ball and successfully kick it back to the coach.

Drill 35: Switch to the Fat Side - Game Sense Objective: Hardwire the instinct to look for open space on the opposite side of the field. Setup: 40m wide field divided in half longitudinally. 6v4 in favor of attackers.

Progression/Description:

1. Attackers start in the left half and are pressured by all 4 defenders.
2. To score, attackers must switch the ball across the halfway line into the empty right half (the fat side).
3. They must then hit a leading target. Coaching Points: Draw the defenders to one side before switching. The switch kick must be long, fast, and flat to avoid being intercepted. Progression/Regression: If the attackers fail to switch within 4 disposals, possession is turned over.

Drill 36: Spatial Awareness Tag - Game Sense Objective: Develop implicit understanding of zones and defensive spacing. Setup: 30x30m grid, divided into 4 smaller squares. 1 tagger, 6 runners. Progression/Description:

1. Runners must evade the tagger, but there is a rule: no more than two runners can occupy the same small square at any time.
2. If a third runner enters, the person who has been there the longest must sprint to another square. Coaching Points: Keep heads on a swivel to monitor where teammates are. Communicate to trigger rotations. Anticipate the taggers path to maintain optimal spacing. Progression/Regression: Add a football that must be handballed between the runners, integrating technical execution with spatial rules.

Drill 37: 5-Point Pressure Handball - Game Sense Objective: Execute skills under severe fatigue and time constraints. Setup: 15x15m grid, 5 attackers, 2 defenders, 1 ball. Progression/Description:

1. Attackers must string together 5 consecutive handballs to score a point.
2. Defenders apply maximum pressure.
3. The drill runs continuously for 3 minutes without stopping for out-of-bounds (coach immediately feeds a new ball). Coaching Points: When fatigued, rely on fundamental technique. Keep moving to space. Defenders must work in tandem to corral the ball carrier into a corner. Progression/Regression: Increase to 3 defenders if attackers are scoring too easily, forcing faster ball movement.

Drill 38: Boundary Line Squeeze - Game Sense Objective: Defensively trap the opposition on the boundary offensively escape the trap. Setup: 20x20m grid utilizing the actual boundary line. 4v4. Progression/Description:

1. The coach throws the ball into the grid.

2. The attacking team aims to move the ball into the center of the field.
3. The defending team aims to tackle the attackers over the boundary line or force a rushed kick out of bounds. Coaching Points: Defenders must set up with their backs to the corridor, forcing the attacker toward the line. Attackers must use quick handballs to break the defensive wall. Progression/Regression: Reward the defending team with a point for every successful tackle over the boundary line.

Drill 39: Decision Making Under Fatigue - Game Sense Objective: Replicate the cognitive breakdown of the fourth quarter and train through it. Setup: 30m lane. 1 ball, groups of 3. Progression/Description:

1. Players complete a 20-second high-intensity sprint and burpee circuit.
2. Immediately upon finishing, the coach rolls a ball.
3. The player must gather it, assess two targets (one 10m away, one 25m away), and hit the optimal target based on a defenders position. Coaching Points: Take a deep breath to steady the heart rate before kicking. Focus intensely on the ball drop when legs are heavy. Assess the risk correctly. Progression/Regression: Have the defender actively pressure the kicker rather than just guarding the targets, forcing a rushed decision.

Drill 40: Target Man Grid - Game Sense Objective: Practice hitting a designated forward target in a congested area. Setup: 30x30m grid. 5v5 in the main area, 1 designated Target Man inside a small 5x5m square in the center. Progression/Description:

1. The attacking team must maintain possession and look for an opening to kick safely to the Target Man.
2. Defenders guard the attackers and attempt to block passing lanes to the center. Coaching Points: Use peripheral vision. Do not force the kick if the lane is blocked retain possession and wait for the defense to shift. The Target Man must move actively within their small square. Progression/Regression: Allow one defender to enter the center square to directly contest the Target Man, simulating a 1v1 forward entry.

Category 5: Match Simulations & Tactical Small-Sided Games

The final ten drills synthesize all technical and tactical components into structured, highly competitive match scenarios. These drills prepare Under 12 players for full-field execution, focusing on positional roles and team plans.

Drill 41: Fifty Footy - Match Simulations Objective: Practice forward line entries, leading, and defensive rebounding. Setup: Full 50m arc area. 8v8 teams. Coach stands in the center square. Progression/Description:

1. The coach throws the ball up in the midfield.
2. The winning team attacks the 50m arc to score a goal.
3. If the defending team intercepts, they must transition the ball cleanly outside the 50m arc to score a point and reset the drill. Coaching Points: Forwards must stagger their leads so they don't all run to the same space. Defenders must punch from behind and quickly spread out to rebound. Progression/Regression: Mandate that the attacking team must mark the ball inside 50m before kicking for goal, eliminating rushed snaps.

Drill 42: Kick-In vs Zone Defense - Match Simulations Objective: Teach defensive players how to set up a zone, and offensive players how to break it. Setup: Defensive 50m arc. 1 kicker at full-back, 6 attackers vs 6 defenders. Progression/Description:

1. Defenders set up a structured zone (guarding space rather than specific players) across the 50m arc.
2. The kicker must find a teammate to safely transition the ball out of defense. Coaching Points: Defenders must hold their line and communicate to shift the zone as the kicker looks around. Attackers must use dummy leads to draw defenders out of their zones and create space. Progression/Regression: Restrict the kicker to a 5-second time limit to force quick decision-making against the zone structure.

Drill 43: Kick-In vs Man-on-Man - Match Simulations Objective: Execute kick-ins under strict, accountable man-on-man pressure. Setup: Defensive 50m arc. 1 kicker at full-back, 6 attackers vs 6 defenders. Progression/Description:

1. Defenders play strict man-on-man accountability.
2. The kicker must direct traffic, asking teammates to block or create isolation plays to get free for the kick-in. Coaching Points: Defenders must stay goal-side of their opponent. Attackers need to utilize explosive changes of pace to lose their defender. The kicker must hit the target cleanly on the chest. Progression/Regression: Award the defense a free shot at goal if they successfully intercept the kick-in, increasing the stakes of the drill.

Drill 44: Stoppage to Forward 50 Entry - Match Simulations Objective: Link

clearance (successfully winning the ball from a stoppage and transitioning it into open play) execution directly to a structured forward entry. Setup: Half field. 4 midfielders, 4 forwards, 4 defenders. Ball starts on the wing.

Progression/Description:

1. Coach initiates a stoppage on the wing.
2. Midfielders must win the clearance, burst forward, and deliver the ball into the forward 50m arc.
3. Forwards and defenders compete in a 4v4 contest. Coaching Points: Midfielders must not bomb the ball blindly look for a leading target. Forwards must leave the far side open for a teammate to lead into. Defenders must communicate who is peeling off to contest. Progression/Regression: Add a trailing midfielder who runs late into the forward line to provide an overlapping offensive option.

Drill 45: The Extra Player Game - Match Simulations Objective: Teach teams how to utilize a numerical advantage, or defend against one. Setup: 40x40m grid. 6v5 in favor of the attacking team. Progression/Description:

1. Play a standard small-sided game.
2. The attacking team must use their extra player to create overlaps and free men.
3. The defending team must use zoning and communication to cover the dangerous space despite being outnumbered. Coaching Points: Attackers must constantly look for the loose man. Defenders must prioritize guarding the corridor and forcing the ball wide to buy time. Progression/Regression: Without stopping play, the coach calls out a player from the attacking team to leave the grid, instantly flipping the numerical advantage to the defense.

Drill 46: End-to-End Transition - Match Simulations Objective: Maximize running capacity and link defensive rebounds to forward entries. Setup: Full field, reduced width. 10v10. Progression/Description:

1. Play starts with a kick-in from the full-back.
2. The team must transition the ball entirely through the midfield and score at the opposite end without the ball hitting the ground more than twice.
3. If they fail, the ball is turned over. Coaching Points: Players must run in waves to support the ball carrier. Use precise kicking to hit targets on the run. Do not slow down the play push the tempo aggressively. Progression/Regression: Require every player on the team to touch the ball at least once before a goal can be scored.

Drill 47: Goal Kicking Race - Match Simulations Objective: Execute set shots under immense physiological and psychological pressure. Setup: Two teams lined up 30m out from two different sets of goals (or staggered on one set). 1 ball per player. Progression/Description:

1. On the whistle, the first player from each team sprints to the 20m line and takes a set shot.
2. As soon as they kick, the next player goes.
3. The first team to kick 10 total goals wins. Coaching Points: Do not rush the ball drop. Stick to the set shot routine despite the race format. Follow through straight toward the target. Progression/Regression: Force players to run a 50m sprint before taking their shot, replicating the heavy legs of a late-game scenario.

Drill 48: Rule-Restricted Scrimmage - Match Simulations Objective: Force players to adapt their game style by removing default options. Setup: Half field. 9v9. Progression/Description:

1. Play a standard match simulation.
2. Impose a strict rule (e.g., Handball only, Every possession must be followed by a backwards kick, or Non-preferred foot only inside 50m). Coaching Points: Players must adapt cognitively to the constraints. Focus on the tactical shifts required (e.g., if handball only, players must run much harder to create continuous overlap options). Progression/Regression: Change the restriction every 3 minutes to keep players mentally agile and constantly reassessing their game plan.

Drill 49: Front and Square Match Play - Match Simulations Objective: Enforce the structural discipline of crumbing forward entries. Setup: Forward 50m arc. 6 attackers, 6 defenders. Progression/Description:

1. The coach kicks long bombs into the 50m arc.
2. While the key forwards and defenders contest the mark, the small forwards must establish the front and square position (10m in front of the contest) to gather any spills.
3. Once gathered, they must be ready to snap a goal (a quick, instinctive kick across the body aiming for the goalposts). Coaching Points: Small forwards must anticipate the drop of the ball. Do not get sucked into the physical marking contest. Stay grounded and balanced. Progression/Regression: Penalize the attacking team if no player is positioned front and square when

the ball hits the ground.

Drill 50: The Freeze Frame Final - Match Simulations Objective: Ultimate test of game sense, allowing real-time tactical correction. Setup: Full available field. 12v12 (or maximum available numbers). Progression/Description:

1. Play a full, unconstrained match simulation.
2. At random intervals, the coach blows a loud whistle and yells Freeze!
3. All players must immediately stop and hold their positions.
4. The coach then asks players about their current spatial awareness (Time, Space, Risk). Coaching Points: Ask a midfielder: Where is your direct opponent? Ask a defender: Who is guarding the corridor? Use this to explicitly point out spatial errors in real-time. Progression/Regression: Let play resume instantly from the freeze, demanding that players immediately action the tactical corrections discussed during the stoppage.

SENIOR WOMEN

Senior Women's Coaching Best Practices

Coaching the Senior Women's squad is about establishing and executing the ultimate benchmark for the football club. These are adult athletes, many balancing demanding careers with elite amateur football. Your role is to build a high-performance environment that maximizes their time on the track, translating complex tactical systems into brutal, uncompromising match-day execution. When they run out onto the field, the objective is total physical and structural dominance.

Building the Tactical Identity

Senior Women's football has evolved rapidly. It is no longer just about who is the toughest at the contest; it is about sophisticated ball movement and suffocating defense.

* **The Run-and-Carry Weapon:** While kicking distance continues to improve, the most devastating weapon in the women's game remains the overlap run. Your half-backs and wingers must be conditioned to break the lines, take the bounce, and draw a defender before releasing the ball.

* **The Defensive Web:** You must implement a full 18-player defensive zone. The women need to understand how to squeeze the ground, protect the corridor, and force the opposition into slow, boundary-line football where your numbers can trap them.

Physical Dominance and Contact Safety

The physical intent must be ruthless. You want a team that embraces the contest, hits hard, and intimidates the opposition through sheer, unrelenting pressure—going out there and sticking it up their arse from the first bounce. However, this aggression must be underpinned by flawless technique. ACL injuries and concussions remain significant risks in the women's game. High-tempo training must constantly reinforce safe deceleration mechanics, cheek-to-cheek tackle technique, and proper landing protocols. You cannot assume these habits are fully ingrained; they must be practiced under fatigue.

Match-Day Load and Game Intelligence

Training must replicate the exact cardiovascular and cognitive load of a Saturday afternoon. Eradicate static drills. Every drill must involve decision-making, physical pressure, and match-realistic spacing. Teach them the game intelligence required to manage the clock, reset the 6-6-6 structure instantly after a goal, and execute red-time scenarios autonomously. Your leaders on the field need to be an extension of your coaching brain, calling the switches and adjusting the forward press on the fly.

THE 50-DRILL SENIOR WOMEN'S LIBRARY

DRILL 1: ELITE DECELERATION AND GATHER - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Injury prevention via safe deceleration combined with clean ball gathering.

SETUP: 20m lanes, pairs, 1 football per pair.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A sprints at top speed toward Player B. At the 10m mark, Player B rolls a rapid groundball. Player A must execute a sudden, controlled deceleration, dropping their hips, maintaining knee alignment, scooping the ball cleanly, and immediately changing direction to exit the lane.

COACHING POINTS: Do not let the knees cave inward on deceleration, drop your center of gravity, one clean scoop, explosive exit.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a passive defender to apply light body pressure as the player decelerates.

DRILL 2: REACTIVE VISION GRID - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Processing peripheral information while executing technical skills.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 8 players, 2 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players continuously handball within the grid. The coach stands outside holding colored cones. Before disposing of the ball, the player must verbally call out the color of the cone the coach is currently holding.

COACHING POINTS: Eyes must flick from the target to the coach and back instantly, do not hold the ball, fast hands.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase to 3 footballs to elevate the cognitive load and spatial traffic.

DRILL 3: CONTINUOUS OVERLAP ENGINE - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Sustaining high-speed overlap running patterns.

SETUP: Full length of the center square, groups of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The group moves end-to-end. The ball carrier executes a handball to the outside runner, then immediately sprints to the outside of the chain to become the next overlap option. The movement is continuous and unbroken.

COACHING POINTS: Never decelerate to receive the ball, deliver the handball out in front, vocalize your run aggressively.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that the final disposal must be a 30-meter penetrating kick on the run.

DRILL 4: TRAFFIC LIGHT CHAOS - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Instant cognitive reaction and disposal execution.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 12 players, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players circulate the ball. The coach calls out commands.

Green means play on via hand. Red means the ball must immediately be placed on the deck for the nearest player to scoop. Yellow means the player must execute a sharp pivot and hold the ball for 3 seconds against pressure.

COACHING POINTS: React instantly to the auditory cue, protect the football on the yellow command, maintain a wide base.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 dedicated defenders who only try to intercept the ball on the green command.

DRILL 5: RUCK TO ROVER BURST - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Timing the clearance run to hit the drop zone at maximum velocity.

SETUP: 20m circle, 1 ruck, 3 rovers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruck tosses the ball high and taps it randomly into space. Rovers must hold their run until the ball is descending, then explode through the drop zone, gathering cleanly without breaking stride.

COACHING POINTS: Read the ruck's hand placement, stay on your toes, snatch the ball cleanly at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a heavy bumping pad at the exit point that the rover must absorb upon exiting.

DRILL 6: THE ZIG-ZAG GROUND BALL COURSE - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Flawless groundball mechanics at high speed and shifting angles.

SETUP: 50m zig-zag cone course, individual players, 5 footballs placed at intervals.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint the course. At each ball, they must scoop it cleanly, execute a rapid handball to a coach on the outside, and immediately accelerate to the next ball without decelerating.

COACHING POINTS: Get low through the hips, scoop cleanly with two hands where possible, transition to disposal instantly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the balls erratically toward the player instead of them being stationary.

DRILL 7: CONGESTION EVASION AND FEND - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Navigating tight traffic using agility, core strength, and ball protection.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 5 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers must traverse the grid. Defenders are instructed to bump and block, but not tackle. Attackers must use lateral steps, legal fends, and core strength to break through to the other side.

COACHING POINTS: Keep a wide base, use the hips to absorb contact, keep the football tucked tight on the non-contact side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Upgrade the defenders to full tackling pressure for a live simulation.

DRILL 8: SHUTTLE SPRINT TO WRESTLE - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Executing contested strength after heavy cardiovascular output.

SETUP: 30m sprint lane, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players sprint 30m, touch a line, sprint back 15m, and instantly engage in a 1v1 grappling contest over a stationary football for 8 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Fight through the lung burn, establish low body position early, lock your core and hold your ground.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the players lying flat on their backs before the initial sprint.

DRILL 9: AERIAL TIMING AND LANDING - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: Attacking the mark at the highest point and landing safely on a single leg.

SETUP: 20m distance, 1 kicker, 1 receiver.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker lofts the ball high. The receiver runs in, jumps off one leg, takes the mark at full extension, and must focus on landing softly, absorbing the impact through a bent knee to protect the ACL.

COACHING POINTS: Drive the knee up for elevation and protection, form a W with the hands, absorb the landing through the hips and knees.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a bumping bag that the receiver must jump into to simulate body contact in the air.

DRILL 10: RAPID FIRE TARGET KICKING - HIGH-TEMPO DYNAMIC WARM-UPS & AGILITY

OBJECTIVE: High-volume, elite-level kicking efficiency on the move.

SETUP: 40m lane, 6 players, 3 footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players work back and forth in pairs over 40m. Receive the ball on the run, take exactly three steps, and deliver a flat, hard drop punt to the chest of the next runner. The movement is relentless.

COACHING POINTS: Fast transition from hands to boot, steady the ball drop, punch through the kick directly at the target.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate non-preferred foot kicking for the entire drill.

DRILL 11: THE 45-DEGREE CORRIDOR DART - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Slicing through the first line of defense using aggressive inboard kicking.

SETUP: Half ground, 8 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play initiates at half-back. The ball carrier fakes a kick wide, pivots, and hits a midfielder bursting 45-degrees into the corridor. The receiver must play on instantly and drive a long kick inside 50.

COACHING POINTS: The corridor runner must time the lead perfectly, the kicker must disguise the pass, execute with zero hesitation.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a floating intercept defender specifically guarding the 45-degree passing lane.

DRILL 12: LIGHTNING FAT-SIDE SWITCH - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Rapid lateral ball movement to exploit the open wing.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to center wing, full width, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is trapped deep in a pocket. Players execute three rapid-fire lateral kicks across the defensive 50, ending with a half-back flanker streaming up the completely open opposite wing.

COACHING POINTS: Ball speed is everything, kicks must be flat and hard, receivers must already be moving laterally before they mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Impose a strict 8-second time limit to move the ball from the pocket to the opposite wing.

DRILL 13: LOWERING THE EYES UNDER PRESSURE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Identifying high-percentage targets inside 50 instead of defaulting to long bombs.

SETUP: Center square to forward 50, 5 midfielders, 5 forwards, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Midfielders break from a stoppage. Forwards execute staggered leads. The ball carrier must ignore the deep pack contest and hit a half-forward leading into space 30 meters from goal.

COACHING POINTS: Steady yourself before kicking, forwards must demand the ball in space, prioritize the uncontested chest mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are instructed to zone off and clog the deep forward line, making the long bomb impossible.

DRILL 14: THE ZIG-ZAG TRANSITION MATRIX - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Advancing the ball linearly through angled passing lanes.

SETUP: 80m length divided into 4 grids, 16 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball must travel from grid 1 to grid 4. Direct vertical kicks are banned. Every disposal must be an angled diagonal pass to a player in the next grid, forcing the defense to constantly shift laterally.

COACHING POINTS: Open the shoulders early, push off the mark instantly, receivers must lead into the diagonal space.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add token pressure on every kicker to force rapid decision-making and execution.

DRILL 15: SENIOR REBOUND 50 EXITS - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Flawless execution of structured defensive exit patterns.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 7 defenders, 5 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Fullback takes a kick-in. Defenders execute a pre-rehearsed exit to clear the pocket and switch to the center corridor. They must link up via hand and foot to cross the 50m arc.

COACHING POINTS: Exploit the full width of the ground, block aggressively for the designated receiver, always provide a backward safety release option.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Attackers set up in a rigid 15-meter zone that the defenders must carefully pick their way through.

DRILL 16: SWITCH, OVERLAP, AND PENETRATE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Combining a lateral switch with an immediate numerical overload forward.

SETUP: Half ground, 12 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play starts on the boundary. The ball is kicked laterally to the center. The central receiver plays on, and two teammates instantly run past to provide overlap options. The ball is carried forward and driven deep into attack.

COACHING POINTS: The central receiver must scan before marking, overlap runners must hold their width, execute the final kick with penetration.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Apply a physical tagger on the central receiver to disrupt the initial pivot.

DRILL 17: HALF-BACK WAVE DRIVE - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Breaking the lines from defense using relentless overlapping run and carry.

SETUP: Defensive 50 to half forward, 6v4 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders win a loose ball. The ball carrier takes off, and teammates spread instantly to provide overlapping handball options, overwhelming the 4 forwards to break through the lines.

COACHING POINTS: Run past the ball carrier to receive, commit the opposition before releasing the handball, keep the chain moving at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the defensive unit to take at least two bounces during the transition out of defense.

DRILL 18: THE CORRIDOR CHOKE-POINT - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Forcing precise ball movement through the most congested, dangerous area of the ground.

SETUP: Half ground, narrow cones funneling through the center square.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players transition the ball from deep defense but are restricted to kicking only within the narrow central funnel. Any disposal wide of the funnel is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Be courageous with the inboard kick, receivers must absorb contact and protect the drop zone, midfielders must work relentlessly to present.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Narrow the funnel further to demand absolute elite kicking precision.

DRILL 19: DEEP DEFENSIVE EXTRACTION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Escaping a high-pressure trap deep in the defensive pocket.

SETUP: Defensive pocket, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is locked deep. Defenders must use rapid, composed handballs to navigate out of the immediate congestion and find a short kicking target on the half-back flank to relieve the pressure.

COACHING POINTS: Maintain composure, use the boundary line to protect your blind side, execute the first handball perfectly to break the initial tackle.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to create a severe numerical disadvantage for the defense.

DRILL 20: 3-PLAYER SEAMLESS TRANSITION - ADVANCED BALL MOVEMENT & TRANSITION

OBJECTIVE: Synchronized forward running patterns executed at maximum velocity.

SETUP: Full length of the ground, groups of 3.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Three players move the ball end-to-end. One stays wide, one central, one crosses behind. They must exchange the ball continuously via kick and handball without any player dropping their forward momentum.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be elite, time leads flawlessly so no one is waiting on the ball, maintain the structural triangle spacing.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 2 chasing defenders starting 15 meters behind the group to enforce speed.

DRILL 21: ELITE INSIDE CONTEST 4V4 - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Dominating the hard ball and extracting it safely under severe physical pressure.

SETUP: 15x15m grid, 4v4 setup, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws the ball into the grid. The groups engage in a heavy physical contest. The objective is to win the ball, extract it from the congestion, and hit a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Drop your hips lower than the opposition, block off the ball to create exit lanes, communicate loudly who is taking the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach designates two players who are only allowed to block and cannot touch the football.

DRILL 22: RUCK TO ADVANTAGE EXPLOITATION - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing clearances from a dominant ruck tap.

SETUP: Center circle, 1 ruck, 3 midfielders per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ruck taps the ball to a specific pre-called zone. The designated sweeping midfielder times their run to take the ball on the burst and break the lines instantly.

COACHING POINTS: Midfielders must disguise their starting positions, ruck dictates the drop zone, the receiver must accelerate through the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck is permitted to physically hold the sweeping midfielder if the tap is inaccurate.

DRILL 23: DEFENSIVE BOUNDARY LOCKDOWN - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Structuring a stoppage to prevent opposition forward entries.

SETUP: Defensive 50 boundary throw-in, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Simulating a boundary throw-in. The defending team sets up a strict defensive structure, prioritizing the corridor block and forcing the opposition toward the boundary or into a secondary stoppage.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the defensive side fiercely, body up hard on direct opponents, communicate the sweeping roles clearly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team starts with possession and must attempt to break the defensive wall from a static start.

DRILL 24: OFFENSIVE POCKET SNAP - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Generating an immediate shot on goal from a forward pocket stoppage.

SETUP: Forward pocket boundary line, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach simulates a throw-in. The attacking team aims to win the tap, execute a quick handball chain to the top of the 50m arc, and snap a shot on goal within 6 seconds.

COACHING POINTS: Lock the ball in if the clearance is lost, prioritize front position at the drop, the receiver at the arc must command the ball loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict the attacking team to a maximum of one handball before a shot must be taken.

DRILL 25: ELITE TACKLE AND RELEASE - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Executing dominant tackles and successfully releasing the ball while being tackled safely.

SETUP: 12x12m grid, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A holds the ball. Player B engages in a heavy, legal tackle emphasizing hip wrapping. Player A must maintain footing, keep arms free, and execute a legal handball to a target outside the grid.

COACHING POINTS: Player B must pin an arm and drive through the hips. Player A must brace, turn to shield the ball, and elevate their hands early.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A starts on their knees and must power up through the tackle.

DRILL 26: THE SHARK AND ACCELERATE - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Anticipating the opposition's hit-out and intercepting the clearance.

SETUP: Center bounce, 1 dominant opposition ruck, 4 defensive midfielders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The opposition ruck is guaranteed to win the tap. The defensive mids must read the ruck's body language, intercept the tap, and instantly burst forward into open space.

COACHING POINTS: Lock eyes on the ruck's hands, stay light on your feet, accelerate the millisecond the ball is secured.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The opposition ruck fakes the tap to draw the mids offside before redirecting it.

DRILL 27: SENIOR CENTER BOUNCE EXECUTION - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Mastering modern center bounce restrictions and set plays.

SETUP: Center square, full 6-6-6 team setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach conducts a center bounce. The midfield executes a pre-planned set play to win the clearance, while forwards and defenders hold strict positional discipline until the ball clears the square.

COACHING POINTS: Wingers hold their width aggressively, forwards lead into the space created by the clearance, defenders remain goal-side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The clearance must result in a marked inside 50 entry to be deemed a success.

DRILL 28: EXTREME CONGESTION HANDBALLS - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Maintaining composed possession in severe traffic.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Both teams confined to a tiny grid. The objective is to string together 8 consecutive handballs without the opposition intercepting or tackling the ball carrier to the ground.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless movement, short and sharp handballs, protect the ball with your core, use your voice to command the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Shrink the grid to 8x8m to create absolute chaos.

DRILL 29: SHIELDING UNDER HEAVY HEAT - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Taking contested marks while absorbing heavy physical contact.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 1 attacker, 2 defenders, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker drops a high ball into the grid. The attacker must hold off both defenders, protect the drop zone using sheer body strength, and take a strong contested mark.

COACHING POINTS: Read the flight early, establish a wide and immovable base, use the arms to fend off legally, bring the ball securely to the chest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders are equipped with heavy bumping pads to apply maximum force on the attacker.

DRILL 30: GROUNDBALL OUTNUMBER EXPLOITATION - STOPPAGE, CLEARANCE & CONTESTED SYSTEMS

OBJECTIVE: Winning the hard ball and instantly exploiting a numerical advantage.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 5 attackers, 4 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach rolls a ball into dispute. Attackers must win the 5v4 groundball contest, instantly locate their loose player, and execute an uncontested pass out of the congestion.

COACHING POINTS: The first player to the ball must be violent and decisive, the loose player must hold their space and avoid getting sucked into the pack.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the attackers facing away from the ball to test reaction speed.

DRILL 31: FULL GROUND WEB DEFENSE - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Mastering full-ground structural defense and spatial coverage.

SETUP: Full ground, 18 defenders, 1 coach with a ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coach moves around the ground with the ball. The entire 18-player defensive unit must shift, slide, and compress to maintain the web structure, prioritizing dangerous spaces and blocking the corridor.

COACHING POINTS: Keep the gaps between defensive lines tight, point and talk relentlessly, wingers must drop back to cover the switch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce 8 attackers to run decoy lines and test the structural discipline of the defense.

DRILL 32: FORWARD HALF SUFFOCATION PRESS - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Locking the ball in the attacking half to force turnovers.

SETUP: Forward half, 12 forwards/mids, 10 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Defenders attempt to exit their defensive 50. The attacking team pushes up aggressively, locking down all short options and forcing the defenders to kick long to a contested outnumber.

COACHING POINTS: High half-forwards must push up to the arc, maintain a structural wall, tackle with absolute ferocity.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Defenders have only 12 seconds to exit the half or the drill resets with a penalty.

DRILL 33: ELITE INTERCEPT AND REBOUND - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Reading the play, leaving an opponent, and launching a counter-attack.

SETUP: Half-back flank, 4 defenders, 4 attackers, 1 kicker.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker targets a leading attacker. The designated intercept defender must peel off their opponent, read the flight, take the intercept mark, and instantly play on to a rebounding teammate.

COACHING POINTS: Back your judgment entirely, attack the ball at its highest point, never hesitate once you commit to leaving your opponent.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker deliberately drives the ball low and flat to compress the interception time.

DRILL 34: DEFENSIVE SLIDING MATRIX - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Seamlessly covering for teammates who leave their zone to apply pressure.

SETUP: 50x50m grid divided into 4 quadrants, 5v5 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers move the ball. When a defender leaves their quadrant to double-team the ball carrier, the adjacent defender must instantly slide over to cover the dangerous space left behind.

COACHING POINTS: Communication must be loud and proactive, head on a swivel, anticipate the lateral movement of the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 6th attacker to ensure there is always a loose player the defense must scramble to cover.

DRILL 35: INSTANT TURNOVER TRANSITION SPRINT - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Immediate physiological and tactical reaction from offense to defense.

SETUP: Half ground, 10v10 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Teams play normal scrimmage. On a sharp whistle blow, the team in possession must drop the ball and instantly transition to defense, finding an opponent and setting a zone within 4 seconds while the other team attacks.

COACHING POINTS: Do not drop your head, find a body immediately, sprint back to goal-side position.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Any player failing to find an opponent within 4 seconds is removed from the drill for one minute.

DRILL 36: CORRIDOR DENIAL LOCKDOWN - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Forcing the opposition into slow, boundary-line football.

SETUP: Center square and both wings, 8v8 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers attempt to move the ball from half-back to half-forward. Defenders set up an impenetrable wall across the center square, forcing all ball movement out wide to the boundary.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the line fiercely, do not get drawn out of the corridor, shepherd the ball carrier physically toward the boundary.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Award the attacking team triple points if they manage to pierce the center square wall.

DRILL 37: SMOTHER, CHASE, AND DESTROY - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Relentless desperation defense and second efforts on the kicker.

SETUP: 30m lane, 1 kicker, 2 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Kicker runs toward a target. Defender 1 approaches from the front to attempt a block/smother. If the kicker evades, Defender 2 chases from behind to execute a ferocious run-down tackle.

COACHING POINTS: Defender 1 commits fully to the smother. Defender 2 closes the gap with maximum speed and drags down safely by the hips.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The kicker has a strict 3-second limit to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 38: MAN-ON-MAN ACCOUNTABILITY GAUNTLET - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Uncompromising tight checking and physical accountability.

SETUP: 60x60m grid, 10v10 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Strict man-on-man matchups. The attacking team maintains possession. Defenders must stay within 1 meter of their direct opponent. If an attacker receives the ball unmarked, the defense is heavily penalized.

COACHING POINTS: Use legal physical contact to stay tight, watch the opponent's hips to anticipate cuts, never ball-watch.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach yells switch, forcing all defenders to instantly locate and cover a new opponent.

DRILL 39: THE BOUNDARY TRAP SYSTEM - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Using the boundary line as a structural weapon to trap the opposition.

SETUP: Defensive pocket extending to the wing, 4 attackers, 5 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to run the ball out of the pocket. Defenders angle their approach to corral the attackers toward the boundary line, closing all inboard passing lanes and forcing a stoppage or turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Angle your body to deny the inside lane, tackle aggressively when space runs out, use the line as an extra defender.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Increase the space to the half-back flank to make the trapping more challenging.

DRILL 40: GOAL SQUARE DESPERATION SCRAMBLE - TEAM DEFENSE, PRESSURING & INTERCEPT GRIDS

OBJECTIVE: Elite desperation defending in the goal square to prevent a score.

SETUP: Defensive goal square, 5 forwards, 5 defenders, 1 coach.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach bombs the ball high into the goal square. Defenders must violently spoil the ball away from danger, follow up at ground level, and rush the ball behind for a minor score if necessary.

COACHING POINTS: Spoil with a closed fist to the boundary, never punch back into the corridor, put your body on the line.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach rolls the ball hard along the ground to simulate a snapped shot on goal through traffic.

DRILL 41: SENIOR 6-6-6 RESET AND EXECUTE - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Flawless structural setups and instant transitions under match fatigue.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Standard center bounce into 1 minute of live play. The coach blows the whistle, and all players have exactly 15 seconds to sprint back to their starting 6-6-6 positions.

COACHING POINTS: Demand extreme physical effort, maintain structural integrity when exhausted, communicate positioning loudly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Reduce the reset time to 12 seconds to drastically increase the cardiovascular pressure.

DRILL 42: RED TIME LEAD PROTECTION - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Elite game management and structural discipline in the final minutes.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Team A leads by 4 points with 2 minutes left. Team A must employ a slow, possession-retaining style, forcing stoppages and kicking down the line. Team B must take extreme risks through the corridor to score.

COACHING POINTS: Team A must kill the clock, keep numbers behind the ball, no risky inboard kicks. Team B must play on at all costs, lower the eyes inside 50.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Change the scenario so Team A is trailing by 2 points, forcing them into emergency attacking mode.

DRILL 43: COAST-TO-COAST COUNTER STRIKE - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Seamless, high-speed transition from deep defense to a shot on goal.

SETUP: Full ground, 12 attackers, 8 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers start with a kick-in from full back. They must move the ball the entire length of the field and score a goal within 20 seconds, utilizing their numerical advantage and overlap run.

COACHING POINTS: Relentless forward running, hit targets perfectly on the chest, do not slow down to wait for leads.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Decrease the time limit to 15 seconds to force a highly direct, corridor-centric attack.

DRILL 44: POSSESSION DOMINANCE STRUCTURE - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Controlling the tempo of the game and resting with the ball.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: One team is instructed to maintain possession for 3 full minutes without scoring or turning the ball over. They must use lateral and backward kicks, switching the play to exhaust the opposition.

COACHING POINTS: Absolute patience, hit uncontested targets only, present wide options constantly, never kick to a contest.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: If the possessing team kicks the ball forward of the center circle, they lose possession instantly.

DRILL 45: RED ZONE SCORING EFFICIENCY - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Maximizing scoring opportunities under severe numerical and physical pressure.

SETUP: Forward 50m arc, 8 forwards, 11 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball is continuously fed into the forward 50. Forwards operate at a severe numerical disadvantage and must use intelligent blocks, screens, and elite groundball skills to manufacture shots on goal.

COACHING POINTS: Work selflessly for your teammates, block for the primary forward, snap rapidly from stoppages.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every shot on goal must be taken from within 35 meters to force elite passing inside the arc.

DRILL 46: OUTNUMBERED DEFENSIVE DELAY - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Defending structurally when caught completely out of position.

SETUP: Defensive half, 6 defenders, 10 attackers.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers stream forward from a center bounce. The 6 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack, forcing wide kicks and delaying the entry until midfielders can drop back to help.

COACHING POINTS: Do not commit to a tackle unless certain to stick it, guard the most dangerous corridor space, force them wide.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add 3 trailing defenders who enter the drill 6 seconds after it begins.

DRILL 47: RELENTLESS ATTACKING WAVES - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Overwhelming the opposition defense with numbers and speed.

SETUP: Full ground, 16 attackers, 12 defenders.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers work the ball forward. They must ensure that at every single contest or mark, they have at least two loose players running past to receive a handball.

COACHING POINTS: Elite work rate, loose players must demand the ball aggressively, overwhelm the defense with overlap momentum.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the attackers to score a goal without taking a single bounce during the transition.

DRILL 48: KICK-IN SUFFOCATION TRAP - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Executing a full-ground press to force a turnover directly from an opposition kick-in.

SETUP: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Opposition takes a kick-in. The defending team implements a strict web zone, manning up the boundary options and clogging the corridor, aiming to force a panic kick and generate a turnover.

COACHING POINTS: Hold your zone flawlessly, anticipate the kicker's eyes, squeeze the ground to suffocate all exit options.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The attacking team is restricted to using kicks only to exit the defensive 50.

DRILL 49: KICK-IN SURGICAL REBOUND - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Breaking through a high defensive press cleanly and safely.

SETUP: Defensive 50, 18v18 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Your team takes a kick-in against a set zone. Players must execute synchronized decoy leads to clear space, utilize short pocket options, and rapidly switch the play to pierce the first line of the press.

COACHING POINTS: The kicker must be instantly decisive, receivers lead with intent, look to play on immediately from the first mark.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The player taking the kick-in has only 6 seconds to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 50: FULL MATCH SIMULATION - MATCH SIMULATIONS & PHASE PLAY

OBJECTIVE: Consolidating all elite tactical and structural concepts in a live match environment in preparation for senior football.

SETUP: Full ground, 36 players, full umpire crew.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: A relentless 20-minute block of unrestricted match play. The coach monitors from the boundary, stopping play only for critical structural errors or to reset specific tactical scenarios. The standard demanded must be absolute elite.

COACHING POINTS: Demand absolute elite standards, enforce team rules violently, praise correct autonomous decision-making, highlight off-the-ball running.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Implement a severe rule where any defensive half turnover immediately results in a 50-meter penalty against the offending team to simulate the ultimate pressure on ball movement.

OVER 35's MENS (Veterans)

Over 35s (Veterans) Coaching Best Practices

Coaching Veterans football requires an entirely different playbook. The men running out for their local club on a weekend have decades of football IQ, but they are also dealing with aging bodies, Monday morning trade jobs, and varying levels of cardiovascular fitness. You are no longer coaching raw development; you are managing load, leveraging immense game sense, and structuring a system that maximizes efficiency while minimizing soft-tissue injuries.

When you get the structure right, the veterans grade becomes a masterclass in smart, economical football, ending with the boys linking arms in the sheds to sing the song and stick it up their arse.

Preservation and Warm-Up Mechanics

Hamstrings and calves are the primary opponents in Over 35s football. You cannot throw veterans into explosive reaction sprints or heavy tackling drills cold. The warm-up must be a

gradual, sustained build-up over 15 to 20 minutes, prioritizing dynamic mobility, hip-openers, and low-intensity ball circulation. You must build heat in the muscles slowly before any high-velocity kicking or sudden changes of direction occur.

Football IQ Over Raw Speed

What your players lack in top-end pace, they make up for in anticipation. The game plan must reflect this. Forget overlap running waves that span 80 meters; instead, focus on 15-meter to 20-meter precision link-up kicks. Teach the squad to lower their eyes and honor the short lead. Defensively, emphasize spatial zoning rather than strict man-on-man accountability, which exhausts older players quickly. Structuring a smart defensive web allows the team to intercept through positioning rather than relying on desperate run-down tackles.

Roster and Rotation Management

In Over 35s, the interchange bench is your most critical tactical weapon. Managing the rotations seamlessly keeps the squad fresh for the final quarter when opposition teams typically fall apart structurally. Utilizing an interactive, mobile-responsive HTML match-day selection webpage on the sidelines is an elite way to manage these rotations digitally, ensuring nobody is left cooking out on the ground for too long and that your structured board layout is always up to date.

THE 50-DRILL LIBRARY

DRILL 1: THE VETERANS BUILD-UP - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Slowly raising core temperature while executing low-risk ball handling.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 12 players, 3 footballs.

Progression/Description: Players jog at 40 percent pace inside the grid, exchanging handballs over short distances. Every 2 minutes, the coach dictates a light dynamic stretch to perform while moving (e.g., high knees, open the gate) before resuming ball circulation.

Coaching Points: Keep the pace strictly controlled, vocalize early, focus on clean hands rather than speed.

Progression/Regression: Gradually increase the running pace to 60 percent after 10 minutes.

DRILL 2: SHORT KICK LOCOMOTION - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Grooving the kicking action without straining cold leg muscles.

Setup: 15m distance, pairs, 1 football.

Progression/Description: Players jog on the spot. Player A executes a gentle 15m drop punt to Player B. Player B marks, takes two steps backward, and returns the kick.

Coaching Points: Do not kick at full power, focus purely on ball drop and timing, use the momentum of the body rather than snapping the leg.

Progression/Regression: Shift the distance to 20m and have players take two steps forward to meet the ball.

DRILL 3: THE 3-MAN WEAVE (JOGGING PACE) - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Forward movement and spatial awareness without maximum velocity.

Setup: 50m length of the ground, groups of 3.

Progression/Description: Players move down the ground executing a traditional 3-man handball weave. The absolute rule is that nobody is allowed to break out of a steady jog.

Coaching Points: Time the lead so you do not have to stop and wait, deliver the handball softly to the chest, communicate names loudly.

Progression/Regression: End the weave with a controlled 20m kick to a coach instead of a final handball.

DRILL 4: FIGURE 8 GROUNDBALLS - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Warming up the lower back and hamstrings for ground level work.

Setup: Two cones placed 10m apart, pairs, 1 football.

Progression/Description: Player A rolls the ball to Player B. Player B bends through the knees, collects the ball, handballs back, and jogs a figure 8 around the cones before receiving the next groundball.

Coaching Points: Do not bend straight-legged at the waist, bend the knees to protect the lower back, collect cleanly with two hands.

Progression/Regression: Roll the ball slightly to the left or right to force lateral knee bends.

DRILL 5: PERIPHERAL VISION GRID - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Switching on the football brain and peripheral vision early in the session.

Setup: 15x15m grid, 8 players, 2 footballs.

Progression/Description: Players handball the balls randomly inside the grid. Before disposing, the player with the ball must verbally call out the name of someone standing on the opposite side of the grid.

Coaching Points: Keep your head on a swivel, do not lock eyes purely on the football, maintain a light jog.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a third football to increase the cognitive traffic.

DRILL 6: THE STATIC MARKING WRESTLE - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Engaging the upper body and core without high-impact running collisions.

Setup: 5x5m grid, pairs, 1 coach with a ball.

Progression/Description: Pairs stand side-by-side in the grid. The coach lofts a ball into the air. Players use their core and upper body to jostle for front position and mark the ball. No running jumps allowed.

Coaching Points: Keep a wide base, use forearm pressure legally, protect the drop zone using body weight.

Progression/Regression: The coach calls out which player is the designated attacker and which is the defender before throwing the ball.

DRILL 7: LATERAL SHUFFLE AND GIVE - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Activating the groins and hip flexors safely.

Setup: 10m channel, pairs.

Progression/Description: Players face each other 5m apart. They perform a lateral defensive shuffle down the channel while exchanging rapid back-and-forth handballs.

Coaching Points: Stay low in the hips, do not cross the feet over, keep the hands up and ready.

Progression/Regression: Change direction every 5 meters to work both sides of the groin.

DRILL 8: AGILITY POLE WEAVE - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Low-impact change of direction.

Setup: 5 agility poles spaced 3m apart, single file line, 1 football per player.

Progression/Description: Players jog through the agility poles at 50 percent pace, bouncing the ball exactly once between each pole.

Coaching Points: Push off the outside foot, keep the ball controlled, do not accelerate into a sprint.

Progression/Regression: Remove the bounce and require the players to weave while keeping the ball tucked under alternating arms.

DRILL 9: THE RUCK TAP TIMING - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Practicing stoppage synergy without aggressive jumping.

Setup: Center circle, 1 ruck, 2 mids.

Progression/Description: Coach throws the ball up gently. Ruckman steps into the tap without jumping, focusing on palming the ball to the moving midfielder.

Coaching Points: Watch the ball all the way to the hand, midfielder must read the cue and time their jog to collect the ball smoothly.

Progression/Regression: The coach calls out a specific quadrant for the ruckman to direct the tap.

DRILL 10: END TO END POSSESSION - GRADUAL DYNAMIC WARM-UPS

Objective: Full team coordination and finalizing the warm-up transition.

Progression/Description: The ball starts in the goal square. The team must move the ball the entire length of the ground using kicks no longer than 20m. No opposition.

Progression/Description: The ball starts in the goal square. The team must move the ball the entire length of the ground using kicks no longer than 20m. No opposition.

Coaching Points: Focus on perfect disposal mechanics, present into space, shake out any final stiffness.

Progression/Regression: Introduce a 3-second disposal limit to increase the tempo slightly.

DRILL 11: THE 20-METER LINK MAN - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Using short, high-percentage kicks to move the ball economically.

Setup: 60m channel, 6 players.

Progression/Description: The ball starts at one end. Players make staggered, short leads. The ball is moved entirely via 15m to 20m kicks. Players must hold their space and not crowd the ball carrier.

Coaching Points: Honor the short lead immediately, drop the ball perfectly onto the boot, receivers must call early.

Progression/Regression: Add token pressure on the kicker to force them to execute the short kick quickly.

DRILL 12: CORRIDOR FUNNEL KICKING - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Programming the instinct to look inboard rather than dumping it down the line.

Setup: Half ground, cones marking a 20m wide corridor funnel.

Progression/Description: Players start at half back and must transition the ball forward. They are only allowed to kick to targets within the designated corridor funnel. Kicking wide is a turnover.

Coaching Points: Midfielders must work smart to find pockets of space in the middle, kickers must trust their skills.

Progression/Regression: Narrow the funnel to 15m to demand even greater accuracy.

DRILL 13: SWITCHING TO THE FAT SIDE - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Making the ball do the work instead of the players.

Setup: Defensive 50, 8 attackers, 4 defenders.

Progression/Description: Play starts deep in a pocket. The team must use two rapid 25m lateral kicks across the defensive arc to switch the play to the completely open opposite flank.

Coaching Points: Kicks must be flat and hard, receivers must anticipate the switch and start drifting laterally before the mark is taken.

Progression/Regression: Impose an 8-second time limit to complete the switch.

DRILL 14: LOWER THE EYES FORWARD ENTRY - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Hitting the high-percentage target inside 50 instead of kicking to a congested pack.

Setup: Center square to forward 50, 4 midfielders, 4 forwards, 3 defenders.

Progression/Description: Midfielders transition the ball forward. Forwards lead. The midfielder must ignore the deep option and hit a forward leading up to the 35m or 40m mark.

Coaching Points: Steady yourself before kicking, forwards must separate from their defender using smart body work, prioritize the chest mark.

Progression/Regression: The defenders are instructed to drop back and heavily clog the goal square.

DRILL 15: THE TRIANGLE OUTLET - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Always providing the ball carrier with a safe sideways or backward option.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 3 attackers, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Attackers maintain possession. They must physically form a triangle around the defender, ensuring the ball carrier never has to kick directly over the pressure.

Coaching Points: Do not stand still, move to recreate the triangle the moment the ball is disposed of, talk constantly.

Progression/Regression: Make the grid smaller to force quicker decision making.

DRILL 16: BOUNDARY LINE ESCAPE - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Navigating out of a tight spot using control and short targets.

Setup: 30m boundary strip, 4 attackers, 3 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers are trapped on the boundary. They must use controlled 10m handballs and 15m kicks to work the ball up the line safely without rushing a blind kick out of bounds.

Coaching Points: Protect the ball on the boundary side, be patient, wait for the safe option to open up.

Progression/Regression: Add a 4th defender to create a high-pressure, even-numbers scenario.

DRILL 7: THE KICK-IN PLAY - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Rehearsing a low-energy, high-efficiency exit from deep defense.

Setup: Defensive 50, 7 players.

Progression/Description: Fullback takes the kick-in. The team executes a pre-planned structured exit, using a short kick to the pocket followed immediately by a switch to the top of the 50m arc.

Coaching Points: Disguise your leads, the kicker must not hesitate, move the ball before the opposition zone can reset.

Progression/Regression: Bring in 5 passive opposition players to stand in the passing lanes.

DRILL 18: DIAGONAL SLICE KICKING - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Breaking lines without requiring players to sprint straight down the ground.

Setup: 60m length, 4 zones marked out.

Progression/Description: Players must move the ball from zone 1 to zone 4. Direct vertical kicks are banned. Every disposal must be an angled diagonal pass to a player in the next zone.

Coaching Points: Open the shoulders early, receivers lead into the diagonal space at a controlled pace.

Progression/Regression: Place a static defender on the boundary line to force the players to kick back toward the corridor.

DRILL 19: HALF-BACK OVERLAP (JOGGING) - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Teaching the timing of the overlap without exhausting the players.

Setup: Defensive 50 to center wing, groups of 4.

Progression/Description: Players move the ball out of defense. The focus is entirely on the timing. The ball carrier jogs, draws a passive defender, and handballs to the outside runner at the exact right moment.

Coaching Points: Do not release the ball too early, draw the man, the receiver must command the ball.

Progression/Regression: Ensure the final disposal is a well-weighted kick to a forward target.

DRILL 20: RETAINING POSSESSION - FOOTBALL IQ & LINK-UP KICKING

Objective: Resting with the football in hand rather than defending.

Setup: Full half ground, 12v12.

Progression/Description: One team is instructed to maintain possession for 2 full minutes. They are encouraged to kick backward and laterally, conserving energy while forcing the opposition to chase.

Coaching Points: Absolute patience, hit uncontested targets only, never kick to a 50/50 contest.

Progression/Regression: If the possessing team kicks to a contest and the ball hits the ground, it is an automatic turnover.

DRILL 21: SMART STOPPAGE SETUP - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Organizing defensively to prevent easy clearances.

Setup: Center bounce setup, 4v4 in the middle.

Progression/Description: Focus on positioning rather than jumping. The defensive side midfielder must anchor themselves on the goal-side of their opponent, ensuring they cannot be easily bypassed if the tap is lost.

Coaching Points: Establish body contact early, hold your ground, communicate who is sweeping behind.

Progression/Regression: Play out the clearance at 75 percent pace.

DRILL 22: THE HIP AND SHOULDER EXTRACTION - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Using veteran body strength to win the hard ball safely.

Setup: 10x10m grid, 2v2, 1 coach with a ball.

Progression/Description: Coach rolls the ball in. Players use legal, side-on hip and shoulder contact to bump their opponent off the line of the ball, securing it and handballing out.

Coaching Points: Get your hips lower than the opposition, stay side-on to protect your ribs, one clean scoop.

Progression/Regression: Widen the grid to 15x15m to require a short jog before the contest.

DRILL 23: BOUNDARY THROW-IN WALL - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Blocking the corridor at boundary stoppages.

Setup: Boundary line, 1 ruck, 3 mids per team.

Progression/Description: The defending team sets up a strict physical wall on the corridor side of the stoppage. They concede the boundary line tap but completely block any inboard clearance.

Coaching Points: Do not get sucked into the contest, hold the wall, tackle aggressively if they try to break through the middle.

Progression/Regression: The attacking team must try to break the wall within 5 seconds of the tap.

DRILL 24: THE STANDING TACKLE - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Pinning the arms safely without going to ground.

Setup: 10x10m grid, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A has the ball. Player B engages in a firm wrap tackle, focusing on pinning the arms and holding Player A up rather than dragging them to the ground and risking injury.

Coaching Points: Get cheek-to-cheek, squeeze the arms tight, maintain your own balance.

Progression/Regression: Player A attempts to get their hands free to execute a handball while remaining standing.

DRILL 25: SHIELDING THE DROP ZONE - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Using body weight to protect space for a mark.

Setup: 15x15m grid, 1 attacker, 1 defender, 1 kicker.

Progression/Description: Kicker lofts the ball. The attacker uses their core and glutes to hold the front position, legally backing into the defender without pushing, taking the mark on the chest.

Coaching Points: Track the flight early, establish a wide stance, let the ball come down to you.

Progression/Regression: The defender is allowed to lean heavily onto the attacker's back.

DRILL 26: QUICK HANDS IN TRAFFIC - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Clearing the ball from a pack using fast hands rather than leg speed.

Setup: 10x10m grid, 4v4.

Progression/Description: The ball is placed in the middle. Players must extract the ball using rapid, 2-meter handballs to each other until they can successfully kick the ball out of the grid.

Coaching Points: Do not try to break tackles, give the first option, use your voice in the congestion.

Progression/Regression: Add a 5th defender to overload the pressure.

DRILL 27: RUCK ADVANTAGE ZONE - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Directing the tap to a safe, pre-determined area.

Setup: Center circle, 1 ruck, 2 mids.

Progression/Description: The ruckman dictates exactly where they will put the ball. The midfielders hold their space rather than running recklessly, letting the ruckman drop the ball directly into their hands.

Coaching Points: Elite communication between ruck and mids, watch the ruck's hand, secure the ball cleanly.

Progression/Regression: Add an opposition ruck to contest the tap physically.

DRILL 28: GROUNDBALL OUTNUMBER - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Exploiting numbers at the contest.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 4 attackers, 3 defenders.

Progression/Description: Coach rolls the ball in. The attackers must use their numerical advantage, having one player aggressively win the ball while the spare player holds off a step to receive the easy extraction handball.

Coaching Points: The spare man must not get sucked into the pack, talk to the ball winner, execute cleanly.

Progression/Regression: Start the players facing away from the ball to slow down their reaction time.

DRILL 29: FORWARD POCKET SNAP - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Generating a quick score from a stoppage inside 50.

Setup: Forward pocket boundary line, 4v4.

Progression/Description: Coach simulates a throw in. The attacking team aims to win the tap, execute one quick handball to a player facing goal, and snap immediately.

Coaching Points: Lock the ball in if the tap is lost, prioritize front position, the receiver must demand the ball.

Progression/Regression: Mandate that the snap must be taken within 4 seconds of the tap.

DRILL 30: ABSORB AND RELEASE - STOPPAGES & VETERANS CRAFT

Objective: Taking a bump while maintaining composure to dispose.

Setup: 15m channel, pairs.

Progression/Description: Player A jogs with the ball. Player B applies a controlled side bump. Player A must brace, hold their footing, and execute a 15m kick to a coach.

Coaching Points: Keep a wide base, tuck the ball away from the contact side, steady yourself before kicking.

Progression/Regression: Use a tackle bag for Player B to generate a heavier, blunt force.

DRILL 31: VETERANS ZONE DEFENSE - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Defending space to save the legs rather than chasing direct opponents.

Setup: Defensive half, 8 defenders, 8 attackers.

Progression/Description: Attackers move the ball forward. Defenders must set up a structural zone, passing attackers off to each other as they enter different areas of the ground, conserving energy by not running 60m to chase one man.

Coaching Points: Point and talk, communicate the handover loudly, maintain the structural wall.

Progression/Regression: Give the attackers an extra player to test the integrity of the zone.

DRILL 32: FORWARD HALF LOCKDOWN - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Trapping the ball in the forward line to avoid transitioning back to defense.

Setup: Forward 50 arc, 8 forwards, 6 defenders.

Progression/Description: Defenders try to clear the ball. The forwards push up and form a physical wall across the 40m line, manning the mark aggressively and blocking all short exit options.

Coaching Points: Hold the line, tackle with intent, bring the ball to ground if you cannot mark it.

Progression/Regression: Defenders have 12 seconds to cross the 50m arc.

DRILL 33: INTERCEPT POSITIONING - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Reading the kicker rather than wrestling an opponent.

Setup: Half-back flank, 1 defender, 2 attackers, 1 kicker.

Progression/Description: Kicker looks to pass. The defender must read the kicker's eyes, peel off their opponent entirely, and step into the passing lane to take an uncontested intercept mark.

Coaching Points: Back your judgment, watch the kicker's body language, do not hesitate once you move.

Progression/Regression: The kicker purposely kicks a low, flat ball to compress the reaction time.

DRILL 34: CORRAL AND DELAY - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Slowing down the play when outnumbered instead of diving in.

Setup: 20x20m grid, 2 attackers, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Attackers run the ball. The defender must backpedal, stay low, and corral the ball carrier toward the boundary to delay them, rather than committing to a tackle they might miss.

Coaching Points: Do not cross your feet, force them onto their non-preferred side, buy time for teammates.

Progression/Regression: Defender must survive for 6 seconds before a teammate is allowed to join the grid.

DRILL 35: THE SLIDING WEB - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Working laterally as a defensive unit.

Setup: 40x40m grid, 4 quadrants, 4 defenders, 4 attackers.

Progression/Description: Attackers move the ball. When a defender leaves their quadrant to pressure the ball carrier, the adjacent defender must slide over to cover the dangerous space left behind.

Coaching Points: Talk early, point to the space you are covering, head on a swivel.

Progression/Regression: Add a 5th attacker to force constant sliding adjustments.

DRILL 36: BOUNDARY TRAPPING - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Using the boundary line as an extra defender.

Setup: Wing boundary line, 3 attackers, 3 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers run down the wing. Defenders must angle their approach to cut off inboard passes, physically forcing the attackers toward the boundary line for a stoppage.

Coaching Points: Angle your body to deny the corridor, shepherd them toward the line, lock the ball up.

Progression/Regression: Widen the playing area to give the attackers more room to escape.

DRILL 37: THE SMOTHER - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Elite pressure without running 50 meters.

Setup: 15m distance, 1 kicker, 1 defender.

Progression/Description: Kicker receives a handball and takes two steps. The defender steps forward aggressively, throwing their hands out to smother the kick off the boot.

Coaching Points: Throw hands straight out, turn the face away, commit to the block.

Progression/Regression: The kicker is instructed to fake the kick and step inside.

DRILL 38: DEEP SCRAMBLE - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Desperate, safe defending in the goal square.

Setup: Defensive goal square, 4 forwards, 4 defenders, 1 coach.

Progression/Description: Coach bombs the ball high. Defenders must safely spoil the ball away to the boundary line, avoiding heavy mid-air collisions while ensuring the ball is cleared.

Coaching Points: Spoil with a closed fist, punch wide, communicate clearly who is going for the ball.

Progression/Regression: Coach rolls the ball hard along the ground instead.

DRILL 39: PROTECTING THE FAT SIDE - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Defending the dangerous switch kick.

Setup: Defensive 50, full width, 6v6.

Progression/Description: Attackers try to switch the ball across the ground. The wingman on the weak side must recognize the danger early and drop back 20m into the space to cut off the switch kick.

Coaching Points: Scan the whole field, read the play early, drop into the hole before the ball is kicked.

Progression/Regression: The attackers are given a 6-second window to execute the switch.

DRILL 40: KICK-IN LOCKDOWN - TEAM DEFENSE & ENERGY CONSERVATION

Objective: Suffocating the opposition's exit from deep defense.

Setup: Forward 50, full team setup.

Progression/Description: Opposition takes a kick-in. The team sets a rigid 15-meter zone outside the 50m arc, completely ignoring direct opponents and guarding the dangerous space to force a long bomb.

Coaching Points: Hold the line, do not get sucked into the pocket, squeeze the ground.

Progression/Regression: Restrict the opposition to using kicks only to exit the 50.

DRILL 41: 6-V-6 HALF GROUND SCRIMMAGE - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Controlled match play focusing on structure over speed.

Setup: Half ground, 12 players.

Progression/Description: Standard match play restricted to one half of the ground. Focus is on utilizing the 20-meter link-up kicks and smart positioning to transition the ball.

Coaching Points: Conserve energy through smart passing, lower the eyes, talk constantly.

Progression/Regression: Implement a rule where players can only take a maximum of one bounce.

DRILL 42: THE RED TIME POSSESSION GAME - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Closing out a game when legs are heavy.

Setup: Full ground, 18v18 scrimmage.

Progression/Description: The scoreboard says the team is up by 4 points with 3 minutes left. The objective is purely to maintain possession, kick down the line to contests, and waste time safely.

Coaching Points: No risky kicks inboard, numbers behind the ball, kill the clock.

Progression/Regression: Change the scenario so the team is down by 2 points and must generate a score safely.

DRILL 43: KICK-IN REBOUND EFFICIENCY - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Exiting defense with minimal physical output.

Setup: Defensive 50, full team setup.

Progression/Description: Fullback takes a kick in against a set zone. Players must execute synchronized decoy leads to clear space, utilize short pocket options, and execute a lateral switch.

Coaching Points: Kicker must be decisive, receivers lead with intent, move the ball cleanly.

Progression/Regression: The kicker is given only 5 seconds to dispose of the ball.

DRILL 44: OUTNUMBERED DELAY TACTICS - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Defending smartly when caught on the counter attack.

Setup: Defensive half, 5 defenders, 7 attackers.

Progression/Description: Attackers push forward. The 5 defenders must organize a desperate zone to slow the attack, forcing the ball wide and delaying the entry until theoretical help arrives.

Coaching Points: Do not commit to a tackle you might miss, guard the corridor, force them wide.

Progression/Regression: Add two trailing defenders who enter the drill 8 seconds later.

DRILL 45: RED ZONE EFFICIENCY - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Capitalizing on forward entries without wasting energy.

Setup: Forward 50m arc, 6 forwards, 6 defenders.

Progression/Description: The ball is fed inside 50. Forwards must use smart leads, physical screening, and quick snaps to generate a score quickly rather than engaging in drawn-out wrestling matches.

Coaching Points: Block for your teammates, front and center at every drop, snap rapidly.

Progression/Regression: Mandate that every shot on goal must occur within 30 meters.

DRILL 46: THE SLOW PLAY TRANSITION - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Moving the ball end to end methodically.

Setup: Full ground, 18v18 setup.

Progression/Description: One team is instructed to move the ball from full back to full forward taking exactly 2 minutes on the clock, using absolute patience and short kicks.

Coaching Points: Hit uncontested targets only, present wide options, wait for the defense to make a mistake.

Progression/Regression: If the team kicks to a 50/50 contest, they lose possession instantly.

DRILL 47: OVERLOAD GROUND BALL SCENARIO - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Ensuring the team always has an extra number at the contest.

Setup: Full ground, 16 attackers, 12 defenders.

Progression/Description: Attackers work the ball forward. They must ensure that at every contest, they have a loose player floating on the outside to receive the easy handball extraction.

Coaching Points: Communicate the loose man, ball winner must find them quickly, economical ball movement.

Progression/Regression: Attackers must score without taking a single bounce.

DRILL 48: THE FATIGUE RESET - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Maintaining structural discipline when exhausted.

Setup: Full ground, full squad.

Progression/Description: Players engage in 2 minutes of scrimmage. On the whistle, play stops, and all players have 20 seconds to jog back to their correct 6-6-6 starting positions for a center bounce.

Coaching Points: Communicate positioning as you move, maintain discipline, catch your breath structurally.

Progression/Regression: Reduce the reset time to 15 seconds.

DRILL 49: ROTATION MANAGEMENT SCENARIO - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Practicing bench rotations during live play.

Setup: Full ground scrimmage, 22 players per team (4 on bench).

Progression/Description: Standard match simulation. The coach actively manages the rotations dynamically, pulling players off every 5 minutes to replicate the high-rotation necessity of Veterans football.

Coaching Points: Players coming on must instantly know their role and opponent, players coming off must jog directly to the bench.

Progression/Regression: The coach forces an unexpected triple-change rotation mid-play.

DRILL 50: VETERANS FULL MATCH SIMULATION - MATCH SIMULATIONS

Objective: Consolidating all tactical concepts into a competitive but controlled environment.

Setup: Full ground, 36 players, full umpire crew.

Progression/Description: A 15-minute block of match play. The focus is entirely on smart, economical ball movement, 20-meter link-up kicks, structural zone defense, and getting through the quarter unscathed.

Coaching Points: Enforce team rules, praise smart positioning over raw effort, prioritize safe contact.

Progression/Regression: Implement a rule where any defensive half turnover immediately results in a 25-meter penalty to enforce safe ball movement.

UNDER 8's

Under 8s Coaching Best Practices

Coaching the Under 8s age group is arguably the most important role at the football club. You are the gateway to the sport. These kids are transitioning from Auskick clinics into their very first structured team environment. Your objective is not to create tactical masterminds; it is to foster an absolute love for the game, develop fundamental motor skills, and ensure every player gets maximum touches of the football.

The 10-Second Attention Span and Maximum Touches

Kids at this age have incredibly short attention spans. If you are talking for more than 10 to 15 seconds, you have lost them. Eradicate long lines completely. If a drill requires kids to stand in a line of ten waiting for one kick, it is a bad drill. Break the squad into small groups. Utilize

parents as helpers to manage multiple small stations. The goal is continuous movement and high-volume touches of the football.

Gamification and Disguised Learning

Under 8s do not want to do "skill drills"—they want to play games. You must disguise the fundamental skill learning within fun, imaginative scenarios. Evasion is taught through playing "Tails" or "Cops and Robbers." Groundball gathering is taught through "Rob the Nest." When a drill has a story or a fun competitive element, their engagement and effort levels double instantly.

Combatting the "Seagull Swarm"

The most common feature of Under 8s football is all 36 kids on the field within two meters of the ball. You must actively coach spatial awareness. Use visual markers like cones and zones to teach them about holding space. Introduce the concept of "staying wide" and "finding your own island." Reward the players who stay on the outside waiting for the handball just as much as the player who wins the groundball.

Safe Contact and the "Hug Tackle"

Under 8s rules are heavily modified to protect the kids and build confidence. Traditional tackling is strictly prohibited. You must teach the modified "hug tackle"—wrapping the arms around the waist to pin the opponent without taking them to the ground. Teach them how to protect the ball when grabbed and how to safely navigate traffic without launching themselves recklessly into packs.

THE 50-DRILL LIBRARY

DRILL 1: TAILS AND EVASION - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Basic dodging, evasion, and spatial awareness.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, entire squad. Each player tucks a training bib (tail) into the back of their shorts.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: On the whistle, players run around the grid attempting to steal as many tails from other players as possible while protecting their own. If a player loses their tail, they keep playing to steal others.

COACHING POINTS: Keep your head up to avoid collisions, use quick lateral steps to dodge, do not grab jerseys.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Give the coach a tail worth 10 points and have the whole team try to catch the coach.

DRILL 2: ROB THE NEST - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: High-speed groundball gathering and running.

SETUP: 4 hoops (bases) in the corners of a 20x20m grid, 1 hoop in the center filled with 15 footballs. 4 teams.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: On the whistle, one player from each team sprints to the middle nest, scoops a ball, and runs it back to their base. The next player goes. Once the middle is empty, teams can steal from other bases.

COACHING POINTS: Bend at the knees to scoop the ball safely, use two hands, sprint all the way through the base.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require players to bounce the ball once on the way back to their base.

DRILL 3: STUCK IN THE MUD - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Fun warm-up focusing on agility and teamwork.

SETUP: 20x20m grid. 2 players designated as taggers (mud monsters).

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Taggers chase the runners. If tagged, a runner is stuck in the mud and must stand still with their legs wide apart. They are freed if another runner crawls through their legs.

COACHING POINTS: Look for teammates who need help, use side-steps to trick the taggers, keep the feet moving.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add more taggers if the runners are escaping too easily.

DRILL 4: SIMON SAYS FOOTY - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Listening skills and basic ball familiarization.

SETUP: Players spread out, each with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach plays Simon Says using footy actions. Simon says put the ball on your head, Simon says squeeze the ball tight, Simon says practice a ball drop, Simon says sit on the ball.

COACHING POINTS: Listen carefully to the instructions, react quickly, keep control of your football.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Speed up the commands to test reaction times.

DRILL 5: ANIMAL WALKS - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Developing fundamental motor skills, balance, and core strength.

SETUP: 15m channel, players in lines of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players move down the channel imitating different animals called by the coach: bear crawl, frog jump, kangaroo hop, crab walk.

COACHING POINTS: Have fun with it, focus on balance, use both arms and legs to coordinate movement.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Have players hold a football while performing the animal walks.

DRILL 6: SHARKS AND MINNOWS - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Running with the ball and avoiding defenders.

SETUP: 20x20m grid. 2 taggers (sharks) in the middle. Rest of the team (minnows) on one end line, all with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Minnows must run from one end of the grid to the other without getting tagged by the sharks. If tagged, they become a shark in the middle for the next run.

COACHING POINTS: Keep the ball tucked securely under one arm, look for the gaps between the sharks, run at top speed.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Require the minnows to complete one bounce before crossing to safety.

DRILL 7: TRAFFIC LIGHTS - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Stop/start acceleration and ball control.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, every player with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players jog around randomly. Coach yells green (run fast), yellow (slow jog or walk), red (stop immediately and stand on one leg holding the ball).

COACHING POINTS: React instantly to the call, keep your head up to avoid bumping friends, balance steadily on the red light.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a roundabout call where players must run in a tight circle before continuing.

DRILL 8: FOLLOW THE LEADER - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Agility and mirroring movements.

SETUP: Pairs, spread around the ground.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A is the leader, Player B follows exactly 2 meters behind. Player A jogs, dodges, jumps, and changes direction. Player B must mimic every move perfectly.

COACHING POINTS: Leaders need to be creative, followers must keep their eyes locked on the leader, stay light on the feet.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Swap roles every 45 seconds.

DRILL 9: CONE FLIPPERS - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: High-energy warm-up requiring squatting and bending.

SETUP: 20x20m grid, 40 cones scattered around. Half placed right-side up, half upside down. Two teams.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Team A must flip all cones right-side up. Team B must flip all cones upside down. Run the drill for 60 seconds and see which team has the most cones their way.

COACHING POINTS: Bend at the knees to flip the cone, do not just bend your back, work as fast as you can.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Run the drill again but players must balance a football under one arm while flipping cones.

DRILL 10: TAG THE COACH - FUN WARM-UPS & FUNDAMENTAL MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVE: Pure enjoyment, chaos management, and sprinting.

SETUP: Half ground, entire squad against 2 coaches.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coaches run away. The players must hunt them down and tag them. Once a coach is tagged 5 times, they must do 10 star jumps.

COACHING POINTS: Work together to trap the coaches on the boundary, run hard, watch out for your teammates.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Coaches are allowed to hold a bump pad to lightly bump the kids away.

DRILL 11: HOT POTATO CIRCLE - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Rapid hand-eye coordination and quick hands.

SETUP: Circles of 6 players, 1 football per circle.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players pass the ball around the circle as fast as possible. The football is a hot potato and will burn their hands if they hold it longer than one second.

COACHING POINTS: Catch with two hands, give it to the next person instantly, keep your eyes on the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Introduce a second football into the circle moving in the opposite direction.

DRILL 12: AROUND THE WORLD - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Getting comfortable manipulating the shape of the football.

SETUP: Players spread out, each with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players pass the football around their waist, transferring it from hand to hand. Then around their knees, then around their head.

COACHING POINTS: Do not drop the ball, feel the shape of the footy, use your fingertips to control it.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Have players race to see who can do 10 wraps around the waist the fastest.

DRILL 13: FIGURE 8 LEGS - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Hand dexterity and lower body flexibility.

SETUP: Players spread out, each with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players stand with legs wide apart. They must weave the football through their legs in a figure 8 motion, passing it from one hand to the other.

COACHING POINTS: Keep your head up slightly, bend your knees, control the transfer.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: See how many figure 8s they can complete in 30 seconds without dropping the ball.

DRILL 14: SKY BALL CATCHING - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Tracking the ball in the air and chest marking.

SETUP: Players spread out, each with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players throw the ball straight up in the air above their head. They must watch it drop and hug it tightly to their chest (chest mark).

COACHING POINTS: Make a basket with your arms, hug it tight to your tummy, keep your eyes open.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Clap once before catching the ball, then try two claps, then three.

DRILL 15: GROUNDBALL RELAY RACE - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Running to a stationary ball and scooping it efficiently.

SETUP: 15m distance, 4 teams lined up. 1 football per team placed 10m away.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: First player runs out, scoops the ball, runs around a cone, and runs back to hand it to the next player. The next player runs out, places the ball back on the ground, and runs back.

COACHING POINTS: Get both hands under the ball like a shovel, bend the knees, run fast.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach can slightly roll the ball away as the player approaches to make it a moving target.

DRILL 16: PARTNER ROLLER - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Fielding a moving groundball.

SETUP: Pairs facing each other 5m apart, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A rolls the ball firmly along the ground. Player B gets their body behind the ball, scoops it up cleanly, and rolls it back.

COACHING POINTS: Get low like a wicketkeeper, keep the legs together so the ball does not go through them, scoop with two hands.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Widen the distance to 10m and require a handball back instead of a roll.

DRILL 17: THE HANDPASS TUNNEL - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Introducing the handball punching motion.

SETUP: Pairs standing 3m apart, 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A holds the ball on a flat platform hand. They practice making a fist with the other hand and punching the ball gently over to Player B.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the ball still like a tray, tuck the thumb on the punching hand, hit the flat part of the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Aim the handball through a hula hoop held by a parent helper.

DRILL 18: REBOUNDER WALL - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Repeated quick handballs to build muscle memory.

SETUP: 2m away from a coach holding a bump pad (or a soft wall), individual players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player handpasses the ball directly into the coach's bump pad, fields the bouncing rebound, and instantly handpasses again.

COACHING POINTS: Quick reactions, punch through the ball, keep the feet moving.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach moves slightly left and right to force the player to shuffle their feet.

DRILL 19: BOUNCE AND CATCH TIMING - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Understanding how the oval ball bounces.

SETUP: Players spread out, each with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players walk forward in a straight line. Every three steps, they push the ball into the ground with two hands and catch it on the way back up.

COACHING POINTS: Push the ball slightly out in front, guide it down rather than throwing it, watch it back into the hands.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Try bouncing the ball with only one hand.

DRILL 20: CLEAN THE BACKYARD - BASIC BALL HANDLING & COORDINATION

OBJECTIVE: Chaotic fun while practicing disposal.

SETUP: 20x20m grid split perfectly in half by a line of cones. 2 teams. 10 footballs on each side.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The grid is the backyard. Teams must throw, roll, or handball the footballs over to the other team's side. After 60 seconds, the team with the fewest balls in their yard wins.

COACHING POINTS: Do not kick the ball to avoid getting hit in the face, work as fast as you can, pick up the balls safely.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Restrict the players to only using proper handballs to clear the yard.

DRILL 21: KICK TO THE COACH - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Basic execution of the drop punt without the pressure of a teammate dropping it.

SETUP: 15m distance, lines of 3 players, 1 coach per line.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player runs 3 steps and kicks the ball to the coach. The coach catches it, gives instant feedback, and rolls it back for the next player.

COACHING POINTS: Hold the ball over the kicking leg, point the toes at the coach, follow through straight.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Put a cone 5m in front of the player that the ball must fly over to ensure it is not a grubber.

DRILL 22: KNOCK DOWN THE TOWER - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Fun accuracy challenge.

SETUP: 10m distance. Build a tower out of 4 tackle bags or large cones. Lines of players with footballs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players take turns kicking the football at the tower, trying to knock it completely over.

COACHING POINTS: Line your body up with the tower, steady ball drop, kick straight through the middle.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Move the players back to 15m if the tower falls down too easily.

DRILL 23: PARTNER KICK AND TRAP - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Safely controlling a kicked ball that hits the ground.

SETUP: Pairs facing each other 15m apart. 1 ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A kicks to Player B. The kick will likely bounce. Player B must use their body to trap the ball, stop it from getting past them, pick it up, and kick it back.

COACHING POINTS: Do not be scared of the ball, get your body in front of it, use your hands and chest to trap it safely.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Encourage the players to try and catch the ball on the full if it is kicked well enough.

DRILL 24: GOAL KICKING RELAY - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: The joy of kicking a goal.

SETUP: 15m out from the goals. 2 teams lined up. 1 football per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: First player runs in, kicks a goal, retrieves their own ball, and runs it back to hand to the next player. First team to kick 5 goals wins.

COACHING POINTS: Take your time, run straight at the big sticks, follow through with the kicking leg.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Set up cones to create an angle to make the shot slightly more difficult.

DRILL 25: THROUGH THE GATES - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Accuracy kicking along the ground or low in the air.

SETUP: Pairs standing 15m apart. Set up a gate of two cones exactly halfway between them, 2m wide.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A must kick the ball so it travels perfectly through the middle of the cone gates to Player B.

COACHING POINTS: Guide the ball onto the boot smoothly, do not just smash it, point the toes at the target.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Make the gates narrower (1m wide) to increase the difficulty.

DRILL 26: THE LONGEST KICK - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Technique and power generation in a fun competition.

SETUP: All players lined up on the goal line facing out toward the center square.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: On the whistle, all players kick their football as hard and as far as they can out into the field. Coach measures the furthest kicks and praises good technique.

COACHING POINTS: Big step forward, swing the leg through fast, watch the ball all the way onto the foot.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Give the players a 5-meter run up to generate more momentum.

DRILL 27: KICK ON THE RUN - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Kicking without stopping to a stationary position.

SETUP: 20m channel, groups of 3, 1 coach as target.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player receives a handpass from a teammate, runs forward three steps at a steady jog, and kicks the ball to the coach without stopping their forward momentum.

COACHING POINTS: Do not stop and prop, keep jogging while you kick, drop the ball out in front of you.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Place a soft hurdle they must step over immediately before kicking to enforce the running motion.

DRILL 28: OPPOSITE FOOT TAPS - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Early familiarity with the non-preferred foot.

SETUP: Players spread out, each with a football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players hold the ball in their hands and gently tap it with their non-preferred foot, letting it pop back up into their hands. Just gentle taps, no full kicks.

COACHING POINTS: Just a little tap, do not kick it away, get used to balancing on the other leg.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Try alternating between the right foot and the left foot tap.

DRILL 29: TARGET HOOPS - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Learning to loft the ball into the air.

SETUP: Place 5 hula hoops on the ground 10m away from the kicking line.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players try to kick their football so it lands directly inside one of the hula hoops on the full.

COACHING POINTS: Lean back slightly, kick the bottom part of the football to make it fly high, soft foot.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Move the hoops to different distances (5m, 10m, 15m) for different point values.

DRILL 30: COACH'S MARK - KICKING FUNDAMENTALS & TARGET PRACTICE

OBJECTIVE: Kicking to a target that is moving.

SETUP: Coach jogs lightly across the front of the group, 15m away. Line of players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The player must wait for the coach to call their name, then kick the ball to where the coach is running, rather than where the coach is currently standing.

COACHING POINTS: Look at the target, kick it out in front of the coach so they do not have to stop running.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: The coach can jog faster or change direction slightly.

DRILL 31: THE BIG CIRCLE - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Visualizing how to spread out around a contest.

SETUP: 15m circle made of cones. 6 players. 1 ball in the middle.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: 2 players are inside the circle wrestling for the ball. The other 4 players must stand on the cones on the outside of the circle. When a player wins the ball, they handball to an outside player.

COACHING POINTS: Do not run into the middle, wait on your cone, call loudly for the handball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Rotate the inside and outside players every 30 seconds.

DRILL 4: FOUR CORNERS - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Breaking the swarm mentality by forcing players into zones.

SETUP: 20x20m grid split into 4 equal 10x10m squares. 2 teams of 4.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: One player from each team is assigned to a specific square. They are not allowed to leave their square. The ball is passed between squares.

COACHING POINTS: Stay in your home square, find space away from the defender, pass the ball quickly.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Allow players to move anywhere, but yell "Corners!" and they must instantly run to an empty corner.

DRILL 33: EVADE THE MONSTER - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Dodging a defender safely without fending off to the head or neck.

SETUP: 15m channel. 1 coach (monster) in the middle. 1 player with the ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The player must run from one end to the other past the coach. The coach moves slowly with arms out. The player must use a side-step or a safe, legal fend-off to the coach's chest/hip to get past.

COACHING POINTS: Run fast, step hard to one side, keep the ball tucked away from the monster.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a second monster to create a narrower pathway.

DRILL 34: MUSICAL FOOTBALLS - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Fun spatial awareness and quick reactions.

SETUP: 20x20m grid. 10 players, but only 8 footballs placed randomly on the ground.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Players jog around the grid. When the coach blows the whistle, every player must scramble to pick up a football. The two players who miss out do 5 star jumps, then return to the game.

COACHING POINTS: Keep your eyes open, look for the closest ball, do not push your friends.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Remove one football each round until only one ball is left for the final two players.

DRILL 35: PASS THE PARCEL - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Moving into empty space to receive a pass.

SETUP: 15x15m grid. 5 attackers, 1 coach as a defender.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers must pass the ball 5 times by hand without the coach intercepting it. The rule is you cannot pass to the person standing closest to you.

COACHING POINTS: Spread out, run away from the coach, put your hands up to show you want it.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 2nd coach to make passing much harder.

DRILL 36: SHADOW RUNNING - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Defensive corralling without tackling.

SETUP: 15m channel, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A runs down the channel with the ball. Player B must run backward in front of them, maintaining exactly a 1-meter gap without touching them.

COACHING POINTS: Stay low, watch their tummy not their feet, do not reach in and grab.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Allow Player A to zig-zag to force Player B to move laterally.

DRILL 37: FIND A SPACE - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Training the instinct to stop swarming the ball carrier.

SETUP: Half ground. Coach has the ball with all players swarming around.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The coach yells "Find a space!" and starts counting to three. All players must sprint away from the coach and find a spot where nobody else is standing.

Coach then kicks it to the player with the best space.

COACHING POINTS: Run away from the pack, spread out wide, wave your arms to show you are open.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Perform this drill randomly in the middle of other drills to test their awareness.

DRILL 38: THE DEFENDER'S HUG - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Teaching the modified Auskick wrap tackle safely.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, pairs.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Player A holds the ball and stands still. Player B approaches and executes a firm bear-hug around the waist, pinning the arms to the body for 3 seconds without pulling them to the ground.

COACHING POINTS: Hug the tummy, squeeze tight, do not grab the neck or shoulders, do not fall over.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Player A is allowed to walk slowly to make it a moving hug.

DRILL 39: KEEPINGS OFF (3V1) - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Simple possession and outnumbering the defender.

SETUP: 10x10m grid, 3 attackers, 1 defender.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Attackers try to handball to each other while the defender tries to intercept or apply the hug tackle.

COACHING POINTS: Form a triangle, always have two options for the ball carrier, move to the empty corner.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Make the grid smaller if the attackers are holding the ball too easily.

DRILL 40: GRID PASSING - EVASION, SPATIAL AWARENESS & ANTI-SWARM

OBJECTIVE: Forcing structural passing to eliminate the swarm.

SETUP: 3 adjacent 10x10m grids. 2 players in each grid. 1 football.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: The ball must travel from grid 1, to grid 2, to grid 3 via hand or foot. Players absolutely cannot leave their designated grid.

COACHING POINTS: Wait for the ball to come to your zone, lead to the front of your grid to receive it, pass quickly to the next zone.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add one defender into the middle grid to apply pressure on the transition.

DRILL 41: 3V3 MINI MATCH - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Small-sided game to maximize touches and involvement.

SETUP: 20x20m grid with two small pop-up goals. 3v3 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play a standard mini match. With only 3 players per team, there is nowhere to hide and everyone gets the ball. Coach acts as umpire and permanent quarterback.

COACHING POINTS: Spread out, look for your teammates, cheer for good tackles and goals.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Mandate that every player must touch the ball before a goal can be scored.

DRILL 42: FORWARD VS DEFENDER 1V1 - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Basic understanding of match-day roles.

SETUP: Forward 50 area. 1 forward, 1 defender, coach 20m out with the ball.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Forward tries to lead and mark the ball. Defender tries to spoil or hug-tackle. If the forward marks, they get a shot on goal. If the defender wins it, they kick it back to the coach.

COACHING POINTS: Forward must run away from the defender, defender must stand goal-side.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Make it 2v2 to introduce working together with a teammate.

DRILL 43: MULTI-BALL MAYHEM - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Chaotic fun, ensuring everyone is engaged and playing the ball.

SETUP: Half ground, full squad split into two teams.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws 3 footballs onto the ground at the exact same time. A match is played with all 3 balls simultaneously.

COACHING POINTS: Find a ball that isn't crowded, spread out, communicate with teammates.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Add a 4th ball if too many kids are swarming one specific football.

DRILL 44: CENTER BOUNCE WINNERS - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Attacking the ball aggressively at a stoppage.

SETUP: Center circle. 2 players from Team A, 2 players from Team B.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach bounces the ball hard into the turf. The 4 players must scramble to win the ball and execute one clean handball to the coach on the outside.

COACHING POINTS: Attack the football, get your body over it, do not just kick it off the ground.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Start the players lying on their backs before the ball is bounced.

DRILL 45: GOAL SQUARE SCRAMBLE - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Desperation and excitement near the goals.

SETUP: Goal square. 3 attackers, 3 defenders. Coach 15m out.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach kicks a grubber ball into the goal square. Attackers try to soccer or snap it through for a goal. Defenders try to clear it out past the 15m line.

COACHING POINTS: Attackers be hungry for the goal, defenders punch it wide, no dangerous sliding.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Coach lofts the ball high to force a marking contest instead of a groundball scramble.

DRILL 46: BOUNDARY THROW-IN TAP - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Simple understanding of out-of-bounds rules and ruck work.

SETUP: Boundary line. 1 ruck and 1 rover per team.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Coach throws the ball in. Rucks contest. Rovers try to win the ball and kick it forward into the field of play.

COACHING POINTS: Rucks try to hit it to your teammate, rovers wait for the tap, keep the ball in play.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Award 10 points for a clean clearance that results in a chest mark.

DRILL 47: THE 5-PASS CHALLENGE - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Encouraging teamwork rather than solo running.

SETUP: 30x30m grid, 6v6 setup.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Keepings off match. A team scores a point by successfully completing 5 passes (hand or foot) in a row without the opposition intercepting or tackling them.

COACHING POINTS: Help your teammates, spread into space, use loud voices.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Reduce the challenge to 3 passes if 5 is too difficult to achieve.

DRILL 48: POSITIONAL ZONES GAME - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Teaching kids to hold their positions on a full ground.

SETUP: Full ground divided into 3 zones (Forwards, Mids, Backs). 18 players.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Play a standard match, but players wear bibs specific to their zone. They are completely forbidden from crossing the cones into another zone. The ball must be passed between the zones.

COACHING POINTS: Forwards stay forward, defenders stay back, trust the mids to bring you the ball.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: After 5 minutes, blow the whistle and make everyone rotate zones.

DRILL 49: COACH'S WHISTLE FREEZE - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Game awareness and listening to the umpire.

SETUP: Full ground scrimmage.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: Normal match play. When the coach blows the whistle sharply, every single player must instantly freeze like a statue. The coach uses this 5-second freeze to praise good spacing or correct a swarm.

COACHING POINTS: Listen for the whistle, do not move a muscle, look at where you are standing.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Make the last person to freeze do 3 star jumps.

DRILL 50: THE GRAND FINAL - MODIFIED MATCH PLAY & FUN SCENARIOS

OBJECTIVE: Pure joy, excitement, and celebrating the effort.

SETUP: Full ground, full squad divided into two teams.

PROGRESSION/DESCRIPTION: A 10-minute full match simulation. Hype it up as the Grand Final. The coach provides loud, constant positive commentary. Celebrate every single touch, tackle, and goal like it won the game.

COACHING POINTS: Have fun, play fair, share the ball with friends who haven't touched it much.

PROGRESSION/REGRESSION: Let the kids link arms and sing the club song loudly in the middle of the ground after the siren.